

Prophetic Justice 101

*Mishpat, Tsedaqah, and What the Church Owes Its
Neighborhood*

JAMES BELL

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Unless otherwise noted, Scripture quotations are from the English Standard Version (ESV).

*But let justice roll down like waters, and righteousness
like an ever-flowing stream.*

AMOS, THE PROPHET, EIGHTH CENTURY BC

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INTRODUCTION

The Two Words We Lost

I CAME TO FAITH from atheism, and the first thing I noticed when I started reading the Bible as a grown man was how much of it I had been taught to ignore. I had assumed the Christians I knew were reading a book about getting to heaven. Instead I found a book that would not stop talking about the poor. It talked about wages held back overnight. It talked about widows and the courts that cheated them. It talked about boundary stones moved in the dark to steal a neighbor's field. It talked about a God who heard the cry of slaves and came down. None of this was in the brochure I had been handed at the door. The brochure was about my private soul and its private destination. The book was about the world and who had been crushed in it.

So I want to begin by naming the gap, because the gap is where this whole book lives. There is a distance between the Bible the prophets wrote and the Bible the modern church has agreed to read. We did not lose the text. We lost two words inside it. And losing those two words has cost us more than we know, because those two words carry the weight of who God is and what God demands, and without them we are left holding a gospel that fits comfortably in a private life and

never once threatens the arrangements of the public one. That is not the gospel of the prophets. That is a domesticated thing we made because the real one asked too much.

The two words are mishpat and tsedaqah. They run through the Hebrew Scriptures like two rivers, sometimes apart and often together, and where they meet they describe the kind of community God intends. Mishpat is usually translated justice. It means giving people what they are due, treating cases rightly, protecting those who cannot protect themselves, and it always has teeth, because in the Hebrew it is not an abstraction floating above the courtroom but the actual setting right of an actual wrong. Tsedaqah is usually translated righteousness, and the English ruins it instantly, because we hear righteousness and we think of a man's private moral record, his clean hands and his clean mouth, when the Hebrew means something closer to right relationship lived out in the open, a life so ordered toward others that the community is made whole by the way you hold your possessions and your power. Tim Keller used to point out that tsedaqah is a fundamentally social word. It is not about your inner ledger. It is about whether the people around you can flourish because of how you live.

*We did not lose the Bible. We lost two
words inside it, and with them the God
those words describe.*

HOLD THOSE TWO WORDS together and you get the biblical vision, and the vision is not what most of us were handed.

Mishpat is the rectifying justice that stops the predatory practice and punishes the cheat. Tsedaqah is the primary justice, the daily ordering of life so that the predatory practice never gets its grip in the first place. One stops the bleeding. The other refuses to let the wound open. And the prophets, when they wanted to describe a society that pleased God, did not describe a society of correct private beliefs. They described a society where mishpat and tsedaqah flowed like water through every transaction, every court, every field, every gate. Take those words out and you can have full churches and a rotten city, and the prophets would have called that exactly what it is.

I am writing this as a pastor, which means I am writing this from inside the failure. I have preached the privatized gospel. I have stood in a pulpit and talked about a man's heart while saying nothing about the wages he paid the people who cleaned his office. I have organized a food drive in December and called it our witness to the neighborhood while never once asking why the neighborhood was hungry in the first place, never asking who profited from the hunger, never asking whether my comfortable distance from the answer was itself a form of guilt. I am not standing outside this indictment. I helped build the thing I am indicting. When I say the church privatized righteousness and outsourced justice, I am describing my own ministry before I am describing anyone else's.

Here is what the privatizing did. It took tsedaqah, which the Bible means as a social and relational way of holding your life open to your neighbor, and it shrank it down to personal piety, so that a righteous man became a man who did not curse, did not drink, and read his Bible in the morning, while

the question of what his money did in the world went entirely unexamined. And it took mishpat, which the Bible means as the active setting right of public wrong, and it handed the whole category over to the government and the courts and the activists, as though justice were a political program that serious Christians could take or leave depending on their temperament. We split the two words from each other and then we hollowed out each half. The result is a church that is personally moral and publicly silent, and the prophets had a name for that too.

This book is an argument that biblical justice is not a political add-on to the gospel. It is not the liberal wing's hobby or the social-justice fad that the careful believer must guard against. It is the character of God, revealed from the Exodus forward, written into the law, sung in the Psalms, thundered by the prophets, and embodied by Jesus when he stood up in his hometown synagogue and read from Isaiah and announced that this is what he had come to do. You cannot remove justice from the Bible and have the Bible left. You can only have the brochure.

And I want to be honest about the danger from the other side, because this is not a book that will fit neatly into anyone's politics. There is a way of talking about justice that has cut itself loose from God entirely, that has made justice into an ideology, a weapon, a tribe, and that version is also under the prophets' judgment, because justice without the living God behind it becomes one more way for the strong to organize against their enemies while calling it righteousness. I am going to indict the church that privatized the gospel. I am also going to indict the movement that secularized justice until it became a religion of grievance with no mercy in it and no humility under God. The prophets struck in every

direction. So will this book. If you finish it comfortable, I will have failed.

What I am after is recovery. The recovery of the Exodus as the founding act of a justice-God who comes down to liberate slaves before he gives anyone a single commandment. The recovery of the gleaning laws, where God wrote poverty relief directly into the agricultural code and gave the poor a legal right to the corners of the field. The recovery of the Jubilee, the most radical economic idea in the ancient world, where every fifty years debts were cancelled and land returned and the slate was wiped so that no family could be permanently locked out of the means of life. The recovery of the Sabbath as resistance to an economy that wants to work you and your animals and your land to death. The recovery of the prophets' fury at worship that runs smoothly while the oppressed go unheard. The recovery of Jesus in Nazareth, unrolling the scroll and reading good news to the poor as his platform, his manifesto, the thing he came to do. That is the tradition I am trying to put back in your hands.

So consider this an invitation and a warning at the same time, which is how the prophets always spoke. The invitation is to read the Bible again as if the two words were still in it, because they are, and to let them do to your life and your church what they were always meant to do. The warning is that this will cost you, because justice always costs the people who benefited from its absence, and most of us reading this book have benefited from its absence more than we have ever admitted. I am not going to leave you comfortable. I am going to try to leave you with weight. The prophet Amos said let justice roll down like waters. He did not say let it trickle when convenient. He said roll down, like a river that takes out everything not anchored to something true. That is what I am

praying happens here. That is the only reason to write a book like this. Let it roll.

CHAPTER ONE

Mishpat and Tsedaqah, and Why English Flattens Them

EVERY TRANSLATION IS A small surrender, and the two words at the center of this book have surrendered more than most. When the Hebrew prophets wrote mishpat and tsedaqah, they were not reaching for vague spiritual ideals. They were naming concrete realities that a farmer and a judge and a widow all understood, realities you could see in a courtroom and a field and a marketplace, and when those words crossed into English they lost their edges, their teeth, their specific demand. We ended up with justice, which sounds like a courthouse statue, and righteousness, which sounds like a man being good in private. Both English words point away from the neighbor. Both Hebrew words point straight at him. That is the flattening, and we have to feel the full weight of it before anything else in this book will land.

Start with mishpat. The word appears more than four hundred times in the Hebrew Bible, and it carries a range that

English cannot hold in a single term. It means the rendering of a judgment, the verdict of a court. It means the rights that a person is owed, the legal claims that belong to them by virtue of being a member of the community. It means the ongoing practice of treating people equitably, week after week, case after case. When Scripture says God loves mishpat, it is not saying God enjoys an abstract principle. It is saying God is the kind of judge who does not take bribes, who does not favor the powerful, who hears the case of the orphan that no human court would bother to hear, and who acts. Mishpat is justice with a body. It does something. It changes the outcome for the person who was being crushed. And critically, in the Hebrew, mishpat is most often described in terms of its objects, and the objects are almost always the same four figures, repeated until you cannot miss them: the widow, the orphan, the immigrant, and the poor. These are the people who in the ancient world had no standing, no clan to defend them, no power to enforce their rights. Mishpat is what God demands precisely for the people the system was built to ignore.

Justice in Hebrew is not blind. It has its eyes wide open, and it is looking at the widow, the orphan, the stranger, and the poor.

THEN THERE IS TSEDAQAH, and here the flattening is even worse, because the English word righteousness has been hijacked by centuries of individualized piety until it now

means almost the opposite of what the Hebrew intended. We hear righteous and we picture a solitary saint, a person of clean private morals, the man who does not swear and does not cheat on his wife and pays his taxes. That is not wrong, exactly, but it is so partial that it becomes misleading. Tsedaqah in the Hebrew Bible is overwhelmingly relational and social. A tzaddik, a righteous person, is someone whose life is so rightly ordered toward the good of the community that the weak are stronger because that person exists among them. Tsedaqah is the kind of righteousness you can only have in relationship, because it is measured by what your existence does to the people around you. The Hebrew has no concept of a righteousness that benefits no one but yourself. To be righteous in the biblical sense is to live in such a way that justice is being done through your ordinary daily conduct, your business dealings, your generosity, your refusal to exploit an advantage you legally possess. Keller put it sharply once: tsedaqah is day-to-day living in which a person conducts all relationships in family and society with fairness, generosity, and equity. It is not a private virtue. It is a public one.

Now watch what happens when these two words appear together, because in Hebrew they very often do, paired as a hendiadys, two words working as one idea. Mishpat u-tsedaqah. Justice and righteousness. When the prophets put them side by side they are describing the entire moral fabric of a community that pleases God, and the pairing tells you something English cannot. Tsedaqah is the proactive, daily, generous, relationship-ordering righteousness that prevents injustice from taking root, and mishpat is the corrective, judicial, rectifying justice that intervenes when injustice has already done its damage. One is the ounce of prevention

woven into the texture of daily life. The other is the pound of cure applied at the gate where cases are heard. You need both. A society that only has mishpat without tsedaqah is constantly putting out fires it keeps starting. A society that imagines it has tsedaqah without mishpat is fooling itself, because a righteousness that never lifts a finger when the courts are corrupt is not righteousness at all. The prophets demanded the pair. We inherited neither word with its meaning intact.

I have watched the flattening do its quiet damage in real churches with real people, and I want to name it concretely because abstractions let us off the hook. I have known good men, generous men, men who would give you the coat off their back if you stood in front of them cold, who understood righteousness entirely as their private record before God and could not for the life of them see why the structures their generosity left untouched were any of their concern. They had tsedaqah cut in half. They had the personal warmth and not the social vision, and so their goodness, real as it was, terminated at the edge of the individual encounter and never reached the system that kept producing cold men with no coats. And I have known the opposite, people consumed with structural critique, fluent in the language of justice, who had no personal righteousness left in them at all, no mercy for the actual human being in front of them, no humility, only the cause. They had mishpat torn loose from tsedaqah and from God, and it had curdled into something hard. The Hebrew refuses both halves. It insists on the whole.

Here is why this matters for everything that follows. If you do not recover the meaning of these two words, you will read the rest of the Bible through the flattened English and you will keep producing the flattened church. You will read the

prophets and think they are being emotional or political. You will read the law and think the social legislation is quaint ancient housekeeping irrelevant to the gospel. You will read Jesus in Nazareth and spiritualize every word so that good news to the poor means good news to the spiritually poor and release to the captives means release from the captivity of sin and nothing, nothing, touches the ground where actual poor people stand and actual captives wait. The flattening is not a translation footnote. It is a theology. It is the theology that let the church keep its private piety and surrender the public square, and it did not happen by accident. Languages flatten in the direction their speakers want them to flatten. We flattened these words because the full meaning was inconvenient, because a God who demands mishpat and tsedaqah is a God who will not stay in the private compartment we built for him.

So this chapter is a request to relearn two words, and relearning a word is harder than learning one for the first time, because you have to unlearn the worn-down version first. When you read justice in your English Bible, train yourself to hear mishpat, with its widow and orphan and stranger and poor standing right there in the meaning, with its insistence that something actually change for them. When you read righteousness, train yourself to hear tsedaqah, that socially generous, relationship-ordering, community-healing way of living that has nothing to do with private religious bookkeeping and everything to do with whether your neighbor flourishes. Hold the two together the way the prophets held them, the prevention and the cure, the daily generosity and the corrective intervention. Do that, and the rest of the Bible begins to read like a single sustained argument, an argument I had completely missed when I first

picked it up as a skeptic, an argument the modern church has largely agreed to mute. The argument is that God is a God of justice and righteousness, that these are not optional themes but the very grain of his character, and that a people who claim him and ignore them have not understood the first thing about who they claim. The words are still in the book. We only have to read them again.

CHAPTER TWO

Do Justice, Love Mercy, Walk Humbly

THERE IS A SINGLE verse that the modern church loves to quote and rarely loves to obey, and it comes from the prophet Micah, working in the eighth century BC in the kingdom of Judah while the great powers gathered and the small farmers were being squeezed off their land. The verse is Micah 6:8, and it has become a kind of bumper sticker for a certain comfortable Christianity, printed on canvas wall art and stitched onto throw pillows. He has shown you, O man, what is good, and what does the Lord require of you, but to do justice, and to love mercy, and to walk humbly with your God. We have managed to make this verse cozy. We have made it sound like a gentle reminder to be a nice person. But in its setting it is nothing of the kind. It is the verdict at the end of a courtroom drama in which God himself is the plaintiff, and Judah is in the dock, and the charge is that they have built an elaborate religion of sacrifice while abandoning the only thing God actually wanted.

You have to read the whole sixth chapter of Micah to feel

the force of the famous verse, because the famous verse is an answer to a desperate question. The chapter opens with God filing a legal complaint against his people, calling the mountains and the hills as the jury, asking what he has done to deserve their abandonment. And the people answer, panicked, trying to figure out what will satisfy this God. They start bidding. Shall I come before him with burnt offerings, with calves a year old. Will the Lord be pleased with thousands of rams, with ten thousand rivers of oil. Shall I give my firstborn for my transgression. The bidding escalates to the unthinkable, to child sacrifice, the people frantically piling up religious payment, trying to buy off a God they have completely misread. And then comes the answer, and the answer cuts through every offer on the table. He has shown you, O man, what is good. As if to say, you already know. You have always known. The thing I want from you was never hidden. It was never about the volume of your worship. It was about whether you do justice.

*God filed a lawsuit against his own
people, and the verdict was three words
long: do justice, love mercy, walk
humbly.*

LOOK AT THE THREE demands, because the order and the pairing are doing theological work that the throw pillow erases. Do justice. The Hebrew is *asah mishpat*, and *asah* is an active verb, to make, to do, to produce. It is not feel justice or believe in justice or have correct opinions about justice. It

is do it, make it happen, produce the actual outcome in the actual world where the widow stands. Justice in Micah is something you manufacture with your hands and your decisions, not something you admire from a distance. Then, love mercy. The Hebrew word for mercy here is *hesed*, and *hesed* is one of the great words of the Hebrew Bible, the covenant loyalty, the steadfast committed love that God shows his people and demands they show one another, a love that keeps faith even when the other person cannot reciprocate. Notice the verbs are different. You do justice and you love mercy. Justice is the floor, the thing you produce as a baseline obligation. Mercy is the thing you fall in love with, the disposition of the heart that goes past obligation into delight. Micah is not letting you choose between them. He is telling you to do the one and love the other, to produce justice as a matter of duty and to cherish covenant kindness as a matter of joy.

And then the third demand, which is the one that keeps the first two from becoming a new form of pride. Walk humbly with your God. Here is the protection against the great danger of justice work, the danger I will return to again and again in this book, the danger that the moment you take up the cause of justice you begin to imagine you are God's appointed prosecutor, cleaner than the people you indict, standing above the failure rather than inside it. Micah will not allow it. He yokes the doing of justice to a humble walk with God, which means the just person is also the lowly person, the one who knows their own complicity, the one who does justice not from a height but from their knees. This is the line that the secular justice movements lose and that the privatized church never reaches, and Micah holds both in a single breath. Do justice and walk humbly. The two are not in

tension. The humble walk is what keeps the justice from becoming a weapon, and the justice is what keeps the humble walk from becoming a private piety that costs the neighbor nothing.

I have to confess what this verse exposed in me, because I quoted Micah 6:8 for years before I let it read me. I had it on a card. I liked the sound of it. I liked that it seemed to summarize the faith in a single elegant line. What I had done, without admitting it, was receive the verse as a description of my temperament rather than a command on my life. I was, I told myself, a justice-minded person. I cared about these things. And caring became my substitute for doing, just as Judah's sacrifices had become their substitute for doing. I had simply updated the currency. They piled up rams and rivers of oil. I piled up sympathy and the right opinions and the occasional moving sermon. And God's answer to me was exactly his answer to them. He has shown you what is good. It was never about the volume of your concern. It was about whether you produced justice in the world where you actually have power, the world of your church budget and your hiring and your relationships across the lines this society draws. I had loved the verse and avoided the verse at the same time, which is the most sophisticated form of disobedience there is.

The genius of Micah 6:8 is that it holds together the three things that our broken approaches keep tearing apart. The privatized church loves mercy and walks humbly, or thinks it does, but will not do justice, because doing justice means touching structures and structures mean politics and politics is uncomfortable, so it keeps the mercy and the humility and quietly drops the first command. The secular activist does justice, loudly, but has no mercy in it and no humility under God, so the justice hardens into ideology and the humble

walk disappears entirely. And the comfortable suburban believer does none of the three in any costly sense but feels warmly about all of them, which may be the worst position of all, because it has the language without the substance, the wall art without the wound. Micah will not let any of us settle into our partial version. He demands all three, together, in tension, held in a single life. Do justice. Love mercy. Walk humbly with your God. Drop any one of them and the other two go sour.

So before we go any further into the Exodus and the law and the prophets and Jesus, I want this verse to function as it was meant to function, as the courtroom verdict it actually is. God has a complaint against his people, and the complaint is not that we have worshiped too little. We have worshiped plenty. We have rams and oil and worship sets and building campaigns and conferences in abundance. The complaint is that we have offered all of it as a substitute for the one thing he asked, which was to do justice, love mercy, and walk humbly with him. There is no amount of worship that buys you out of that demand. There is no volume of religious activity loud enough to drown out the cry of the widow at the gate. Micah said it twenty-seven centuries ago to a people who thought their sacrifices had them covered, and it lands on us with the same weight, because we have made the same trade. He has shown us what is good. We already know. The only question this verse leaves us is whether we will keep loving it on a pillow or finally let it cost us what it costs.

CHAPTER THREE

The Exodus, Where the Justice-God Comes Down

BEFORE GOD GIVES A single commandment, he frees slaves. This is the order of events, and the order is the theology. We are so accustomed to thinking of the God of the Old Testament as the lawgiver, the God of Sinai and the tablets and the thunder, that we forget the law came second. It came to a people who had already been rescued. The first thing the God of Israel does in the founding story of the nation is not legislate. It is liberate. He hears the cry of an oppressed people groaning under forced labor, and he comes down. That phrase, he came down, in the third chapter of Exodus, is one of the most important sentences in the entire Bible, and the church has managed to read past it for centuries. The God of the universe identifies himself, at the burning bush, not first as the creator of heaven and earth, but as the one who has seen the affliction of his people and has heard their cry and has come down to deliver them. The

justice of God is not an attribute he reveals later. It is the way he introduces himself.

Consider who these people were when God chose to act. They were not a holy nation yet. They had no law, no temple, no covenant, no creed worth the name. They were slaves, a despised laboring underclass in the most powerful empire on earth, conscripted to build the storehouse cities of a Pharaoh who had decided their growing numbers were a threat and had ordered their male infants drowned in the Nile. They had nothing to recommend them religiously. What they had was a condition, oppression, and a sound, a cry, and the God of the Bible responds to the cry. He does not first require their righteousness. He responds to their suffering. This is the scandal at the root of the whole story, and it sets the pattern for everything that follows: God's justice moves toward the oppressed not because they have earned it but because oppression itself is an offense against him, a violation of the order he intends for his world.

*God did not give Israel the law and
then free them if they obeyed. He freed
them first, and the freedom was the
reason the law could come at all.*

THE EXODUS THEOLOGIANS OF the twentieth century saw this clearly, sometimes too narrowly, but they saw something the comfortable church had missed. Gustavo Gutierrez, writing from Peru in 1971, insisted that the Exodus was not merely a spiritual metaphor but the foundational political act

of God's self-revelation, a God who takes the side of the enslaved against the empire. Now, the liberation theologians sometimes collapsed the whole gospel into the political, and that is a real error I will address later, because the Exodus is not only about political liberation and the New Testament will not let us stop there. But the comfortable church made the opposite and larger error. It spiritualized the Exodus so completely that Egypt became a symbol of sin, Pharaoh a symbol of the devil, the Red Sea a symbol of baptism, and the actual slaves with their actual broken backs vanished into allegory. We turned a story about God liberating real people from real bondage into a story about our private souls escaping our private guilt, and in doing so we performed the exact operation this book is about. We privatized a public act of God. We took the justice out of the founding event and kept the personal salvation.

But you cannot finally do that with the text, because the text will not cooperate. When God gives the Ten Commandments at Sinai, he prefaces them with a sentence that grounds the entire moral law in the act of liberation. I am the Lord your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of slavery. That is the preamble to the law. The basis of Israel's obedience is not abstract divine authority. It is gratitude for liberation. You shall keep these commands, God says in effect, because of who I am, and who I am is the God who heard you when you were slaves and came down and brought you out. And then, crucially, throughout the law that follows, the memory of slavery becomes the engine of social ethics. You shall not oppress the immigrant, for you were immigrants in the land of Egypt. You shall remember that you were a slave in Egypt, and therefore you shall give your servants rest, you shall leave the gleanings

for the poor, you shall not pervert the justice due to the stranger. The Exodus is not a one-time rescue that God then leaves behind. It is the permanent reference point. Every time Israel is tempted to oppress the weak, God says, remember Egypt. Remember what it felt like to be on the bottom. Remember that I came down for you when you were there, and act accordingly.

This is why the privatized gospel is not just incomplete but actually false to the character of God as the Bible reveals it. The God who comes down at the burning bush is the same God all the way through. He does not have a justice phase that ends when the New Testament begins. The exodus pattern, oppression heard, God comes down, deliverance enacted, a community formed to live differently, runs straight through the Scriptures and finds its deepest expression in the cross, where God comes down again, into the lowest place, into the condition of the condemned and the executed, to liberate a humanity enslaved to sin and death and every power that crushes. The cross does not cancel the Exodus. It fulfills it. And a church that preaches the cross while ignoring the oppressed has cut the cross loose from the God who hung on it, the God who has always, from the very beginning, come down toward the bottom.

I have to confess that I preached the Exodus wrong for years, and I preached it wrong in the most respectable way possible. I preached it as a story about deliverance from personal sin, and everything I said was true as far as it went, and it did not go nearly far enough. I would stand in the pulpit and talk about the Egypt of addiction, the Egypt of guilt, the Egypt of the past you cannot escape, and I would call people to let God bring them out, and people would weep and be genuinely helped, and none of it ever once landed on the

actual structures of bondage operating in the actual lives of the people in my neighborhood. There were people in my city in literal economic bondage, trapped in debt at four hundred percent interest, working full time and still unable to make rent, and I was preaching the Egypt of their feelings. I had taken the most political book in the Bible and made it therapeutic. And I want to be careful here, because the personal application is real and I am not throwing it out. The point is that I stopped there, every time, because stopping there cost me nothing, and the God of the Exodus has never once stopped there.

So let the Exodus stand at the head of this book as the founding fact, the thing that orients everything else. The God of the Bible is a justice-God, a God who comes down. He is not neutral about oppression. He is not above the fray, weighing both sides with detached impartiality while the slaves drown their infants in the Nile. He has a settled disposition toward the crushed, a disposition the prophets will call by its name and the Psalms will sing and Jesus will embody, and that disposition is not in tension with his holiness or his love or his sovereignty. It is the expression of all three. When we made the gospel into a private transaction between the individual soul and God, we did not just narrow the gospel. We changed the God at the center of it. We traded the God who came down for a God who stayed up, above it all, untroubled by the cry that troubled the real God at the real burning bush. Recovering biblical justice begins here, with the recovery of this God, the one who heard slaves groaning and did not send a message and did not appoint a committee but came down himself. Everything else in this book is a footnote to that descent.

CHAPTER FOUR

The Widow, the Orphan, and the Stranger

IF YOU WANT TO know what is on God's mind, watch who he keeps mentioning. Through the law of Moses, through the Psalms, through every prophet, three figures appear again and again, named together so often that they function almost as a single unit, a kind of refrain that runs through the whole Hebrew Bible: the widow, the orphan, and the stranger. Sometimes a fourth is added, the poor, and sometimes the Levite, who owned no land. But the core triad is constant: the widow, the fatherless, and the foreigner. These are not random examples. They are the structurally vulnerable, the people whose vulnerability is built into the architecture of an agrarian, patriarchal, clan-based society, the people who fall through every crack that society contains. And God, with a consistency that should stop us cold, attaches his own name and his own protection to exactly these three.

Understand why these three and not others, because the

logic reveals the heart of biblical justice. In ancient Israel, security came through land and through family. Your land fed you, and your clan defended you, and your standing in the community depended on both. The widow had lost her husband, which meant she had lost her legal and economic representative, the man who would speak for her at the gate where cases were heard and defend her claim to the family land. The orphan had lost his father, which in that culture meant he had lost his inheritance, his protection, his entire future, because a fatherless child was a child with no one to secure his portion. The stranger, the ger, the resident foreigner, had no clan at all in the land where he lived, no kinship network, no ancestral claim, no one obligated by blood to take his side. These three had in common that they had no natural defender. The systems of protection that everyone else relied on simply did not reach them. And so God appoints himself their defender. A father to the fatherless and a protector of widows is God in his holy habitation. He does not merely command that they be cared for. He takes their case personally.

*Tell me who your God defends when no
one else will, and I will tell you whether
your God is the God of the Bible.*

THE LEGISLATION THAT FLOWS from this is remarkable, and it is remarkable precisely because it is legislation and not sentiment. God does not simply tell Israel to feel compassion for the vulnerable. He writes their protection into the legal

code with specific, enforceable provisions. You shall not mistreat a widow or an orphan, and the warning that follows is terrifying in its directness: if you do mistreat them, and they cry out to me, I will surely hear their cry, and my wrath will burn, and I will kill you with the sword, and your own wives will become widows and your children fatherless. God promises to personally avenge the mistreatment of the vulnerable by visiting the same vulnerability on the oppressor. There is the triennial tithe, where every third year the tithe is stored in the towns specifically so that the Levite and the stranger and the orphan and the widow may come and eat and be filled. There is the command, repeated in the legal blessings and curses, that cursed is anyone who perverts the justice due to the stranger, the orphan, and the widow. The vulnerable are not objects of optional private charity. They are subjects of legal right, protected by statute, with God himself as the enforcing authority.

And then there is the stranger, the foreigner, the immigrant, and I want to dwell here because this is where the modern church most reliably loses its nerve. The Hebrew word *ger* refers to a resident alien, someone living among the people of Israel who was not ethnically Israelite, without the protections of belonging to the tribes. The law's treatment of the *ger* is among the most striking things in all of Scripture. You shall not wrong a stranger or oppress him, for you were strangers in the land of Egypt. The command is grounded, again, in the Exodus memory: you know what it is to be the foreigner, the despised outsider, the one with no rights, because that is exactly what you were, and the God who heard you then is watching how you treat the foreigner now. The law goes further than non-oppression. In Leviticus, God commands that the stranger who sojourns with you shall be

to you as the native among you, and you shall love him as yourself, for you were strangers in the land of Egypt. The command to love your neighbor as yourself, the command Jesus would call the second greatest, is in its original context applied explicitly to the foreigner. Love the immigrant as yourself. It is right there in the law, and we have managed to quote the love-your-neighbor command for two thousand years while quietly excising the foreigner it was first applied to.

Here is where I have to implicate myself and the church I serve, because the contrast between the law's posture and ours is not subtle. The God of the Bible commands his people to love the immigrant, to leave the corners of the field for the immigrant, to extend to the immigrant the same legal standing as the native-born, and to remember constantly that they themselves were once immigrants and slaves. And the church in my country has too often led the way in fearing the immigrant, in seeing the stranger as a threat to be repelled rather than a neighbor to be loved, in baptizing a politics of exclusion with a thin coat of Scripture. I am not making a partisan point, and I want to be clear about that, because the prophets struck in every direction and I intend to as well. The point is theological. Whatever your policy conclusions about borders and immigration, the law of God does not permit the church to treat the foreigner as less than a neighbor, to fear him, to harden its heart against his vulnerability, and when we have done so we have not merely held a debatable political position. We have contradicted the explicit, repeated, Exodus-grounded command of God. I have stayed silent in rooms where the stranger was being spoken of with contempt, and my silence was a vote, and I am inside this failure, not above it.

What the widow, the orphan, and the stranger reveal is the direction of God's justice, its built-in bias, if we can use that word carefully. God is not neutral. The God of the Bible has a settled, declared, legislated concern for the people at the bottom, the people without defenders, the people the systems of the world are built to ignore. This is not because the vulnerable are more virtuous than the powerful. The Bible is not romantic about the poor. It is because justice, biblically defined, means precisely the protection of those who cannot protect themselves, and a God of justice will therefore always be found standing where the protection is most absent. This is the test the prophets will apply to Israel, and it is the test that still applies to the church. Not how do you treat the powerful, who can reward you, but how do you treat the widow, the orphan, and the stranger, who can do nothing for you in return. That is where the character of a community is revealed, because that is where there is no incentive to do right except the command and character of God himself.

So the next time you read your way through the law of Moses and your eyes glaze over at what looks like ancient social housekeeping, slow down and notice the refrain. The widow. The orphan. The stranger. Count how many times it appears. Notice that God keeps coming back to it, that he will not let Israel forget it, that he attaches his wrath to its violation and his blessing to its keeping. This is not housekeeping. This is the heart of God, written into law because hearts forget and laws endure. And it stands as a permanent rebuke to every privatized gospel that imagines God cares only about the inner life of the individual soul. The God who wrote these laws cares, with legal specificity and personal vengeance, about whether the widow at the gate gets justice. He has not changed. The question is whether we have

ever really known him, or whether we have worshiped a God of our own design who conveniently shares all our blind spots and defends all the same people we already wanted to defend.

CHAPTER FIVE

The Gleaning Laws and the Book of Ruth

IN THE LAW OF Moses there is a piece of economic legislation so simple and so radical that it has almost no equivalent in the ancient world, and the modern church has reduced it to a charming detail in a love story. When you reap the harvest of your land, you shall not reap your field to its very edge, nor shall you gather the gleanings after your harvest. You shall leave them for the poor and for the stranger. That is the gleaning law, and what it does is establish, by divine statute, a legal right of the poor to a portion of the produce of land they do not own. Read that again, because the church has trained itself to read past it. The poor have a right, written into law, to glean the fields of the wealthy. The landowner does not get to decide, out of the goodness of his heart, whether to share. He is commanded to leave the edges unharvested and the dropped grain ungathered, and the poor are entitled to come and take it. This is not charity. It is justice, structured into the economy itself, a built-in provision that gives the landless poor a

guaranteed access to the means of life.

Notice the genius of the design, because it tells you something about how God thinks justice should work. The gleaning system does not create a class of passive recipients waiting for a handout from a benefactor. The poor still have to come and glean. They have to do the labor of gathering, bending in the heat, working the edges of the field. Their dignity is preserved, because they are working for their bread, not receiving it as a gift from a superior. But the access is guaranteed by law, not left to the whim of the powerful, so that the dignity does not come at the cost of security. It is a system that protects both the dignity of work and the right to eat, and it does so by placing an obligation on the wealthy that they cannot escape by claiming they earned what they have. You did earn your harvest, the law says in effect, and the edges of it are not yours. The corners belong to the poor by right. Your ownership is real but it is not absolute, because the land is ultimately mine, says the Lord, and I have written a claim of the poor into the title.

*The gleaning law did not ask the rich
to be generous. It told them the corners
of the field were never theirs to begin
with.*

THIS IS THE STRUCTURE that makes the book of Ruth possible, and once you see the gleaning law clearly, the book of Ruth reads completely differently. Most of us were taught Ruth as a romance, the lovely story of a faithful Moabite

widow and the kind landowner who marries her, a story about loyalty and providence and the line of David. All of that is there and all of that is true. But underneath the love story is a story about the law working exactly as God designed it to work. Ruth is a widow, and a foreigner, a Moabite, two of the three categories of the structurally vulnerable in a single person. She has no husband, no land, no clan in Israel, no defender. And what does she do when she and Naomi arrive in Bethlehem destitute. She goes to glean. She exercises her legal right under the gleaning law to gather in the fields of someone wealthy enough to have fields. The entire plot turns on a piece of social legislation. Ruth survives because God wrote a law that gave the foreign widow the right to eat from the harvest of a man she had never met.

And then there is Boaz, and Boaz is held up, rightly, as a model of righteousness, but watch what his righteousness actually consists of, because it is more than personal kindness. Boaz keeps the gleaning law, and then he goes beyond it. He instructs his workers to leave extra grain deliberately for Ruth, pulling stalks from the bundles and dropping them in her path. He commands that she not be touched or harassed, protecting a vulnerable foreign woman in a field full of male laborers. He invites her to eat with his workers, breaking the social barrier between the landowner and the gleaner. Boaz is *tsedaqah* in human form, righteousness as the Hebrew means it, a life so ordered toward the vulnerable that the weak are stronger because he exists among them. But notice that his personal generosity operates within and on top of a legal structure. He does not invent a private charity that lets the law go unkept. He fulfills the law and exceeds it. His mercy is built on a foundation of justice, the floor that the gleaning law established. This is the

biblical pattern that we have inverted. We have kept the personal generosity of Boaz, the warm individual kindness, while abandoning the legal structure of justice that his generosity was meant to crown. We have Boaz without the gleaning law, mercy without the floor of justice underneath it, and the result is that the Ruths of our world are entirely dependent on whether they happen to stumble into a kind man, with no legal right to anything if they do not.

This is exactly the difference between charity and justice that this whole book keeps circling, and the gleaning law makes it concrete. A charity model says the poor are dependent on the generosity of the rich, who may give or withhold as they please, and when they give, they are praised as benefactors, and the poor are grateful recipients, and the basic arrangement of who has and who has not is never disturbed. A justice model says the poor have a right, structured into the system, that does not depend on anyone's mood or virtue, a right that the powerful are obligated to honor whether they feel generous or not. The gleaning law is unmistakably the second kind. It is not a suggestion that landowners be nice. It is a command that establishes a claim. And the difference matters enormously, because a charity model leaves the powerful in control and merely asks them to be kind, while a justice model limits the power of the powerful and gives the poor a standing they did not have to beg for. God chose the justice model. He wrote it into the law. And the church, by and large, has chosen the charity model, because the charity model lets us keep control and feel good while changing nothing structural, and that preference is itself a confession of where our hearts actually are.

I think about the gleaning law every time my church runs a benevolence program, and I think about it with a degree of

conviction, because our benevolence is good and it is also a charity model through and through. We decide who gets help. We assess their worthiness. We give from our abundance and feel the warmth of giving, and the people who come to us come as petitioners, hat in hand, hoping we will judge them deserving. There is nothing in our system that resembles a right. There is nothing that limits our power or guarantees their access. And I am not saying we should not do benevolence, of course we should, but I am saying that if benevolence is the whole of our economic ethic, then we have settled for the charity model that God rejected when he wrote the gleaning law, and we have done it for the same reason everyone does it, because it lets the people with the fields keep deciding, and deciding is power, and we do not want to give the power up. The gleaning law asks us to give it up, to accept that the corners of our fields are not ours, that the vulnerable have a claim on what we have that does not depend on our approval.

So let Ruth be read again, and this time read it as what it is, a story made possible by economic justice legislation, a story in which a foreign widow survives because God built a right to glean into the law of the land. Read Boaz as a man whose righteousness operated within that structure and crowned it, not as a man whose private kindness substituted for it. And let the gleaning law stand as a permanent question to every church and every Christian who has resources, which is most of us reading this book, whether we know it or not. Where are the corners of your field. What have you left deliberately unharvested for the people with no land of their own. Is there anything in how you hold your resources that resembles a right of the poor, or is it all charity, all your decision, all dependent on your mood. God wrote the corners

of the field out of the landowner's portion. The question for us is whether we will keep insisting the whole field is ours, every last stalk, and offer the poor only what falls from our hand when we feel like opening it. That is not the law of Moses. That is not the righteousness of Boaz. And it is not, I am afraid, far from where most of us actually live.

CHAPTER SIX

The Jubilee and the Cancellation of Debt

IN THE TWENTY-FIFTH CHAPTER of Leviticus there is a law so economically radical that scholars still argue about whether Israel ever actually kept it, and the modern church has dealt with the difficulty by ignoring it almost entirely. It is the Jubilee. Every seven years there was to be a sabbath for the land, a year in which the fields lay fallow and debts were released. And then, after seven cycles of seven, in the fiftieth year, came the Jubilee, the great reset, the year when liberty was proclaimed throughout the land to all its inhabitants. In the Jubilee, slaves were freed, debts were cancelled, and most astonishing of all, land returned to the families that had originally held it. Every fifty years, the economic deck was reshuffled. Every fifty years, the accumulation of wealth in the hands of the few was undone, and every family was restored to the means of making a life. There has never been a more radical economic provision written into the founding law of a people, and God wrote it.

You have to understand what land meant to grasp what the

Jubilee was doing. In an agrarian society, land was not one asset among many. Land was life itself. Land was the difference between feeding your family and starving, between freedom and debt-slavery, between a future and the loss of one. And in any economy, over time, land concentrates. The strong acquire the holdings of the weak. A bad harvest, a death, a debt, and a family loses its land to a wealthier neighbor, and once the land is gone, the family has nothing, and the children are born into a poverty they did not create and cannot escape, because the means of escape, the land, now belongs permanently to someone else. This is the ordinary trajectory of every economy left to itself: concentration at the top, dispossession at the bottom, a hardening of the lines until there is a permanent aristocracy and a permanent underclass and no way across. The Jubilee was God's answer to that trajectory. Every fifty years, the concentration was undone. The land went back. No family could be permanently locked out. The lines that every economy hardens, God commanded to be erased, twice a century, by law.

*The Jubilee was God refusing to let
poverty become permanent. He wrote a
reset into the law because he knew the
economy would always, left alone,
grind the poor into the ground.*

THE THEOLOGICAL FOUNDATION OF the Jubilee is one

sentence, and it dismantles the entire ideology of absolute private property. The land shall not be sold in perpetuity, God says, for the land is mine, for you are strangers and sojourners with me. There it is. The land is mine. The Israelites are tenants, not owners, sojourners on land that belongs to God, permitted to use it but never to possess it absolutely, never to accumulate it without limit, never to lock another family out of it forever. This single sentence is the death of the notion that what I have earned is mine to do with as I please. The God of the Bible says the land is his, that human ownership is always provisional and always under his claim, and that his claim includes the demand that no one be permanently dispossessed. We have built entire economic philosophies on the sacredness of private property, and many of us in the church have baptized those philosophies as though they were Christian, and Leviticus 25 stands against all of them with a flat divine assertion. The land is mine. You are sojourners. Your ownership is real but it is not ultimate, and it does not include the right to lock your neighbor out forever.

Now I want to be careful and honest, because the careless reader will hear this as a partisan economic program, and it is not. The Jubilee is not modern socialism, and it is not modern capitalism, and anyone who flattens it into either is doing to the text what this whole book is trying to undo. The Jubilee did not abolish private property. Families owned and worked their own land. It did not redistribute everything to everyone equally every year. It was not a permanent leveling. What it did was something stranger and wiser than any modern ideology: it allowed the ordinary functioning of the economy, with its incentives and its inequalities, while building in a periodic correction that prevented those

inequalities from becoming permanent and hereditary. It honored both the dignity of ownership and labor and the limit on accumulation. It said you may grow wealthy, but you may not build that wealth into a permanent wall that locks the poor out across generations. It is neither the left's program nor the right's. It is God's, and it judges both, because both modern ideologies tend, in practice, toward exactly the hereditary concentration the Jubilee was designed to break.

Whether Israel ever kept the Jubilee is genuinely uncertain. There is little evidence in the historical books that the reset was ever actually carried out, and the prophets' fury at land-grabbing suggests it was not. Isaiah cries woe to those who join house to house and add field to field until there is no more room and they are made to dwell alone in the land, which is a description of exactly the concentration the Jubilee was meant to prevent, which means it was happening, which means the Jubilee was being ignored. So we should not romanticize ancient Israel as a society that achieved economic justice. They had the law and they broke it, like we have the prophets and ignore them. But the point is not whether Israel kept the Jubilee. The point is that God commanded it, that he wrote into the founding law of his people a permanent mechanism against permanent poverty, that he declared the land his own and the people sojourners, and that this reveals, with unmistakable clarity, what God thinks about an economy that grinds families into hereditary dispossession. He thinks it is wrong, so wrong that he legislated a reset against it, and the fact that his people ignored the legislation is an indictment of them, not a softening of him.

The Jubilee did not stay in Leviticus. It surfaces again at the most important moment, and I am getting ahead of

myself, but I have to name it here because it changes how you read everything. When Jesus stood up in the synagogue in Nazareth and read from Isaiah and announced his mission, the phrase he landed on, to proclaim the year of the Lord's favor, is Jubilee language. The year of the Lord's favor is the Jubilee year, the year of release, the year liberty is proclaimed. Jesus took the most radical economic provision in the law and made it the banner of his ministry. We will get there in a few chapters. But hold this connection: the Jubilee is not an obscure piece of ancient legislation that the church can safely shelve. It is the very image Jesus chose to describe what he came to do. To proclaim the year of the Lord's favor. To announce the great release. To declare that God's reign means the cancellation of debt and the liberation of the captive and the restoration of the dispossessed. If we have no theology of the Jubilee, we have no way to understand the platform Jesus announced, because he announced it in Jubilee terms.

I confess that the Jubilee terrifies me a little, and I think it is supposed to, because I am a man with debts owed to me and assets I would not want reshuffled and a comfortable position I would prefer to keep, and the Jubilee comes for exactly that comfort. It is easy to admire the Jubilee in the abstract and very hard to want it applied to your own balance sheet. And I think that discomfort is the honest response, the response God intended, because the Jubilee is not meant to be admired. It is meant to indict the part of us that wants our gains to be permanent and our position secure regardless of who is locked out below us. I do not have a tidy program for how the church applies the Jubilee in a modern economy, and anyone who offers you a tidy program is selling something. What I have is the conviction that we cannot read Leviticus 25

honestly and go on treating economic concentration as natural and inevitable and none of God's concern. The land is mine, God says. You are sojourners. And a sojourner who has built a wall around the field and locked his neighbor's grandchildren out of it forever has forgotten whose land it was, and the Jubilee was God's way of making sure his people remembered, every fifty years, whether they wanted to or not.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Sabbath as Resistance

WE HAVE MADE THE Sabbath small. We have turned it into a personal discipline, a self-care practice, a recommendation to slow down in a busy life, and in doing so we have stripped it of nearly everything the Bible loaded into it. The Sabbath is one of the most politically and economically subversive commands in all of Scripture, and the church has reduced it to a suggestion about getting more rest. But look at where the Sabbath comes from and what it is set against, and you find not a wellness tip but an act of resistance, a weekly rebellion against the entire logic of empire, a refusal of the economy of endless production that was killing the people God came down to free. The Sabbath is not first about your tiredness. It is about who owns your time, and the answer the Sabbath gives is not Pharaoh, and not the market, and not you, but God.

Remember where Israel came from. They came from Egypt, from slavery, and slavery is, among other things, an economy with no Sabbath. The genius of Pharaoh's system,

the thing that made it an empire, was production without limit, labor without rest, human beings reduced to units of output, valued only for what they could make. When Pharaoh wanted to crush the spirit of the Hebrews who were asking for freedom, what did he do. He took away their straw and demanded the same quota of bricks, which is to say he intensified the production, increased the relentlessness, because in the logic of empire the answer to unrest is always more work. Egypt was a machine that never stopped, that consumed human lives as fuel, that knew no day on which a slave was anything other than a means of production. And out of that machine, God brought his people, and almost the first thing he did with their freedom was give them a Sabbath, a day on which the machine stops, a day on which no one, not you, not your son, not your servant, not the foreigner, not even your ox, is reduced to a unit of labor. Six days you shall work, but the seventh is a sabbath to the Lord your God. On it you shall not do any work.

*The Sabbath is the day the slaves God
freed get to remember they are not
slaves. It is a weekly strike against
every Pharaoh who says your worth is
your output.*

WALTER BRUEGGEMANN SAW THIS with great clarity, that the Sabbath is resistance, that it is the great refusal of the anxious, acquisitive, production-driven society that Egypt

represented and that every empire since has represented in its turn. The Sabbath, Brueggemann argued, is an act of trust, a declaration that the world does not depend on my ceaseless labor, that I can stop and the bread will still come, that my security rests not in my output but in the God who provides. And it is therefore an act of defiance against the systems that tell us our worth is what we produce, that we must work without limit to be safe, that to stop is to fall behind and to fall behind is to be lost. The Sabbath says no. The Sabbath says the people of God will not live by that logic, will not be ruled by that anxiety, will not let the market or the boss or the relentless engine of acquisition own the entirety of their days. One day in seven, they stop, and in stopping they declare that they belong to God and not to Pharaoh, that their time is a gift and not a commodity, that they are human beings made in the image of God and not machines made to produce.

And notice who the Sabbath protects, because this is where it becomes a justice command and not merely a personal one. The Sabbath command in Deuteronomy explicitly extends rest to the most vulnerable: your male servant and your female servant may rest as well as you. And the grounding is the Exodus, again, always the Exodus: you shall remember that you were a slave in the land of Egypt, and the Lord your God brought you out, therefore the Lord your God commanded you to keep the Sabbath day. The logic is unmistakable. You know what it is to be worked without rest, to be a body valued only for its labor, to have no day that is yours. You know that, because you were slaves. Therefore you will never do that to anyone under your power. Your servants will rest. The foreigner in your gates will rest. Even your animals will rest. The Sabbath is the great equalizer, the day on which the master and the servant and the stranger

and the beast all stop together, all stand equal before the God who made them and freed them, all released from the relentless demand to produce. It is a weekly enactment of the truth that no human being exists merely to be used, and that truth is a justice truth, a leveling truth, a truth that empires cannot abide.

I think the modern church has lost the Sabbath precisely because we have lost the resistance, and we have lost the resistance because we have made our peace with the empire. We are as production-driven, as anxious, as acquisitive, as captured by the logic of endless output as any culture in history, and we have simply baptized it. We praise the busy. We admire the hustle. We measure our worth and our neighbor's worth by output and achievement and accumulation, and then we wonder why we are exhausted and why our people are exhausted, and the answer is that we have refused the gift God gave precisely to free us from this. We kept a thin religious Sabbath, an hour or two on Sunday morning, and then we went right back to the machine, and the machine owns us, and we call it normal. To recover the Sabbath would be to recover an act of defiance, a weekly declaration that we will not be ruled by the engine of production, that we and our employees and the strangers in our midst will stop, will rest, will remember that we are not slaves. It would cost us. The machine does not like to be stopped, and the part of us that has internalized the machine does not like to stop it. That is exactly why it is a command and not a suggestion, and exactly why we have quietly let it go.

I have been the worst kind of Sabbath-breaker, the pastor who preaches rest and lives in perpetual motion, who tells his people that their worth is not their output and then privately measures his own ministry entirely by output, by numbers,

by the relentless production of sermons and programs and growth. I have treated my own life as a machine and modeled the machine for my people while preaching against it, which is its own kind of hypocrisy, the hypocrisy of the man who cannot receive the gift he commends. And I have failed the justice dimension of the Sabbath too, because I have not asked hard enough about the people whose labor makes my comfortable life possible, the people with no Sabbath at all, the workers in the relentless economy who cannot stop because stopping means not eating, the people for whom the very idea of a day of rest is a luxury they cannot afford. The Sabbath is supposed to make me ask about them, to make the church a community that defends the right of the worker to rest, that refuses to participate in the grinding-down of human beings into units of production. I have not asked hard enough. I have kept my thin Sunday and made my peace with the machine, and the Sabbath stands against me, as it stands against all of us who have forgotten that the God who gave it was freeing slaves.

So recover the Sabbath, but recover the whole of it, not the wellness fragment we have kept. Recover it as resistance, as defiance, as a weekly refusal of the empire's logic that your worth is your output and your security is your labor and you must never stop. Recover it as justice, as the leveling day on which servant and master rest together and the worker's right to rest is defended by the people of God. Recover it as memory, the memory of Egypt, the memory that we were slaves and were freed, and that a people who were freed will never grind anyone else into the slavery they were brought out of. The Sabbath is not small. It is one of the great subversive commands of God, a stone thrown into the gears of every machine that reduces human beings to their

usefulness. We made it small because the large version asked us to stop a machine we had decided to serve. The question the Sabbath puts to us is the oldest question in the Bible, the question of the Exodus itself. Whom will you serve. Pharaoh, who demands the bricks without end, or the God who gives his people a day to remember they are free.

CHAPTER EIGHT

When God Hates Your Worship

THERE IS A MOMENT in the prophets that should make every churchgoing person go cold, and we have learned to read past it because reading it honestly would ruin our Sunday. God says, through the prophet Amos in the eighth century BC, that he hates the worship of his own people. Not that he is disappointed with it. Not that he wishes it were better. He hates it. I hate, I despise your feasts, he says, and I take no delight in your solemn assemblies. Take away from me the noise of your songs, for I will not listen to the melody of your harps. This is God speaking about the worship of his own covenant people, the festivals he himself instituted, the songs offered in his own name, and he says take it away, I cannot stand the noise of it. And then comes the reason, the famous verse, the verse this whole book takes for its epigraph: but let justice roll down like waters, and righteousness like an ever-flowing stream. Mishpat and tsedaqah. The two words. God says he hates worship that is offered while justice and righteousness are absent, and there

is no clearer statement in all of Scripture that you cannot buy God off with worship while you ignore the poor.

Amos was a shepherd from Tekoa, a layman, no professional prophet, who was sent north to the prosperous kingdom of Israel during the reign of Jeroboam the Second, a time of remarkable economic boom. The kingdom was wealthy, the religion was thriving, the festivals were crowded, the sacrifices were abundant. By every external measure, it was a golden age of prosperity and piety. And into that prosperous, religious, self-satisfied society God sent a shepherd to announce that it was rotten to the core, because the prosperity had been built on the backs of the poor, and the piety was a cover for the exploitation. Amos describes it in unforgettable detail. They sell the righteous for silver and the needy for a pair of sandals. They trample the head of the poor into the dust of the earth. They store up violence and robbery in their strongholds. The merchants cannot wait for the Sabbath to end so they can get back to cheating, making the ephah small and the shekel great, dealing deceitfully with false balances, buying the poor for silver. And all of this, all of this exploitation, ran alongside a thriving religious life, full festivals, abundant sacrifices, beautiful music. The worship and the injustice coexisted perfectly, and God says the worship, far from covering the injustice, makes him sick.

*God would rather have no worship at
all than worship offered by hands that
crushed the poor on the way to church.*

ISAIAH, WORKING IN THE southern kingdom of Judah in the same century, says the same thing with the same fury. In the very first chapter of his book, God rejects the worship of his people in language that is almost unbearable. What to me is the multitude of your sacrifices, he says. I have had enough of burnt offerings. I do not delight in the blood of bulls. When you come to appear before me, who has required this of you, this trampling of my courts. Bring no more vain offerings. Incense is an abomination to me. Your new moons and your appointed feasts my soul hates. They have become a burden to me. I am weary of bearing them. When you spread out your hands, I will hide my eyes from you. Even though you make many prayers, I will not listen. And then the reason: your hands are full of blood. And then the demand: wash yourselves, make yourselves clean, remove the evil of your deeds, cease to do evil, learn to do good, seek justice, correct oppression, bring justice to the fatherless, plead the widow's cause. There it is again. The widow and the orphan. The command to seek justice. God says your worship is an abomination to me because your hands are full of blood, and the only thing that will change it is not better worship but justice. Seek justice. Correct oppression. Defend the orphan and the widow. Until you do, your prayers hit the ceiling and your incense is a stench.

And then there is the fifty-eighth chapter of Isaiah, which goes after the most sincere religious practice of all, fasting, and exposes it as worthless when it is divorced from justice. The people are complaining that they have fasted and God has not noticed. Why have we fasted, they ask, and you see it not. And God answers that their fasting is a sham, because on the day of their fast they pursue their own pleasure and oppress their workers, they fast only to quarrel and to hit with

a wicked fist. And then God describes the fast he actually chooses, and it is not about food at all. Is not this the fast that I choose, to loose the bonds of wickedness, to undo the straps of the yoke, to let the oppressed go free, and to break every yoke. Is it not to share your bread with the hungry and bring the homeless poor into your house, when you see the naked to cover him, and not to hide yourself from your own flesh. There is the fast God wants. Not the abstention from food while you oppress your workers, but the loosing of bonds, the freeing of the oppressed, the sharing of bread, the housing of the homeless. God takes the most spiritual, most internal, most personal religious practice imaginable, fasting, and says it means nothing, nothing at all, unless it issues in justice for the oppressed. The internal must become the external or it is a lie.

I want to sit in this, because this is the prophetic word that lands most directly on me and on every church I have ever served. We are a worshipping people. We pour enormous energy and money and care into our worship, into the music and the production and the experience, and we measure our health by it, by how full the room is and how moved the people are and how excellent the service was. And the prophets stand in the middle of our beautiful services and ask the question we never ask: while you were singing, what was happening to the poor in your city. While your worship was excellent, were the bonds of wickedness being loosed or tightened. While you spread out your hands in praise, were your hands clean, or were they full, like the hands of ancient Judah, with the blood of an exploitation you benefit from and refuse to see. And I have to confess that I do not know the answer for my own ministry, and the not-knowing is itself the indictment, because the prophets assume that a people right

with God will know, will be able to point to the bonds they have loosed and the oppressed they have freed, and a people who can only point to their worship and not to their justice are a people God has already named.

The terrifying thing about these passages is not that God demands worship and justice both. We could handle that. The terrifying thing is that God says worship without justice is worse than no worship at all, that it actively offends him, that it becomes an abomination and a stench and a burden he is weary of bearing. This means the very thing we are most proud of, our rich worshiping life, can be the very thing that condemns us, if it runs alongside an injustice we tolerate. It means that a church with magnificent worship and no concern for the oppressed is not a partially faithful church. It is, in the prophets' own words, a church whose worship God hates. We have assumed that worship is always a credit in our account with God, that more worship is always more faithfulness, and the prophets blow that assumption to pieces. Worship offered by hands full of blood is not a credit. It is the aggravation of the offense. It is adding insult to the injury, dressing up the exploitation in the clothes of piety, and God hates it precisely because it uses his own name to cover the crime against his own poor.

So what do we do with a God who hates our worship. We do the only thing the prophets ever tell us to do, which is the thing we most want to avoid. We do not improve the worship. We seek the justice. Wash yourselves, make yourselves clean, cease to do evil, learn to do good, seek justice, correct oppression, defend the orphan, plead for the widow, loose the bonds, free the oppressed, share the bread, house the homeless. The path back to acceptable worship does not run through better music or deeper sincerity in the singing. It

runs through the streets where the poor of our cities are being crushed, through the structures we have tolerated and benefited from, through the justice we have outsourced and the righteousness we have privatized. Let justice roll down like waters, Amos said, and righteousness like an ever-flowing stream. He said it to a prosperous, religious, worshiping people who could not understand why their God was so angry. He says it to us, and we are that people, and the only question is whether we will hear a dead shepherd from Tekoa or keep on singing while the river runs dry.

CHAPTER NINE

Nazareth, Where Jesus Read His Platform

EVERY LEADER ANNOUNCES A platform. When a man stands up to lead a movement, there is a moment when he tells you what it is for, what he intends to do, where he is going. Jesus had such a moment, and the church has spent two thousand years failing to take it as seriously as he did. It happened in Nazareth, in the synagogue where he had grown up, early in his ministry, in the fourth chapter of Luke. Jesus stood up to read, as was his custom, and they handed him the scroll of the prophet Isaiah, and he unrolled it and found the place, deliberately, the text says he found the place, and he read. The Spirit of the Lord is upon me, because he has anointed me to proclaim good news to the poor. He has sent me to proclaim liberty to the captives and recovering of sight to the blind, to set at liberty those who are oppressed, to proclaim the year of the Lord's favor. And then he rolled up the scroll and gave it back and sat down, and the eyes of everyone in the synagogue were fixed on him, and he said, today this Scripture has been fulfilled in your hearing. That

was the platform. That was the manifesto. Jesus chose the text, found the place, read it, and announced that it was being fulfilled in him, today, in their hearing. This is what I came to do.

Notice what he read, because he chose it. Of all the texts in all the scrolls of all the prophets, Jesus reached for Isaiah 61, and Isaiah 61 is a justice text, drenched in the language of release and liberation and the lifting of the oppressed. Good news to the poor. Liberty to the captives. Sight to the blind. Freedom for the oppressed. The year of the Lord's favor. And that last phrase, the year of the Lord's favor, is, as I said when we looked at the Jubilee, Jubilee language. The year of the Lord's favor is the year of release, the year of the great reset, the year debts are cancelled and captives freed and the dispossessed restored. Jesus took the most economically radical provision in the law of Moses and made it the banner over his entire ministry. He stood up in his hometown and announced that he had come to proclaim the Jubilee, the year of release, good news to the poor, liberty to the captives. He could have chosen a text about personal forgiveness, about private salvation, about the inner life of the soul, and there are such texts, and they are true. He did not choose them for his inaugural address. He chose the text about the poor and the captive and the oppressed and the year of release. That choice is a revelation of his priorities, and the church has spent two millennia trying to spiritualize the choice away.

Jesus had one chance to tell his hometown what he came for, and he reached for the scroll of the poor and the captive and the oppressed. He chose his platform. We keep editing it.

AND HERE IS THE thing we cannot dodge: the church has worked very hard to make the poor in this text into the spiritually poor, the captives into the captives of sin, the blind into the spiritually blind, the oppressed into those oppressed by guilt, so that Jesus' platform becomes entirely internal and touches no actual poor person, no actual prisoner, no actual oppressed body. And there is a sense in which the spiritual reading is not wrong, because Jesus did come to free us from the deepest captivity, which is sin, and to give sight to the deepest blindness, which is the blindness of the soul. I am not denying the spiritual dimension. But the spiritualizing becomes a lie the moment it is used to evacuate the text of its plain meaning, the moment poor stops meaning poor and captive stops meaning captive, the moment we use the spiritual reading not to deepen the literal one but to escape it. Jesus did not stand in Nazareth and proclaim good news only to the metaphorically poor while the literally poor of Galilee went on starving outside the synagogue. He came for both, body and soul, and a reading that keeps the soul and discards the body has not deepened his platform. It has deleted half of it, and it has deleted exactly the half that costs us something.

Watch what Jesus actually did in his ministry, because his

deeds interpret his platform. Did he tend only to souls. He fed thousands of hungry people with actual bread, not metaphorical bread, real loaves and real fish for real empty stomachs. He healed actual bodies, blind eyes that actually saw, lame legs that actually walked, lepers actually cleansed and restored to a community that had cast them out. He touched the untouchable, ate with the outcast, crossed every social barrier his society had built to keep the impure and the foreign and the sinful at a distance. He noticed the widow putting in her two coins and named the system that had devoured widows' houses. He told a rich young man to sell what he had and give to the poor. He warned the comfortable and blessed the poor, blessed are you who are poor, he said, and woe to you who are rich. His ministry was not a ministry to disembodied souls. It was a ministry to whole persons, bodies and souls together, hungry bodies fed and sick bodies healed and excluded bodies welcomed, exactly as you would expect from a man whose announced platform was good news to the poor and liberty to the captives. The deeds match the manifesto. It is only the church's editing that has pulled them apart.

There is a detail at the end of the Nazareth scene that we cannot skip, because it tells us how dangerous this platform was. After Jesus announced that the Scripture was fulfilled, the crowd was at first amazed, speaking well of him. And then he kept talking, and he reminded them of two stories from their own Scriptures, the story of Elijah being sent to a foreign widow in Sidon during a famine in Israel, and the story of Elisha healing Naaman the Syrian, a foreign general, when there were many lepers in Israel. In other words, Jesus pointed out that God's justice and mercy had, in their own sacred history, reached past the chosen people to foreigners,

to outsiders, to the very people they despised. And when he said this, the same crowd that had just been praising him was filled with rage. They rose up, drove him out of the town, and tried to throw him off a cliff. They tried to kill him. Why. Because the platform of justice, the moment it crossed the boundary of their tribe and included the outsider, became intolerable. They could handle good news to the poor as long as the poor were their own. The instant Jesus suggested God's favor extended to the foreigner, to the enemy, to the outsider, they wanted him dead. This is the first attempt on Jesus' life in Luke's Gospel, and it is provoked not by a claim about his divinity but by the inclusiveness of his justice. The platform was dangerous from the first day. It got him nearly thrown off a cliff in his own hometown. And we have made it safe.

I have to ask myself why the church I belong to, the tradition I love, has so consistently softened the platform Jesus announced, and the honest answer is that the soft version is safer and cheaper and keeps the right people comfortable. Good news to the spiritually poor costs me nothing. Good news to the actually poor costs me my comfort, my assumptions, my position, my money, my distance from the suffering I would rather not see. Liberty to the captives of sin is a sermon I can preach without ever visiting a prison. Liberty to the actual captives might require me to ask about the prisons in my own city and the people in them and the system that put them there. The spiritualized platform lets me keep Jesus as the savior of my inner life while leaving the whole outer world, the world of the poor and the captive and the oppressed, exactly as it was. And I have preached that soft version, found that place in the scroll and somehow read past the poor and the captive to land on the safely spiritual, because the safely spiritual was what my people wanted and

what I wanted, and the dangerous platform that nearly got Jesus killed in Nazareth was not a platform I was eager to stand on.

So let Nazareth function as it was meant to, as the announcement of what Jesus came to do, in his own words, by his own choosing. The Spirit of the Lord is upon me to proclaim good news to the poor, liberty to the captives, sight to the blind, freedom to the oppressed, the year of the Lord's favor. This is not a marginal text. It is the inaugural address of the Son of God, the platform he chose over every other text he could have chosen, the mission statement of his entire ministry, confirmed by everything he then did with his hands and his words and his body. And it is a justice platform, an Exodus platform, a Jubilee platform, a platform about the poor and the captive and the oppressed and the great release. To follow this Jesus is to take up this platform, not the edited version that keeps the soul and discards the body, but the whole of it, the dangerous whole that nearly got him killed in his own hometown before his ministry had barely begun. He found the place in the scroll on purpose. The least we can do is stop reading past it.

CHAPTER TEN

Justice Is Not a Political Category

THE OBJECTION COMES EARLY and it comes often, and I have heard it from people I love and respect, people who genuinely fear that the church is being captured by something foreign to the gospel. The objection is this: justice is a political category, and when the church takes up justice it is abandoning its true spiritual mission for a worldly political program, trading the gospel for activism, the cross for a cause. Stick to the gospel, the objection says. Preach Christ crucified. Save souls. Leave justice to the politicians and the activists, because justice is their territory, the territory of the left or the right, the territory of partisan struggle, and the moment the church enters that territory it has compromised its witness and confused its mission. I want to take this objection seriously, because it is sincere and because it contains a real fear that is sometimes justified. And then I want to show you why it rests on a mistake so fundamental that, once you see it, the whole objection collapses.

The mistake is the assumption that justice is first of all a

political category. It is not. Justice is first of all a theological category, a category that belongs to God before it belongs to any government or party or movement, a category rooted in the very character and being of God himself. The politicians did not invent justice. The activists did not invent justice. God is just, justice flows from his nature, it is one of the foundational attributes of his character, and human politics is at best a faint and corrupted echo of a justice that originates in heaven. When the Bible says that righteousness and justice are the foundation of God's throne, it is not making a political statement. It is making a statement about the structure of reality, about what holds up the rule of God over the universe. Justice is not borrowed by the church from politics. Justice belongs to God, and politics, when it does justice at all, is borrowing from him. To say that the church should stay out of justice because justice is political is exactly backward. It is like saying the church should stay out of love because love is a Hallmark category. The greeting cards did not invent love. The politicians did not invent justice. Both belong to God, and the church abandons them to the world's counterfeits at the cost of its own soul.

*Justice did not come up from politics
into religion. It came down from the
character of God into a world that
keeps making cheap copies of it.*

HERE IS WHY THE confusion happens, and it is worth understanding. In a polarized society, every issue gets sorted

into a political team, and once an issue has been sorted, it becomes nearly impossible to discuss it on any terms other than the team's. Justice, in particular concern for the poor and the oppressed, has been sorted, in the American context, onto one political team, the left, so that the moment a pastor preaches about the poor, half the congregation hears a political signal, hears the team, and reacts to the team rather than to the text. And the other half, hearing the same signal, claps for the team and misses the text in the opposite direction. Both halves have made the same error. Both have assumed that justice is a political category, the property of a team, when in fact justice is a biblical category that the teams have each grabbed a piece of and distorted. The left grabbed the structural concern for the oppressed and cut it loose from God and from personal righteousness, producing a justice that is real in its concern but godless and merciless in its execution. The right grabbed personal righteousness and individual responsibility and cut them loose from the structural concern for the oppressed, producing a piety that is real in its morality but blind and self-justifying in its comfort. Each team has half the biblical vision and treats its half as the whole, and the church, captured by the teams, has lost the ability to speak the whole because the whole no longer belongs to any team.

This is why I insist, throughout this book, that biblical justice is not partisan, and I insist on it not as a clever evasion but as a theological necessity. The justice of the prophets indicts the left and the right with equal force, because the prophets were not running for anyone's office and were not members of anyone's team. Amos thundered against the economic exploitation of the poor, which sounds like the left. Amos also thundered against the moral corruption and the

abandonment of God's law, which sounds like the right. Isaiah demanded justice for the oppressed and also called the people to personal holiness and repentance. The prophets held together what our politics tears apart, the structural and the personal, the demand for justice and the demand for righteousness, *mishpat* and *tsedaqah*, and they held them together because they came from a God who is both perfectly just and perfectly holy, who hates oppression and hates idolatry, who defends the poor and demands purity, all at once, without contradiction. A church that recovers prophetic justice will be homeless in our politics. It will be too concerned with the poor for one team and too concerned with righteousness for the other, too structural for the right and too personal for the left, and that homelessness is not a failure. It is the sign that the church is finally speaking from somewhere other than a team, from the character of God rather than the platform of a party.

Now I have to be honest about the real danger the objection is pointing at, because the fear is not entirely groundless. There is a way for the church to take up justice that does abandon the gospel, that does trade Christ for a cause, that does become merely a religious wing of a political movement, baptizing a partisan program and calling it the kingdom of God. This is a real failure, and I have seen it, and I will indict it later in this book as forcefully as I indict the privatized gospel, because justice cut loose from God and from the cross becomes an ideology, and an ideology is a hungry god that devours its own. So the objection is not foolish. There is a real way to lose the gospel by politicizing justice. But the answer to that danger is not to abandon justice to the politicians. The answer is to recover justice as what it actually is, a theological category rooted in the

character of God, held together with personal righteousness, submitted to the lordship of Christ and the authority of Scripture, and therefore captive to no party and serving no team. The answer to bad theology of justice is not no theology of justice. It is good theology of justice. And good theology of justice begins exactly where this chapter began, with the recognition that justice belongs to God before it belongs to anyone else, and that the church which abandons it has not protected the gospel but amputated it.

I confess that for years I used the political objection as a shield, and I suspect many pastors do, because it is such a respectable shield. I told myself and my people that I was keeping the church focused on the gospel by staying away from justice, that I was protecting our spiritual mission from political contamination, and it sounded so principled, so faithful, so wise. What it actually was, underneath the principle, was cowardice and comfort. Staying away from justice kept my congregation comfortable, kept the giving steady, kept the difficult people from leaving, kept me from having to risk anything or lose anyone or be misunderstood. The political objection was the theological cover for a decision I had already made on other grounds, the decision to keep the peace and keep the doors open and keep the dangerous half of the gospel safely shelved. And I dressed that cowardice in the language of protecting the gospel, which is the most sophisticated cowardice there is, the cowardice that quotes Scripture in defense of its own silence. I was not protecting the gospel. I was protecting myself, and using the gospel to do it.

So when someone tells you that justice is political and the church should stay out of it, you can answer them now, gently but without retreating. Justice is not first political. It is

theological. It belongs to God, it flows from his character, it is the foundation of his throne, and the politicians and the activists who have grabbed pieces of it are working with stolen and broken fragments of something that came down from heaven. The church does not enter foreign territory when it takes up justice. It returns to its own home, the home it abandoned when it let the world's teams divide up what belonged to God. Yes, there is a danger of politicizing it, and we will guard against that danger with everything we have. But the greater danger, the danger we have actually fallen into, is not that we politicized justice. It is that we abandoned it, handed it over to the teams, and then quoted the gospel to justify the surrender. Justice is not a political category. It is the character of God. And a church that will not preach the character of God for fear of sounding political has already decided that the approval of its team matters more than the truth of its Lord.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

Personal Sin and Systemic Sin

WE ARE VERY GOOD at one kind of sin and almost blind to the other, and the blindness is not accidental. The church, especially the evangelical church I come from, has a richly developed theology of personal sin. We know that the human heart is corrupt, that we are sinners by nature and by choice, that every individual stands guilty before God and needs the blood of Christ to be cleansed. We can preach personal sin in our sleep. The lust, the greed, the pride, the lie, the private failures of the individual soul, we have named and confessed and prayed over for generations, and rightly, because personal sin is real and the gospel is the only answer to it. But there is another category of sin that runs all through the Bible, a category we have largely refused to see, and that is systemic sin, structural sin, the sin that is built into the arrangements and institutions and systems of a society, the sin that no single individual chose and yet everyone participates in, the sin that does its damage not through one wicked heart but through a thousand ordinary decisions that

add up to oppression. We can see the sin in the man. We cannot, or will not, see the sin in the system. And that selective blindness is one of the great failures of the modern church.

The Bible has no such blindness. The prophets denounce not only wicked individuals but wicked systems, corrupt courts, rigged markets, oppressive laws, structures of exploitation that grind the poor whether or not any particular participant feels malicious about it. Isaiah cries woe to those who decree iniquitous decrees and write oppression. Decrees and writing, that is legislation, that is law, that is structure. The sin is in the decree, in the law itself, in the system that has been set up to rob the poor of their rights and make the widow their prey. Amos denounces the merchants who make the ephah small and the shekel great, who use false balances, but he is describing not just individual cheaters but an entire commercial system organized around the exploitation of the poor, a market culture in which the cheating is normal, expected, built in. The prophets understood that sin is not only personal. It accumulates into structures. It hardens into institutions. It writes itself into laws and markets and customs, and once it has, it does its damage automatically, without requiring any individual to be especially wicked, because the wickedness is in the machine, and ordinary people simply operate the machine.

*Sin does not stay in the heart. It
hardens into systems, writes itself into
laws, and goes on crushing people long*

after the men who built it are dead.

LET ME GIVE THE clearest biblical example, because it cuts through the abstraction. When the prophets denounce the moving of boundary stones, they are describing a practice by which a powerful landowner would, over time, gradually shift the stone markers that defined property lines, encroaching on a poor neighbor's field, stealing land an inch at a time. Now, each individual act of moving a stone is a personal sin, a particular man choosing to steal. But the prophets are describing something larger, a whole social pattern, a system in which the powerful routinely dispossess the weak, in which the courts that should stop it are bribed, in which the law that should protect the poor man's boundary has been bent to serve the rich man's greed, in which the accumulation of land in fewer and fewer hands has become the normal operation of the economy. Isaiah's woe to those who join house to house and field to field is not about one greedy man. It is about a systemic trajectory, a structural concentration, a whole society organized in such a way that the poor are steadily ground out of their land and into debt and dependence. The sin is personal at every point and systemic in its totality, and the prophets denounce both, the wicked individual and the wicked system, without ever pretending that naming the one excuses the other.

Here is where our blindness does its real damage, because the refusal to see systemic sin is not neutral. It protects the people who benefit from the system. If sin is only personal, then the only question I ever have to ask is whether I, personally, in my own heart, harbor malice toward the poor or the outsider. And if I do not, if I am a decent person who

wishes everyone well and would never personally cheat anyone, then I am off the hook entirely, no matter how much I benefit from a system that is cheating people on a massive scale. The privatized doctrine of sin gives the comfortable a permanent alibi. I did not personally redline that neighborhood. I did not personally write that predatory loan. I did not personally do anything wrong, and my heart is clean, and therefore the suffering of the people crushed by systems I benefit from is none of my concern and certainly not my sin. This is the great escape that a purely personal theology of sin provides, and it is precisely why the comfortable church loves it and clings to it. It lets us benefit from injustice while feeling innocent of it, because we have defined sin in such a way that only the personal and the malicious counts, and the structural and the beneficial does not. We did this. I did this. I taught people a doctrine of sin that left them innocent of the very systems that fed them.

But I have to be just as hard on the opposite error, because the secular justice movements have made it, and it is just as deadly in the other direction. If the church's error is to see only personal sin and never systemic sin, the secular activist's error is to see only systemic sin and never personal sin, to locate all evil in the structures and none in the human heart, to imagine that if we could only fix the systems, redistribute the power, tear down the oppressive institutions, then human beings would be good, because human beings are basically good and only the systems corrupt them. This is a lie as old as Eden and just as destructive. It produces revolutions that overthrow one oppressive system and build a worse one, because the revolutionaries forgot that the corruption was not only in the system they tore down but in the human hearts that did the tearing, including their own.

The Bible will not let you locate evil only in the structures, because the Bible knows that structures are built by people and operated by people and that the corruption in the structure is the corruption in the heart, multiplied and hardened and institutionalized. Personal sin and systemic sin are not rivals. They are the same corruption at two scales, the corruption of the individual heart and the corruption of the collective arrangement, and any honest account of evil has to name both.

The biblical genius is that it holds both together, and holding both together is exactly what neither of our political teams can do. The church needs to recover the systemic half of the doctrine of sin that it lost, to learn to see, as the prophets saw, the sin that is built into laws and markets and customs, the oppression that operates through structure and not only through individual malice, the way that ordinary people benefit from and participate in collective evil they did not personally author. And the church needs to hold onto the personal half it has always had, the conviction that the human heart is corrupt, that no system can save us because the corruption is in us, that even the most just structure will be bent toward evil by the sinners who run it, that the final hope is not a perfect system but a redeemed heart in a redeemed people under a redeemed Lord. Both. Always both. The man who sees only personal sin will tend the soul and ignore the structure that is crushing the soul's neighbor. The man who sees only systemic sin will tear down structures while his own heart goes unexamined and unredeemed. The prophets saw both. Jesus saw both. He went to the cross to deal with the corruption of the human heart, and he announced a kingdom that overturns the structures of oppression, and he held them together in a single gospel, the

gospel we have spent so long pulling apart.

So we have to repent of our blindness, and I mean repent in the full sense, a turning, not just an admission. The church I serve has to learn to confess not only the personal sins of its members but the systemic sins of the society it inhabits and benefits from, to say, as the great prayers of confession in Scripture say, we have sinned, we and our fathers, naming the collective and inherited and structural evil as our own and not only the private failures of the individual heart. This is hard, because it offends the doctrine of innocence that the comfortable church has built. It offends the man who has never personally cheated anyone and does not see why he should confess a sin he did not commit. But the great confessions of Scripture, Daniel confessing the sins of his people, Nehemiah confessing the sins of his fathers, do exactly this, take the collective and structural and inherited sin upon themselves, own it, repent of it, even when they did not personally author it. That is the model. Not the personal alibi that says my heart is clean so the system is not my concern, but the prophetic confession that says we have sinned, we and our fathers, the personal and the systemic together, all of it ours, all of it needing the mercy of God. We did this. I did this. And the first step back is to stop pretending that a clean private heart makes us innocent of the systems we feed on.

CHAPTER TWELVE

Charity Treats the Symptom, Justice Treats the Cause

THE CHURCH LOVES CHARITY and fears justice, and the reason is that charity leaves us in control and justice does not. This is the distinction that, once you see it, you cannot unsee, and it explains more about the failures of the modern church than almost anything else. Charity is the response to a symptom. It addresses the immediate suffering of the person in front of you, the hunger, the cold, the immediate lack, and it is good, it is necessary, the Bible commands it, and I am not against it for a single moment. But charity, by itself, never asks why the person is hungry, never touches the cause, never disturbs the arrangement that keeps producing hungry people. Justice is the response to a cause. It asks why, it looks upstream, it addresses the structure that is generating the suffering, and it works to change the arrangement so that fewer people end up hungry in the first place. Charity hands the drowning man a rope. Justice walks upstream to find out

who keeps throwing people in the river. We have become a church of ropes that will not walk upstream, and the reason we will not walk upstream is that upstream is where the powerful are, and the powerful might be us.

Consider the difference with a clear example. A church runs a food pantry, and every week hundreds of families come and receive groceries, and they are genuinely helped, and their children eat who would otherwise go hungry, and this is a real good and I bless it. That is charity. Now suppose someone in the church begins to ask why these hundreds of families are hungry in the first place, in a wealthy country, in a wealthy region. And the asking leads to uncomfortable answers, that wages in the area have not kept pace with rent, that a major employer pays so little that full-time workers qualify for food assistance, that the cost of housing has been driven up by forces that profit from it, that the families are not hungry because they are lazy but because the arrangement of the local economy guarantees that a certain number of working people cannot afford to eat. And suppose the church begins to act on those answers, to advocate, to organize, to press the employer and the landlords and the local powers, to address the cause. That is justice. And here is what you will find: the food pantry will be praised by everyone, and the justice work will make people furious. The same community that celebrates the charity will resist the justice, because the charity asks nothing of the powerful while the justice asks the powerful to change, and the powerful would much rather you keep handing out ropes than ask who is throwing people in the river.

*Charity is safe because it never names
the cause. Justice is dangerous because
it does, and the cause usually has a
name, an address, and a stake in
keeping you handing out ropes.*

THIS IS WHY THE church has so consistently chosen charity over justice, and I want to name the choice as the choice it is, because we have hidden it from ourselves. We chose charity because charity is safe and justice is costly. Charity makes us feel good and asks nothing of our position. We can run the food drive, fill the boxes, feel the warmth of giving, take the photographs, and go home to a comfortable life entirely undisturbed, because charity never once questions the arrangement that made our comfort and their need two sides of the same economy. Justice questions exactly that. Justice asks whether our comfort and their need are connected, whether the cheap goods we enjoy depend on the cheap labor that keeps them poor, whether the neighborhood we fled and the neighborhood we fled to are linked by a history of decisions that benefited us and cost them. Charity lets us be benefactors. Justice asks whether we are beneficiaries, beneficiaries of the very injustice we are charitably patching. And no one wants to ask that question, least of all a comfortable church full of comfortable people who would genuinely like to help as long as helping does not require them to examine the source of their comfort. So we chose charity. We chose the rope and refused the walk upstream,

and we called it generosity, and it was, but it was also a way of not asking the question we were afraid to answer.

I have to be careful here, because there is a way to read this chapter as a dismissal of charity, and that is not what I am saying, and the prophets would not say it either. Charity is necessary. The man bleeding in the road needs his wounds bound now, today, not after we have reformed the highway patrol. The hungry child needs to eat tonight, not after we have restructured the regional economy. To refuse charity in the name of justice is its own kind of cruelty, a willingness to let people suffer in the present for the sake of a structural change in the future, and the secular justice movements sometimes fall into exactly this hardness, despising the soup kitchen as a mere palliative while real people go hungry waiting for the revolution. No. Bind the wounds. Feed the child. Run the pantry. Charity is not the enemy of justice. The enemy is charity that pretends to be the whole answer, charity that is used as a substitute for justice, charity that lets us feel we have responded to suffering while leaving its causes entirely untouched. The problem is not that we do charity. The problem is that we do only charity, that we have made charity the ceiling of our response when the Bible makes it the floor, that we hand out ropes forever and never once walk upstream, and call the rope-handing the fullness of our obedience.

The Good Samaritan, whom I will turn to in the next chapter, is usually read as the great parable of charity, and it is. The Samaritan binds the wounds of the man left for dead, pays for his care, does everything charity asks and more. But notice what the parable assumes and what it leaves open. The road from Jerusalem to Jericho was notorious, a known

danger, a place where robbery and violence were so common that the road itself had a reputation. The Samaritan did the work of charity beautifully. And the parable, by naming the road, quietly raises the question that charity alone never answers: what about the road. The Samaritan saved one man on one day, and the road went on producing victims, day after day, because the road itself was the problem, the conditions on the road, the lack of safety, the structure that made robbery routine. Charity is the Samaritan binding the wounds. Justice is asking what it would take to make the road safe, so that there are fewer bleeding men in the ditch tomorrow. The parable commands the charity and leaves the road open as a question, and the church has answered the charity for two thousand years and almost never asked about the road, and the road is still producing victims, and we are still binding wounds, one at a time, forever, because we will not ask the upstream question that might require us to change the road and the people who profit from leaving it dangerous.

So the call of this chapter is not to stop the charity but to refuse to let the charity be the end. Bind the wounds and ask about the road. Run the food pantry and ask why the families are hungry. Hand the rope to the drowning man and then, with the same conviction, walk upstream and find out who keeps throwing people in the river, and confront them, even if they turn out to be people you know, people you do business with, people in your own pews, people who look in the mirror and find you looking back. That last possibility is the one that keeps us downstream, handing out ropes, refusing the walk. Because when you walk far enough upstream, you sometimes find that the person throwing people in the river is wearing your own face, benefiting from an arrangement that costs

others their lives, and that is a discovery the comfortable church will do almost anything to avoid, including an endless, sincere, photographed, celebrated ministry of ropes. Charity treats the symptom. Justice treats the cause. God commands both, the floor and the work above it, and a church that has settled for the floor and called it the building has not been generous. It has been afraid, and it has dressed the fear in the clothes of charity, and the river runs on.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

The Good Samaritan and the Road That Needs Fixing

A LAWYER ASKED JESUS a question to justify himself, which is how most of our questions about justice begin, as attempts to limit the demand. He had agreed that the law commanded love of God and love of neighbor, and then, wanting to draw a boundary around the obligation, he asked the question that has echoed ever since: and who is my neighbor. It is a lawyer's question, a question designed to define the limits of duty, to establish who is in and who is out, to find the edge of the obligation so he could be sure he had met it. If I know exactly who my neighbor is, then I know exactly who my neighbor is not, and I am free of any duty toward the ones outside the line. And Jesus, instead of answering the question, told a story that destroyed the question, that made the boundary the lawyer was trying to draw impossible to draw, and that has been read so many times in church that we have nearly drained it of the shock it

carried when it was first told.

A man was going down from Jerusalem to Jericho, and he fell among robbers, who stripped him and beat him and departed, leaving him half dead. The road from Jerusalem to Jericho was real, a steep and winding seventeen miles through desolate country, descending more than three thousand feet, full of rocky places where robbers could hide and ambush travelers, a road so notorious for violence that it had a grim nickname, the Way of Blood. Everyone listening to Jesus knew the road. They knew its danger. And so the scene was not abstract. It was a specific, infamous stretch of highway where this kind of thing happened all the time, where men were regularly left half dead in the ditch, where the violence was not an aberration but a feature, a known and tolerated condition of that particular road. Hold onto the road, because the road is the part we skip.

*The Samaritan saved one man on the
Way of Blood. The road went on killing.
Charity bound the wounds. Nobody
fixed the road.*

A PRIEST CAME DOWN that road, and when he saw the man, he passed by on the other side. And a Levite likewise, when he came to the place and saw him, passed by on the other side. The two religious professionals, the very people whose whole life was supposedly devoted to God, saw the broken man and crossed to the far side of the road to avoid him. We have speculated endlessly about their reasons, ritual purity, fear of

the robbers, the inconvenience, the danger of stopping on a road famous for ambush, and Jesus gives us none of these reasons, because the reasons do not matter. What matters is that the men whose religion should have moved them toward the suffering man moved them away from him, that their piety and their position made them more able, not less, to pass by, and that this is the indictment Jesus is laying at the feet of the religious establishment of his day, and at the feet of every religious establishment since, including mine. The professionally religious passed by. The men with the right theology and the right credentials and the right place in the religious system crossed to the other side. That is the picture Jesus paints of religion without mercy, and it is a picture of the church far more often than we would like to admit.

And then the Samaritan, and we have so domesticated this word that we cannot feel its scandal. To Jesus' audience, the Samaritan was the enemy, the heretic, the despised half-breed, the people the Jews would not eat with or speak to or touch, the people whose very name was a slur. When Jesus made the Samaritan the hero of the story, the one who did what the priest and the Levite would not, he was not telling a heartwarming tale about a nice helpful stranger. He was taking the most despised outsider his audience could imagine and making him the moral exemplar, the one who fulfilled the law that the religious insiders had failed, the one who loved the neighbor while the professionals passed by. It would be like telling this story today and making the hero the member of the group your congregation most fears and despises, whoever that is, the immigrant, the addict, the person on the other side of the political war, the one you have been taught to see as the enemy. That is the Samaritan. And he is the one who had compassion, who came to the man,

who bound up his wounds, pouring on oil and wine, who set him on his own animal and brought him to an inn and took care of him, who paid the innkeeper and promised to cover whatever more it cost. The despised outsider did the work of love that the religious insiders refused. That is the parable, and it answers the lawyer's question by demolishing it. Who is my neighbor. Wrong question. The question is, will you be a neighbor, to anyone, even the man in the ditch, even when you are the despised one and he is not yours.

But I want to come back to the road, because the road is the part the church almost never preaches, and it is the part that turns this parable from a charity story into a justice story. The Samaritan did everything right. He is the model of compassion, of personal mercy, of charity in its highest form. And yet, when he rode away from that inn, the road was exactly as dangerous as it had been the day before. The Way of Blood was still the Way of Blood. Tomorrow another traveler would be stripped and beaten and left half dead in the same ditch, and the day after that another, because the road itself, the conditions on the road, the structural violence of that particular stretch of highway, was completely untouched by the Samaritan's mercy. He saved one man. He could not save the road. And the parable, by naming the road so specifically, by setting the whole story on a highway famous for exactly this kind of violence, raises the question it does not answer: what about the road. What would it take to make the road safe. Who is responsible for a road that produces victims day after day. Is there a form of love that goes beyond binding the wounds of today's victim to addressing the road that guarantees tomorrow's. The parable commands the charity of the Samaritan and leaves the justice of the road as an open wound, and the church has bound

wounds for two thousand years and almost never asked about the road.

Here is the fullness the church keeps cutting in half. The Good Samaritan is the great parable of charity, and we have preached it as such forever, and we should, because the personal mercy it commands is real and binding and we fail it constantly, crossing to the other side of a thousand roads every day. But the road is the great unpreached question of justice, the question of the structure that keeps producing victims, the conditions that guarantee that for every man the Samaritan saves, another will be in the ditch tomorrow. And a complete obedience to this parable would do both, would have the heart of the Samaritan toward the man in the ditch today and the mind of a reformer toward the road that put him there, would bind the wound and ask about the Way of Blood, would refuse to choose between the mercy that saves the one and the justice that might save the many. The church chose the mercy and ignored the road. The secular activist sometimes chooses the road and despises the mercy, marching for the highway reform while stepping over the actual bleeding man in the actual ditch. Both have half the parable. Jesus gave us the whole, the Samaritan and the road, the compassion for the victim and the open question about the violence that made him one, and a church that recovers prophetic justice will finally do what we have avoided for two millennia. It will bind the wounds and fix the road. It will be the Samaritan and ask his unasked question. It will love the neighbor in the ditch and refuse to leave the Way of Blood the way of blood.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

The Black Church and the Long Memory of Justice

IF YOU WANT TO see what it looks like when the church refuses to privatize the gospel, when it holds together the personal salvation of the soul and the public demand for justice, when it reads the Exodus as a real liberation and the prophets as a living word, you do not have to imagine it. It existed, and it exists, in the Black church in America, and any honest account of prophetic justice in this country has to sit at its feet and learn. While the white church I come from was busy privatizing the gospel, spiritualizing the Exodus, and using Scripture to justify or ignore the oppression of an entire people, the Black church was reading the same Bible and finding in it exactly what the prophets put there, a God who hears the cry of the oppressed and comes down, a God of justice and not only of private piety, a gospel that saves the soul and also demands the liberation of the body. They read the Bible we handed them, often the same English

translation, and they found the justice we had managed to read past, because they were standing in a place, the place of the oppressed, where the justice of God is most clearly visible, the place the prophets always wrote from and the place the comfortable church can never quite see from.

Consider the history, and you have to start before the proximate cause, because the Black church's prophetic tradition did not begin in the 1950s, it began in the hold of a slave ship and the brush arbors of the plantation, where enslaved people gathered in secret to worship a God their masters claimed but did not know. The enslaved heard the gospel preached to them as a tool of submission, a gospel that said slaves obey your masters and promised them a heaven that conveniently required them to accept their hell on earth. And they took that gospel, that deliberately privatized and pacifying gospel handed to them by enslavers, and they read past the slaveholder's edits to the actual Bible underneath, and in the actual Bible they found Moses and Pharaoh, they found let my people go, they found a God who drowned the army of the oppressor in the sea, they found the very Exodus the white church had spiritualized into harmlessness, and they read it as what it was, the story of a God who liberates slaves. The spirituals are full of it. Go down Moses. Steal away. Deep river, my home is over Jordan. The enslaved church understood the Bible better than the church that enslaved them, because they read it from the place of the oppressed, and from that place the justice of God is not hidden. It is the whole point.

The enslaved read the same Bible their masters used to justify the chains, and they found Moses, and Pharaoh, and a God who drowns oppression in the sea. They understood the book better than the men who owned them.

AND SO WHEN THE movement came, when Rosa Parks refused to give up her seat in Montgomery in December of 1955 and the bus boycott began and a young pastor named Martin Luther King Jr. was thrust into leadership, it did not come out of nowhere, and it did not come out of secular politics. It came out of the church, out of the Black church and its long prophetic memory, out of a tradition that had been reading the Exodus and the prophets as a living word for two hundred years. King was a preacher before he was anything else, the son and grandson of preachers, steeped in the Black church's reading of Scripture, and when he spoke, he spoke as a prophet in the biblical tradition, quoting Amos, let justice roll down like waters and righteousness like an ever-flowing stream, the very verse at the head of this book, quoting Isaiah, every valley shall be exalted, grounding the entire movement not in a secular theory of rights but in the character and demand of God. The civil rights movement at its heart was a church movement, a prophetic movement, an application of mishpat and tsedaqah to the actual structures of American oppression, and it succeeded to the degree that it did precisely because it spoke from the deep well of biblical

justice that the Black church had kept alive while the white church had let it run dry.

I have to name what the white church did, because I am a white pastor and the indictment falls on my house, and naming it is part of the repentance. While the Black church was reading the Exodus as liberation, the white church was, by and large, either actively defending slavery and segregation with Scripture or standing silently by while it was defended. When King wrote his letter from the Birmingham jail in April of 1963, he wrote it not to the open enemies of the movement but to the white moderate clergy, the respectable pastors who had urged him to wait, to be patient, to not push so hard, who agreed with his goals but deplored his methods, who valued order over justice and the absence of tension over the presence of righteousness. King wrote that he had almost concluded that the great stumbling block in the stride toward freedom was not the open bigot but the white moderate, the one who preferred a negative peace which is the absence of tension to a positive peace which is the presence of justice. That was my house. That was the church I come from, the church of the white moderate who agreed in principle and opposed in practice, who quoted the gospel to counsel patience to people who had been waiting for three hundred years. The white church did not fail to understand the gospel of justice by accident. It failed because understanding it would have cost us a system we benefited from, and so we privatized the gospel precisely at the point where the public gospel would have indicted us, and we called our cowardice prudence and our complicity peace.

What the Black church preserved, and what the white church has to learn from it, is that there is no contradiction

between the salvation of the soul and the liberation of the body, between personal conversion and structural justice, between loving Jesus and doing mishpat. The Black church at its best held them together with a wholeness the white church lost. It preached the new birth and the freedom struggle in the same breath. It called individuals to personal holiness and called the nation to public righteousness. It sang about heaven and marched for earth. It understood, in a way the privatized white church never did, that the God who saves your soul is the same God who hears the cry of the oppressed, that the cross that reconciles you to God is the same cross that exposes and overturns the powers of injustice, that there is one gospel and it is for the whole person and the whole society, body and soul, individual and structure, now and forever. This is not a different gospel from the gospel of personal salvation. It is the full gospel that personal salvation was always part of, the gospel the prophets preached and Jesus announced in Nazareth, the gospel the Black church kept alive in this country while the white church traded it for a privatized counterfeit that left our comfort undisturbed.

So this chapter is a confession before it is anything else. The tradition of prophetic justice in America did not survive because of my church. It survived in spite of my church, kept alive by the very people my church oppressed and ignored, read out of the very Bible my church handed them as a tool of submission and then read better than we ever did. If I want to learn what mishpat and tsedaqah look like when they are taken seriously, when the Exodus is read as liberation and the prophets as a living word and Jesus' Nazareth platform as a real mission, I do not look first to my own tradition, which privatized all of it. I look to the Black church, which preserved all of it, at enormous cost, under enormous pressure, with a

faithfulness that puts mine to shame. The long memory of justice in this country is largely their memory, kept when we forgot, sung when we were silent, marched when we counseled patience. And the least the white church can do, having spent so long on the wrong side of this history, is to stop pretending we have nothing to learn, to sit down at the feet of the tradition we ignored, and to confess that the gospel of justice we are only now rediscovering was never lost. We lost it. They kept it. And they have been waiting a very long time for us to come and learn what we threw away.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

Color-Blindness Is Not a Theological Virtue

THERE IS A PHRASE that sounds like righteousness and functions like an evasion, and the church has embraced it precisely because it allows us to feel virtuous while changing nothing. The phrase is color-blindness, the claim that the truly Christian posture is to not see color at all, to treat everyone exactly the same, to refuse all racial categories as though refusing to see them were the same as healing the wounds they have caused. It sounds so good. It sounds like the dream itself, like the content of character over the color of skin, like the very thing the movement fought for. And it has become, in much of the white church, the settled and self-satisfied answer to every question of racial justice: I do not see color, we are all one in Christ, the past is the past, let us move forward as though the categories do not exist. I want to show you why this sounds like a theological virtue and is actually a theological evasion, why a faith that claims not to see what God plainly sees is not transcending the problem but hiding from it.

Start with the Bible, because the Bible is not color-blind, and the heaven it describes is not color-blind either. When John sees the final vision of the redeemed in the book of Revelation, he does not see a uniform mass of indistinguishable humanity with all distinction erased. He sees a great multitude that no one could number, from every nation and tribe and people and language, standing before the throne. Every nation, tribe, people, and language. The distinctions are not erased in the consummation. They are gathered, redeemed, brought into harmony, but they are still there, still visible, still named, every tribe and tongue. God does not save us by making us all the same. He saves us in our particularity, and the final picture of redemption is not a colorless uniformity but a gathered diversity, every people present and recognizable and praising God in their own tongue. A faith that aspires to not see the very distinctions that God himself sees and gathers and redeems is not aspiring to the biblical vision. It is aspiring to an erasure that the Bible never asks for, an erasure that, conveniently, allows the people in power to avoid reckoning with what the distinctions have meant in history.

*God is not color-blind. He sees every
tribe and tongue and gathers them. A
church that claims not to see what God
plainly sees is not transcending the
wound. It is refusing to look at it.*

HERE IS THE DEEPER problem with color-blindness, and it is a problem of justice, not just of theology. To say I do not see color, when color has been the basis of three hundred years of systematic oppression, is to refuse to see the very thing that justice requires you to see. Mishpat, remember, has its eyes wide open. It looks at the widow, the orphan, the stranger, the specific people who have been specifically wronged. It does not avert its gaze and claim a virtuous blindness. It looks directly at the wrong and at the people who suffered it, and it acts. To be color-blind in a society shaped by centuries of racial injustice is to refuse to see the wound, and you cannot heal a wound you refuse to see. The injuries done on the basis of color do not become healed when we stop naming color. They become invisible, unaddressed, allowed to continue under the cover of a false equality that exists in our rhetoric and not in our reality. Color-blindness treats the present as though it were disconnected from the past, as though we could simply declare ourselves equal now and have the accumulated weight of history vanish, as though the wealth built on stolen labor and the neighborhoods shaped by deliberate exclusion and the gaps in every measure of well-being would simply evaporate the moment we agreed to stop noticing them. They do not evaporate. They compound. And color-blindness is the doctrine that lets the people who benefit from the compounding avoid ever having to account for it.

I want to be careful and fair, because there is a real truth that color-blindness is grasping at, and the secular alternative has its own deep dangers. The truth color-blindness grasps is that our final identity is in Christ, that in Christ there is neither Jew nor Greek, that the deepest thing about a believer is not their ethnicity but their union with

Christ and their membership in his body. This is gloriously true, and any account of racial justice that makes ethnic identity ultimate, that turns race into the deepest and final truth about a person, that builds a permanent politics of racial grievance with no hope of reconciliation, has fallen into an error every bit as serious as color-blindness, an error that makes an idol of the very distinctions God means to gather and heal. The secular justice movements often fall exactly here, into a racial essentialism that is the mirror image of racism, that cannot imagine a future beyond the categories, that has no gospel of reconciliation because it has no cross. I am not commending that. The biblical vision is neither the erasure of color-blindness nor the absolutization of racial identity. It is the redemption of difference, difference fully seen, fully named, the wrongs fully reckoned with, and then difference gathered into a reconciled body where every tribe and tongue stands together before the throne, not erased and not idolized, but redeemed.

And this brings me to the heart of the matter, the thing the white church most wants to avoid, which is repentance. Because you cannot get from the wound to the reconciliation without passing through repentance, and color-blindness is, at bottom, a way of skipping repentance. It says let us move forward as equals without ever saying what was done, who did it, who benefited, and what is owed. It wants the reconciliation without the reckoning, the harmony without the confession, the new creation without the death that always precedes resurrection. And there is no such path. The gospel itself does not work that way. There is no reconciliation with God that skips the confession of sin, no resurrection that skips the cross, no cheap grace that declares peace without the costly naming and bearing of the

wrong. Bonhoeffer named cheap grace as the deadly enemy of the church, grace without discipleship, grace without the cross, grace as a doctrine we possess rather than a costly gift we receive in repentance. Racial reconciliation without repentance is cheap grace applied to the deepest wound in this nation's history. It is branding. It is the appearance of unity purchased by the refusal to name the cost, and it is precisely the kind of thing the prophets despised, peace, peace, they cried, when there is no peace, healing the wound of my people lightly, crying peace where there is no peace because the wound underneath was never cleaned.

So I have to confess, as a white pastor, that color-blindness was for years my comfortable doctrine, and it was comfortable precisely because it asked nothing of me. I could declare that I did not see color, that we were all one in Christ, that I treated everyone the same, and in declaring it I could exempt myself entirely from the work of seeing the wound, naming the history, reckoning with what I had inherited and benefited from, repenting of what my own house had done and left undone. Color-blindness let me feel righteous about my refusal to look. And it was a refusal to look, dressed up as a refusal to discriminate, and the difference between those two things is the difference between healing and hiding. The justice of God does not avert its eyes. It looks directly at the wound, names it, and moves to set it right. A church that wants the reconciliation of every tribe and tongue gathered before the throne has to be willing to do what gets us there, which is not the pretense that the distinctions do not exist, but the hard, particular, costly work of seeing the wound fully, naming the wrong honestly, repenting where repentance is owed, and only then, on the far side of that reckoning, reaching for a reconciliation that is real because it was

COLOR-BLINDNESS IS NOT A THEOLOGICAL VIRTUE

bought with truth and not with the cheap currency of a virtue that exists only to let us avoid looking at what we would rather not see.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

The Church's Wealth and the World's Poverty

THERE IS A FACT that sits at the center of the church's life and that we have arranged our entire spiritual existence to avoid confronting, and it is this: the church, especially in the wealthy West, is rich, and the world is poor, and the Bible has an enormous amount to say about that gap, almost none of it comfortable. We have built a thousand strategies for not hearing what Scripture says about wealth and poverty, spiritualizing the poor until they are only the poor in spirit, reading the rich young ruler as a special case rather than a pattern, treating the constant biblical drumbeat about money as somehow less binding than the verses about personal morality. But the drumbeat is there, and it is relentless, and it is one of the most consistent themes in the entire Bible. There are more verses about money and possessions and the poor than about almost any other subject, more than about heaven, more than about prayer, more than about sexuality, and yet we have managed to build churches that talk constantly about the few and barely whisper about the many.

The selectivity is the confession. We talk about what does not threaten us and fall silent about what does.

Consider what Jesus actually said about wealth, stripped of our domestications. He said it is hard for a rich man to enter the kingdom of heaven, so hard that it is easier for a camel to go through the eye of a needle. He told a rich man to sell all that he had and give it to the poor, and when the man went away sorrowful, Jesus did not run after him to clarify that he had only meant it spiritually, he let him go and said how difficult it is for those who have wealth to enter the kingdom. He told a parable about a rich man who feasted while a poor man named Lazarus starved at his gate covered in sores, and in the parable the rich man ends in torment and Lazarus in comfort, and the rich man's crime was not active cruelty but simply that he feasted while a poor man starved at his gate and he did nothing, he did not even see him, the poverty at his own door was invisible to him because he had arranged his life so that it could be. He warned you cannot serve God and money, naming money, mammon, as a rival god, a competing lord, a power that claims the worship that belongs to God alone. This is not a marginal theme in the teaching of Jesus. It is central, constant, and almost uniformly uncomfortable for the wealthy, which is to say, for us.

A poor man starved at the rich man's gate, and the rich man's sin was not cruelty. It was that he had arranged his life so he never had to see him. We

*have built whole churches with the gate
on the far side.*

THE EARLY CHURCH HEARD this and did something about it that we have spent two thousand years explaining away. In the book of Acts, the believers in Jerusalem held their possessions in common, sold their property and goods and distributed to anyone who had need, so that, the text says, there was not a needy person among them. There was not a needy person among them. That sentence should stop us cold, because it is an echo of the law of Moses, which promised that if Israel kept the commandments there would be no poor among them, and here in Acts the promise is fulfilled, not by a government program but by a community of believers who held their wealth so loosely that the needs of the poor among them were simply met, as a matter of course, because no one claimed that what they had was theirs alone. We have explained this away as a temporary arrangement, a special circumstance, an idealistic experiment that did not last and was never meant to be normative. And perhaps the specific form was particular to that moment. But the underlying conviction, that the wealth of the believers belonged in some real sense to the needs of the poor among them, that you could not hold your abundance tight while your brother went without, that the gap between the church's wealth and the world's poverty was an intolerable contradiction of the gospel, that conviction is not temporary. It is the conviction of the whole Bible, and we have explained it away because living by it would cost us everything we have arranged our lives to keep.

I have to put the numbers in front of my own face, and yours, because abstraction is how we escape this. The church in the wealthy West controls staggering resources, buildings worth fortunes, budgets that run to millions, endowments, real estate, the accumulated wealth of generations of comfortable believers. And in the same world, at the same moment, hundreds of millions of people lack clean water, adequate food, basic medicine, the minimum conditions of a human life, and many of them are our brothers and sisters in Christ, members of the same body, the same church, separated from our abundance by nothing but distance and the arrangements we have made to keep the distance comfortable. The gap is not a regrettable feature of a fallen world that we can do nothing about. It is, in significant part, the direct contradiction of the gospel by the people who claim it, the rich man feasting while Lazarus starves at the gate, except that we have built the gate on the far side of the world so that we do not have to see him, and we have called our not-seeing innocence. The early church arranged its life so that there was not a needy person among them. We have arranged ours so that we never have to encounter the needy person at all, and we have mistaken the arrangement for righteousness.

Now I want to resist the cheap and partisan reading, because it comes quickly and it lets everyone off the hook in a different way. The point is not a political program of redistribution imposed by force, and it is not a guilt-driven hatred of all wealth as though money itself were evil, and it is not the prosperity gospel's grotesque inversion that treats wealth as the sign of God's favor and poverty as the sign of his absence. The Bible does not say money is evil. It says the love of money is a root of all kinds of evil, that wealth is a profound spiritual danger, that it is hard, desperately hard, for those

who have it to enter the kingdom, because wealth has a way of capturing the heart, of becoming the thing we actually trust, of insulating us from the God who is found among the poor and the desperate and the people who have nothing left to trust but him. The danger of wealth is not first economic. It is spiritual. It is that the rich man cannot see Lazarus at his gate, that the abundance has blinded him, that he has come to believe, without ever saying it, that his security rests in his possessions and not in God, and that this belief, which wealth makes almost irresistible, is idolatry, the worship of mammon, the rival god Jesus named. We are in spiritual danger, those of us who are rich, and the first sign of the danger is that we do not feel it, that we read these passages and feel no threat, that we have so thoroughly domesticated the Bible's word on wealth that the camel passes easily through the needle and we feel no strain at all.

So what does the church owe, holding the wealth it holds in a world of the poverty that exists. It owes, first, repentance, the honest confession that we have explained away the clear and constant teaching of Scripture because living by it would cost us our comfort, that we have built the gate on the far side of the world to keep from seeing Lazarus, that we have served mammon while claiming to serve God and have not even felt the contradiction. And it owes, second, a different way of holding what we have, a loosening of the grip, a recovery of the conviction that the wealth of the believers belongs in some real and costly sense to the needs of the poor, that we cannot feast in good conscience while our brothers and sisters starve, that the gap between the church's wealth and the world's poverty is not a fact to be managed but a sin to be repented and, as far as we are able, undone. This will cost us. It is meant to cost us. The whole point of the rich young ruler

is that the cost is real and that many of us, like him, will go away sorrowful, because we have great possessions and we love them more than we love the kingdom, and Jesus, in his terrible mercy, will let us go. The question this chapter leaves is not abstract. It is the oldest question Jesus ever put to a rich man. Will you sell what you have and give to the poor and follow me, or will you, like the man at the gate, feast on while Lazarus starves where you have arranged not to see him. He let the rich man walk away. He will let us walk away too. That is the weight of it, and I will not lift it, because Jesus did not.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

Economic Justice and the Poor as the Test

THE POOR ARE NOT a problem the church manages. The poor are the test the church takes, the place where it is revealed whether we know the God we claim, and the Bible says so with a directness that should make us tremble. He who oppresses the poor insults his Maker, says the book of Proverbs, but he who is generous to the needy honors him. Insults his Maker. Honors him. How you treat the poor is, according to Scripture, a direct statement about what you think of God, because the poor bear the image of the God who made them, and to crush them is to spit in the face of that image, and to honor them is to honor the One whose image they bear. Whoever is kind to the poor lends to the Lord, says Proverbs again, and the Lord will repay him. The poor are not a category of people we may choose to help or not as our temperament dictates. They are the place where God has located the test of whether our religion is real, and the prophets and Jesus apply that test relentlessly, and the modern church, by and large, has done everything possible to

avoid sitting for it.

Let me bring this out of the abstract and into the streets where I actually live, because the prophets never dealt in abstraction and neither should we. In my own country, in cities and towns like the one where I pastor, there is an entire industry built on the systematic exploitation of the poor, and it operates legally, respectably, with storefronts and advertising and the full protection of the law. It is the industry of poverty itself, the businesses that exist specifically to extract wealth from people who have almost none. Consider the practice of payday lending, where a person in desperate need of a few hundred dollars to cover rent or a car repair or a medical bill borrows against their next paycheck, and the effective interest rate on that loan runs not to ten or twenty percent but to three hundred, four hundred, sometimes five hundred percent annually, so that a person who was poor because they had no money becomes poorer still because they had no money, trapped in a cycle of debt designed to be inescapable, the loan rolled over and over, the fees compounding, the original few hundred dollars becoming a thousand, two thousand, a permanent drain on a life that was already drowning. This is the moving of the boundary stone. This is the false balance, the ephah made small and the shekel made great, that Amos denounced. It is the predatory extraction of wealth from the poor, dressed in the respectable clothes of legal commerce, and it operates in the open, in our towns, often within sight of our churches, and we say nothing, because to say something would be to enter the territory of justice, and we have agreed that justice is not our department.

*The poor are the test the church takes,
and we have spent generations
cheating on it by pretending the test
was about something else.*

CONSIDER HOUSING, THE MOST basic of human needs after food, the place where you sleep and raise your children and keep yourself safe from the weather and the world. In a wealthy society, in the wealthiest society in the history of the world, there are working people, people with full-time jobs, who cannot afford a place to live, who spend half or more of their income on rent for housing that is inadequate, who are one missed paycheck from the street, who move their children from place to place and school to school because they can never quite get stable footing under a roof they can afford. And there are forces that profit from this, that treat housing not as the basic human need it is but as a pure financial instrument to be optimized for the maximum extraction of rent, that buy up the housing stock and raise the rents and evict the families and let the units sit empty waiting for a wealthier tenant, that have made the most basic human shelter into a machine for transferring wealth from the poor to the already wealthy. And the church, which worships a God who commanded that the poor have a right to glean the corners of the field, who built a Jubilee into the law to keep families from being permanently dispossessed of their land, who declared that the land is mine and you are sojourners, the church has, by and large, treated the housing of the poor as a matter of private charity and personal misfortune and

not as a matter of justice, not as a structure to be examined and confronted, because confronting it would require us to ask who profits, and the answer might be people we know, might be the church's own investments, might be us.

I am describing systemic injustice, the kind I argued for in an earlier chapter, the sin that is built into structures and operates automatically and does not require any individual to be especially wicked. No single payday lender twirls a mustache. No single landlord is a cartoon villain. The people who operate these systems are mostly ordinary people doing ordinary jobs within arrangements they did not create and rules they did not write, and that is exactly the point, that is exactly how systemic sin works, that is exactly why the prophets denounced the system and not only the individual, because the system grinds the poor whether or not any particular person operating it feels malicious about it. The boundary stone gets moved an inch at a time by people who tell themselves they are just doing business. The ephah gets made small and the shekel great by a whole commercial culture in which everyone is just following the practice that everyone follows. And the poor get crushed, methodically, legally, respectably, by a machine that no one in particular is running and everyone in general is operating, and the church looks at the machine and says, with the priest and the Levite, that this is not our road to fix, and passes by on the other side.

What would it mean for the church to take seriously that the poor are the test. It would mean, first, that we could no longer treat economic justice as optional, as the special interest of a few activist Christians, as a political distraction from our true spiritual mission. It would mean recognizing that how we relate to the predatory structures that crush the

poor is a direct statement about what we think of God, because the poor bear his image and he has bound himself to their cause. It would mean that a church in a community plagued by payday lending could not be silent about payday lending, that a church in a community where working people cannot afford housing could not treat that as none of its business, that a church surrounded by the systematic exploitation of the poor could not run its food pantry and call the food pantry the whole of its obedience while the machine that produces the hunger operates undisturbed in plain sight. It would mean walking upstream, asking who profits, confronting the structures, and accepting the cost, the very real cost, of becoming a church that the powerful regard as a problem rather than an ally. Because the powerful do not mind a church that runs a food pantry. They mind a church that asks why the line at the food pantry keeps getting longer, and who is getting rich at the other end of it.

And so I have to confess, again, because this book is a confession before it is an argument, that the church I serve has mostly failed this test, and I have led the failing. We have managed our relationship to the poor through charity, which keeps us in control and costs us nothing structural, and we have avoided the question of justice, which would cost us our comfort and our standing and possibly our donors. We have run the programs and avoided the structures, fed the hungry and never asked who was profiting from the hunger, bound the wounds of the man in the ditch and never once asked about the Way of Blood that put him there. We have taken the test the poor represent and we have cheated on it, year after year, by pretending it was a different test, a test about our private generosity and our warm feelings, when it was always a test about whether we would confront the structures that

crush the people God has bound himself to defend. The poor are the test. We have been cheating for generations. And the most honest thing I can say, at the end of this chapter, is that I do not yet know whether the church in this country, my church, my own ministry, has the courage to stop cheating and actually sit the test that the God of the gleaning law and the Jubilee and the prophets has set before us. I know what the test requires. I am not yet sure we will pay it. That uncertainty is where I have to leave you, because it is where I honestly am.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

The Prisoner and the Forgotten

THERE IS A CATEGORY of human being that the modern church has almost entirely forgotten, and the forgetting is the more striking because Jesus put this category at the very center of his most explicit teaching about the final judgment. In the twenty-fifth chapter of Matthew, Jesus describes the Son of Man separating all the nations as a shepherd separates the sheep from the goats, and the basis of the separation is laid out with terrible clarity. I was hungry and you gave me food, I was thirsty and you gave me drink, I was a stranger and you welcomed me, I was naked and you clothed me, I was sick and you visited me, I was in prison and you came to me. And the righteous ask, when did we see you in any of these conditions, and the King answers, as you did it to one of the least of these my brothers, you did it to me. I was in prison and you came to me. Jesus places visiting the prisoner alongside feeding the hungry and clothing the naked as the very criterion of the final judgment, the thing by which the nations are sorted, the thing he identifies so closely with

himself that to do it or fail to do it is to do it or fail to do it to him. And the church, which loves to quote this passage about the hungry and the naked, has almost entirely dropped the prisoner from its memory.

Why have we forgotten the prisoner. Because the prisoner is the one we have decided deserves it. The hungry we can pity, the naked we can clothe, the sick we can visit with a clear conscience, because we can imagine them as innocent victims of misfortune. But the prisoner, we tell ourselves, is in prison because of something he did, because he is guilty, because he broke the law and is paying the price, and so our compassion curdles into judgment and we feel released from any obligation toward him. This is precisely the calculation Jesus refuses to allow. He does not say I was in prison unjustly and you came to me. He does not say visit the innocent prisoner, the wrongly convicted, the political prisoner whose cause you can endorse. He says I was in prison and you came to me, full stop, with no qualification about guilt or innocence, no asterisk that exempts us from the prisoner who actually did the thing. The whole force of the teaching is that Jesus identifies himself with the prisoner as such, the guilty one, the one who deserves it, the one our justice has condemned, and he commands us to come to him, to see his face in the face of the condemned, and warns that to refuse the prisoner is to refuse Christ himself.

*Jesus said he was in prison and we
came to him, or we did not. He did not
ask whether the prisoner was innocent.*

*He made the condemned man the test
of whether we know him at all.*

THIS IS OFFENSIVE, AND it is meant to be, because it cuts directly against the deepest instinct of our justice, which is the instinct to divide humanity into the deserving and the undeserving and to feel righteous in our treatment of the undeserving. The gospel itself is built on the scandal that God came to the undeserving, that Christ died for the ungodly, that while we were yet sinners, enemies, the guilty, the condemned, he gave himself for us. We were the prisoner Christ came to. We were the guilty one he did not abandon. And a church that has received that scandalous mercy and then turns to the actual prisoner, the actual condemned, and withholds from him the very mercy it received, has not understood the gospel it claims to preach. The one who has been forgiven much and forgives little, the servant who was released from an impossible debt and then seized his fellow servant by the throat over a small one, this is the church that quotes Matthew 25 about the hungry and forgets the prisoner in the same passage, that has received the mercy of God toward its own guilt and refuses to extend it to the guilt of the condemned. We did this. I have done this. I have visited the sick and fed the hungry and never once set foot in a jail, never written a letter to a prisoner, never asked about the conditions in which the condemned of my own community are held, because somewhere I had decided they deserved it, and in deciding that, I had quietly exempted myself from a command Jesus placed at the center of the final judgment.

And then there is the systemic question, which we cannot

avoid once we have learned to see systemic sin, because the prison is not only a place where individuals are held, it is a structure, a system, and the system itself stands under the prophets' scrutiny. My own country imprisons a larger share of its people than almost any nation on earth, holds millions behind bars, and does so in a way that falls with crushing disproportion on the poor and on certain communities, so that the prison system is not a neutral instrument of justice applied evenly to all wrongdoers but a structure shaped by the same forces of poverty and power and history that shape everything else. The poor man and the rich man who commit the same offense do not face the same justice, because the rich man has the lawyer and the bail and the standing, and the poor man has none of these, and so our prisons fill disproportionately with the poor, and the children of the imprisoned grow up without a parent, and the cycle deepens, and the structure perpetuates itself across generations. This is mishpat's concern exactly, the concern for whether the courts render true judgment or favor the powerful, the concern that runs all through the law and the prophets, the demand that justice be done truly and not be bought by those who can afford it and denied to those who cannot. To be silent about the structure of our justice system, about who fills our prisons and why and at what cost to whom, is to be silent about precisely the thing the biblical word mishpat was most concerned with, the integrity of judgment itself.

I want to be careful, because there is a cheap version of this concern that the secular movements offer, a version that romanticizes the criminal, denies real guilt, treats all law as oppression and all punishment as injustice, and refuses to take seriously the real victims of real crime, including the poor, who suffer most from crime and most deserve

protection from it. That is not the biblical position. The Bible takes sin and crime and real harm with complete seriousness. It does not pretend the guilty are innocent or that wrongdoing has no consequences or that the protection of the vulnerable from violence is not itself a demand of justice. The widow and the orphan need protection from the predator, and a justice that will not restrain the predator has failed them. So the answer is not to abolish all judgment or pretend all prisoners are martyrs. The answer is the biblical one, which holds together the seriousness of real wrong with the dignity of the wrongdoer, the legitimacy of just punishment with the demand that punishment be just, true judgment with mercy, the protection of the victim with the refusal to discard the perpetrator as beyond the reach of God. Both. Always both. The Bible will not let us romanticize the criminal, and it will not let us discard him either, and our politics, which can only do one or the other, fails on both sides.

So the prisoner stands as one more test the church has been failing, and the failure is particularly damning because Jesus made it so explicit. He did not leave us to infer that he cared about the prisoner. He stated it, placed it at the center of the judgment scene, identified himself with the condemned in the plainest possible terms, and warned that to forget the prisoner is to forget him. And we have forgotten the prisoner, comprehensively, deciding he deserved it, exempting ourselves from a command we cannot honestly claim we did not hear, because it is right there in the most quoted judgment passage in the Gospels. The church that wants to recover prophetic justice has to recover the prisoner, has to remember the forgotten, has to go to the jail and the prison and the condemned, not because the prisoner is

innocent but precisely because he is guilty and Christ came to the guilty and we are the proof of it. I was in prison, Jesus said, and you came to me. Or you did not. The whole weight of the final judgment, in his own telling, hangs in part on that one. And most of us, if we are honest, have never once gone, and have never once let the fact that we never went trouble us, and that untroubled forgetting is itself the verdict on how little we have understood the mercy we claim to live by.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

What the Church Owes Its Actual Neighborhood

A CHURCH DOES NOT exist in the abstract. It exists on a particular corner, in a particular neighborhood, among particular people, and the question of justice finally comes down not to grand theories but to this concrete reality: what does this church owe the actual neighborhood it sits in. Not the neighborhood in general, not the poor as a concept, but the specific streets within walking distance of the building, the specific people who live there, the specific needs and wounds and structures of this place. The whole argument of this book lands here, on the ground, on the corner where your church actually stands, because prophetic justice is not a posture or an opinion or a set of correct beliefs about distant injustices. It is a way of being present, costly and particular, to the people God has placed you among, and a church that has all the right convictions about justice in the abstract and does nothing for the actual neighborhood outside its doors has not understood justice at all. It has merely added justice to the list of things it has opinions about and does not do.

Most churches have a strange relationship to their neighborhoods, and I want to name it because naming it is the beginning of repenting of it. Many churches function as commuter churches, gathering people from across a wide region who drive in on Sunday and drive home afterward, so that the church has almost no relationship to the actual blocks around its building, knows almost nothing about the people who live there, and treats the neighborhood as little more than a parking problem and a location on a map. The church is in the neighborhood but not of it, present geographically and absent in every other way, a fortress that fills up on Sunday and empties out by noon, its lights off and its doors locked for the rest of the week while the life of the neighborhood goes on around it, unknown and unengaged. And often the neighborhood the church sits in is poorer than the people who drive in to attend, so that the building represents a concentration of resources and attention that pointedly does not reach the people closest to it, a church surrounded by need that it does not see because it does not live there, does not know the names, does not walk the blocks, has arranged its entire life so that the neighborhood is scenery rather than mission.

*A church owes its neighborhood more
than a parking lot full of strangers on
Sunday. It owes its presence, its
knowledge, its costly nearness to the
people God placed at its door.*

WHAT WOULD IT MEAN to actually owe the neighborhood something, to take seriously that God placed this church on this corner for the sake of these people. It would mean, first, knowing them, which sounds simple and is in fact a discipline most churches have abandoned, the discipline of presence, of walking the blocks, of learning the names, of understanding the actual conditions of life on the streets around the building, the actual needs, the actual wounds, the actual structures of poverty or instability or neglect that shape the lives of the neighbors. You cannot do justice for people you do not know. The abstraction that lets us care about distant injustices while ignoring the ones at our door is broken precisely by presence, by the costly work of knowing the actual neighbor, because the actual neighbor, once known, makes a claim on you that the abstract poor never could. The Samaritan did not love the neighbor in general. He loved the man in the ditch, the specific man, the one he could see and touch and carry. Justice begins with presence, with the refusal to let the neighborhood be scenery, with the costly nearness that knows the names.

And then it would mean addressing what presence reveals, both the wounds and the structures, both the charity and the justice, both the man in the ditch and the road that put him there. A church present to its neighborhood will find immediate needs to meet, hunger to feed, instability to steady, loneliness to enter, and it will meet them, because charity is the floor and the man in the ditch needs his wounds bound today. But a church truly present to its neighborhood, knowing it deeply over time, will also begin to see the structures, the patterns, the upstream causes, the road that keeps producing victims. It will see that the hunger has sources, that the instability has architects, that the

neighborhood's poverty is not a brute fact of nature but the product of decisions, some of them old and some of them ongoing, some of them made by people the church could actually confront. And then the church faces the real test, the test of whether it will walk upstream, whether it will move from charity to justice, whether it will risk the cost of confronting the structures that are crushing the neighbors it has come to know and love. This is where most churches stop, at the charity, at the food pantry, at the warm and costless ministry that helps real people and changes no structures, and I understand why we stop there, because what lies beyond is costly, and I have stopped there myself, again and again.

I think of my own church, First Baptist of Fenton, and the actual neighborhood we actually sit in, and I have to confess that for much of my ministry I treated the neighborhood as scenery, as the place the building happened to be, and poured my energy into the people who gathered rather than the people who lived around us. I knew my congregation. I did not know my neighbors. I could tell you the needs and struggles of the families who drove in on Sunday, and I could tell you almost nothing about the families who lived on the streets immediately around our building, whose lives went on entirely unknown to me, whose needs and wounds and struggles were as invisible to me as Lazarus was to the rich man at his gate. And I called this ministry. I called this a faithful pastorate. And it was, in the narrow sense, a real ministry to a real congregation, and it was also, in the larger sense, a church present to its members and absent to its neighborhood, a fortress that filled and emptied while the people closest to us went unseen. The repentance I am still working out, the repentance this whole book has been driving

toward, includes this very specific and local thing: the turning from a church that knows its members and not its neighbors to a church that knows the actual people God placed at its actual door, and owes them, and pays.

So the question this chapter leaves with every church and every pastor and every believer is as concrete as it gets. Who lives within walking distance of your church, and do you know them, and what do you owe them, and are you paying it. Not the poor in general, not justice as an abstraction, not the distant injustices that cost you nothing to deplore, but the specific neighborhood, the specific streets, the specific people, the specific structures crushing them, the specific cost of being present and faithful and just in this place where God has actually put you. The neighborhood is the test made local, the test made unavoidable, the test you cannot pass with correct opinions or distant sympathies, the test that requires your presence and your knowledge and your costly nearness and finally your willingness to confront what crushes the neighbors you have come to know. A church owes its neighborhood the gospel in full, the gospel that saves souls and binds wounds and confronts the structures and stays, stays, stays present to the people at its door across the long years it takes for justice to come. Most of us have not paid it. I have not paid it. And the neighborhood is still out there, just past the parking lot, full of names we have not learned, waiting for a church that will finally come close enough to know them.

CHAPTER TWENTY

Justice Without Love Becomes Ideology

I HAVE SPENT THIS entire book indicting the church for privatizing the gospel and outsourcing justice, and now, near the end, I have to turn the prophetic edge in the other direction, toward the danger that lies on the road I have been urging you to take, because the road to justice has a cliff on the other side of it, and many who set out for justice have gone over that cliff, and I would be a false guide if I led you toward justice without warning you of the way it can destroy you. The danger is this: justice without love becomes ideology, and ideology is a hungry god that devours everything, including the people who serve it. The same passion for justice that begins in the heart of God can, cut loose from God, harden into something that is no longer the justice of the prophets at all but its grim counterfeit, a justice that has lost its mercy, lost its humility, lost the self-implication that keeps the prophet inside the indictment, and become instead a weapon for the righteous to wield against the wicked, with the righteous always being us and the

wicked always being them.

You can see the pattern in every revolution that began in the name of justice and ended in terror. The passion was real, the injustice it opposed was real, the cause was, at the start, righteous. And then, somewhere along the way, the justice detached from love and humility and the fear of God, and the movement divided the world cleanly into the oppressors and the oppressed, the guilty and the innocent, and located all evil in the oppressors and all virtue in the oppressed, and licensed any cruelty against the guilty in the name of justice for the innocent, and the revolution that began by opposing oppression became the new oppressor, more total and more merciless than the one it overthrew, because it now had the absolute moral confidence that it was on the side of justice itself. This is the cliff. This is where justice without love goes. It goes to the place where the cause becomes everything and the human being becomes nothing, where the enemy is no longer a fellow sinner to be reckoned with but an embodiment of evil to be destroyed, where mercy is treated as weakness and complexity as betrayal and the slightest deviation from the line as collaboration with the oppressor. And the terrible thing is that it happens to people who started out caring about real injustice, which is why no one is immune, which is why I am not immune, which is why the warning has to be sounded loudest to exactly those who have heard the call to justice and answered it.

*Justice without love becomes ideology,
and ideology is a hungry god. It begins
by opposing the oppressor and ends by
becoming one, with perfect confidence
the whole way down.*

WHAT IS MISSING, WHEN justice curdles into ideology, is precisely the three things Micah held together, the three things I keep returning to because they are the whole answer. Do justice, love mercy, walk humbly with your God. Ideology does justice, or thinks it does, but it has lost the mercy and lost the humility, and without mercy and humility the justice goes rancid. It loses mercy, so it cannot forgive, cannot extend grace, cannot imagine the redemption of the oppressor, can only condemn and destroy, and a justice that can only condemn has forgotten the gospel that the condemned themselves are the very people Christ died for. And it loses humility, the humble walk with God, so it no longer implicates itself, no longer knows its own complicity, no longer stands inside the indictment but climbs up onto the judgment seat and pronounces sentence on everyone else from a height of perfect self-righteousness, and a justice without humility is the most dangerous thing in the world, because it is cruelty that believes itself to be righteousness, oppression that experiences itself as liberation, and it cannot be reasoned with because it has made itself God. The prophet, the true prophet, never climbs onto the judgment seat. The true prophet says we have sinned, we and our

fathers, includes himself in the indictment, walks humbly even while doing justice, and that self-implication, that humility, that mercy, is exactly what ideology strips away, and stripping it away is what turns the justice of God into the terror of men.

This is why I have insisted, all through this book, that biblical justice is rooted in the character of God and submitted to the lordship of Christ and held together with personal righteousness and mercy and humility, and is not a freestanding political program that can be cut loose from its source. Because the moment you cut justice loose from God, you lose the very things that keep it from becoming ideology. You lose the transcendent reference point that judges your justice as well as your enemy's injustice, that keeps you from becoming God, that reminds you that you too are a sinner saved by grace and not the pure prosecutor of the impure. You lose the cross, which is the place where God's justice and God's mercy meet, where sin is taken with full seriousness and the sinner is loved to the death at the same time, and without the cross you get either a justice with no mercy or a mercy with no justice, and the ideologue chooses the first and the sentimentalist chooses the second and neither has the gospel. And you lose the command to love your enemy, which Jesus placed at the very center of his ethic, the command that is impossible for ideology because ideology needs the enemy, feeds on the enemy, defines itself by the enemy, and could not survive the discovery that the enemy is a human being made in the image of God and beloved of Christ and no more or less a sinner than yourself.

So I have to say to everyone this book has stirred toward justice, and I include myself, that the most important thing is

not that you take up justice but how you take it up, in what spirit, under whose lordship, with what relationship to mercy and humility and the love of your enemy and the knowledge of your own sin. Take up justice as the prophets did, with fury at oppression and tears for the oppressed and a relentless demand that the wrong be set right, yes, but also with the self-implication that keeps you inside the indictment, the humility that keeps you off the judgment seat, the mercy that never forgets that the oppressor too is a person Christ died for, and the love that refuses to let the cause become an idol that devours the people it claims to serve. This is harder than ideology. Ideology is easy, because it gives you a clean enemy and a pure cause and the intoxicating certainty of your own righteousness. The justice of the prophets is hard, because it gives you a fury that must be held together with mercy, a demand that must be held together with humility, a cause that must be held together with the love of the very enemy who embodies the injustice, and holding those things together is almost impossible, and it is exactly what God requires, and it is exactly what the cross makes possible and nothing else does.

I will not pretend I have held these together well, because I have not, and the failure has gone in both directions. There have been seasons when I avoided justice altogether, the privatized seasons this whole book repents of, and there have been moments, when I finally began to care, when the caring curdled toward the ideological, when I felt the intoxication of the clean enemy and the pure cause and the righteous fury that no longer implicated myself, and in those moments I was not closer to the prophets but further, because I had taken up their fury and dropped their humility, taken the half that felt powerful and left the half that felt like death. The whole

struggle of the just life, the whole reason it requires the constant nearness of God and not just a program of action, is that justice is always one step from becoming ideology, and the only thing that keeps it from going over the cliff is the love and the humility and the mercy that are so easy to lose precisely when the fury feels most righteous. Do justice. But love mercy. And walk humbly with your God. Drop any one of them and you have not failed to do justice. You have done a worse thing. You have made justice into a god, and the gods we make always turn and devour us, and the wreckage they leave is indistinguishable from the oppression they promised to end.

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

The Psalms, Where the Oppressed Cry and God Answers

WE HAVE LEARNED TO read the Psalms as private devotion, the prayer book of the individual soul in its quiet moments, and so we have missed that a great many of the Psalms are the cries of the oppressed, the prayers of people being crushed, the songs of those at the bottom calling out to a God they trust to be on the side of the bottom. The Psalms are not first a manual for personal serenity. They are, in large part, the prayer book of the poor, the persecuted, the wrongfully accused, the ones whose enemies are powerful and whose own power is exhausted, and the reason they cry out to God is precisely that they believe, with the whole weight of Israel's faith behind them, that God is the kind of God who hears the cry of the oppressed and acts. When we domesticate the Psalms into private comfort, we lose the very thing that makes them what they are, which is the conviction, sung over and over in a hundred different ways, that the Lord is a refuge

for the oppressed, a stronghold in times of trouble, a God who does not forget the cry of the afflicted, a God who rises up to defend those whom no one else will defend.

Listen to how the Psalms describe God, and notice how relentlessly the description is a description of justice. The Lord works righteousness and justice for all who are oppressed. He executes justice for the oppressed, he gives food to the hungry, the Lord sets the prisoners free, the Lord opens the eyes of the blind, the Lord lifts up those who are bowed down, the Lord watches over the sojourners, he upholds the widow and the fatherless. This is from a single Psalm, the hundred and forty-sixth, and it is a complete summary of everything this book has been arguing, the character of God laid out in a song, the God who does justice for the oppressed and feeds the hungry and frees the prisoner and watches the immigrant and upholds the widow and the orphan, all the categories we have been tracing, all gathered into a single hymn of praise. The Psalmist praises God specifically for being a God of justice toward the vulnerable. This is what makes God praiseworthy in the Psalter, not only his power and his holiness in the abstract, but his settled, reliable, sung-about commitment to the people at the bottom, his refusal to forget the cry of the afflicted, his rising up to do justice when the powerful have done injustice. The Psalms know the God of the Exodus, the God who comes down, and they sing him.

*The Psalms are not first a book of
private comfort. They are the prayer
book of the crushed, and they sing of a
God who hears the cry from the bottom
and rises up to answer it.*

AND THEN THERE ARE the Psalms that frighten us, the ones we skip, the imprecatory Psalms, the prayers that call down the wrath of God on the oppressor, that ask God to break the teeth of the wicked, to repay the violent for their violence, to rise up and judge the earth. We are embarrassed by these Psalms. They seem to violate everything we believe about loving our enemies and turning the other cheek, and so we quietly drop them from our reading and our worship, and in dropping them we miss what they are doing. The imprecatory Psalms are the cries of the powerless against the powerful, the prayers of people who have been crushed and have no recourse, who cannot avenge themselves because they have no power to avenge themselves, and who therefore bring their rage and their longing for justice to God and lay it at his feet, asking him to do what they cannot, to set right what is wrong, to judge the oppressor they cannot judge. These Psalms are not models of personal vengeance. They are the opposite. They are the renunciation of personal vengeance, the handing over of the longing for justice to the only One who can do justice rightly, the refusal of the oppressed to take the sword themselves and the insistence instead that God, the just judge, will not let the oppression stand forever. There is a

world of difference between the man who takes vengeance and the man who cries out to God for justice, and the imprecatory Psalms are the cry, not the vengeance, and a church too comfortable to have ever been truly crushed has no idea how necessary that cry is to people who have.

I think the comfortable church's embarrassment at the imprecatory Psalms is itself a confession of where we stand, because these Psalms make sense from the bottom and they offend from the top. If you have never been oppressed, never been crushed by a power you could not resist, never cried out for a justice you had no means to obtain, then the rage of these Psalms seems excessive, unchristian, an embarrassment to be explained away. But if you are the widow whose house has been devoured, the worker whose wages have been stolen, the family driven off its land, the prisoner held unjustly, the people ground down for generations by a power that faces no consequence, then the imprecatory Psalms are not an embarrassment. They are a lifeline. They are permission to bring your rage to God, to name the injustice in the rawest terms, to demand that God act, and to trust that he will, that the oppression you cannot stop, he can and will judge. The comfortable church reads these Psalms from the top and is offended. The oppressed church reads them from the bottom and is sustained. And the gap between those two readings is the gap this entire book is about, the gap between the privatized comfortable Christianity that has never needed a God of justice because it has never been on the receiving end of injustice, and the prophetic biblical faith that knows the God of the Exodus because it has cried to him from inside the affliction he came down to end.

What the Psalms give us, finally, is a model for how the people of God hold injustice before God, and it is a model we desperately need, because we tend to manage injustice in two equally faithless ways. Either we suppress it, deny it, spiritualize it, pretend it is not happening or does not matter or is not our concern, the way of the comfortable church that will not see the oppression at its gate. Or we are consumed by it, taken over by rage, driven toward the cliff of ideology where the longing for justice curdles into the lust for vengeance, the way of the secular movements that have lost God and kept the fury. The Psalms offer a third way, the way of lament and imprecation brought to God, the way of naming the injustice in the rawest terms and then handing it over, of bringing the full weight of the rage and the grief and the longing for justice into the presence of the only One who can bear it and act on it rightly. The Psalmist neither suppresses the injustice nor avenges it. He sings it, prays it, weeps it, and lays it before the God of justice, and trusts. That is the discipline the church has lost and needs to recover, the discipline of lament, the prayer of the oppressed, the song that holds injustice before God without either denying it or being destroyed by it. We do not have many songs like that anymore. Our worship is relentlessly upbeat, triumphant, comfortable, the worship of people who have never been crushed and do not want to be reminded that others have. And so we cannot sing with the oppressed, cannot lament with those who lament, cannot bring the world's injustice before God because we have no songs for it, having kept only the songs of the comfortable and dropped the prayers of the crushed.

So recover the Psalms in their fullness, the laments and the imprecations along with the praise, the prayers from the

bottom along with the songs from the height. Learn to read them as the prayer book of the oppressed, which is largely what they are, and let them teach you the God they sing, the God who works righteousness and justice for all who are oppressed, who hears the cry of the afflicted and does not forget it, who rises up to do the justice that the powerless cannot do for themselves. And learn to pray them, even the hard ones, even the ones that frighten the comfortable, because there are people in your own city, your own neighborhood, perhaps your own pews, who need to know that their faith has a place for their rage and their grief and their longing for a justice they cannot obtain, a place to bring it and lay it before God, a God who, the Psalms insist, will not let the oppression stand forever. The Psalms are not private comfort. They are the songs of a people who believed, in the teeth of every appearance to the contrary, that God is just and will do justice, and they sang that belief from the bottom of the pit, and the church that has forgotten how to sing from the bottom has forgotten half of what it means to know the God of the Psalms.

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

The Prophets Were Not Predicting the Future

WE HAVE DONE SOMETHING strange with the prophets, and the strangeness has cost us enormously. We have turned them into fortune-tellers. When the modern church thinks of biblical prophecy, it thinks first of prediction, of the foretelling of future events, of charts and timelines and the decoding of obscure passages to determine the schedule of the end times. We have made the prophets into a kind of ancient mystics whose main function was to predict the distant future, and especially to predict the coming of Christ, so that the prophetic books become primarily a collection of messianic predictions surrounded by a great deal of material we do not quite know what to do with. And in doing this, we have missed almost entirely what the prophets actually were and what they actually did, which was not primarily to predict the future but to confront the present, to stand before the powers of their own day and name the injustice and call the people back to the God they had abandoned. The prophets were not fortune-tellers. They were truth-tellers. And the

truth they told was overwhelmingly about justice.

Walter Brueggemann gave us the phrase prophetic imagination, and what he meant by it cuts directly against the fortune-teller reading. The prophet, Brueggemann argued, is not primarily one who predicts but one who criticizes and energizes, one who pierces the dominant consciousness of the age, the comfortable assumptions of the powerful, the numbness that lets a society tolerate its own injustice, and who awakens an alternative imagination, a vision of how things could be under God, a grief over how things are and a hope for how things might become. The prophet criticizes the royal consciousness, the consciousness of empire and power and the established order that has made its peace with injustice, and the prophet energizes a different consciousness, the consciousness of the kingdom of God, where justice rolls down and the oppressed go free. This is what Amos did, what Isaiah did, what Micah did, what Jeremiah did. They did not stand in a corner predicting the future. They stood before kings and priests and the prosperous and named the injustice of their own moment, the exploitation of the poor, the corruption of the courts, the worship that ran smoothly while the widow went unheard, and they called down the judgment of God on a society that had abandoned the justice and righteousness God demanded.

*The prophet was never mainly a
fortune-teller. He was a truth-teller,
standing before the powerful, naming
the injustice of his own moment, and*

*calling a numb society back to the God
it had abandoned.*

WHY DOES THIS MATTER so much. Because if the prophets were primarily predicting the future, then their work is essentially done, their predictions either fulfilled or scheduled, and our job is merely to read the predictions and wait. But if the prophets were primarily confronting injustice in their own present, then their work is a model for ours, an ongoing vocation, a way of standing in our own moment and doing what they did in theirs, piercing the comfortable consciousness of our own age, naming the injustice of our own society, calling our own people back to the justice and righteousness of God. The fortune-teller reading lets us off the hook. It makes the prophets into a closed book of predictions to be studied. The truth-teller reading puts us on the hook, because it makes the prophets into a living vocation to be continued, a way of being faithful that the church is called to take up, the prophetic vocation of confronting the injustice of our own time as they confronted the injustice of theirs. And the church has vastly preferred the fortune-teller reading, has built whole industries around the prediction-decoding while almost entirely abandoning the truth-telling, because decoding predictions is safe and confronting injustice is dangerous, and we have always, in this book and in life, chosen the safe reading of the dangerous text.

The prophets were dangerous men, and we have made them harmless, and the gap between the two is the gap between what they were and what we have made of them. Amos was so dangerous that the priest Amaziah tried to have

him expelled from the kingdom, told him to go back to Judah and prophesy there and stop disturbing the peace of the king's sanctuary at Bethel. Jeremiah was so dangerous that he was beaten, put in stocks, thrown into a cistern to die, imprisoned, because his truth-telling threatened the powers of his day so directly that they wanted him silenced. Isaiah, according to tradition, was executed. These men were not consulted as mystics for their predictions of the future. They were persecuted as threats for their confrontation of the present. They named the injustice of the powerful to the faces of the powerful, and the powerful did what the powerful always do to those who name their injustice, they tried to silence them, expel them, kill them. The prophetic vocation was a dangerous vocation precisely because it was a vocation of truth-telling about justice, of standing before power and naming what power did not want named, and a church that has turned the prophets into harmless fortune-tellers has not just misread a genre. It has neutralized a vocation, defanged a calling, taken the most dangerous figures in the Scripture and made them safe, because the safe version asks nothing of us and the dangerous version asks everything.

I have preached the prophets as fortune-tellers, and I confess it as one more instance of the pattern this whole book confesses, the pattern of choosing the safe reading of the dangerous text. I have mined Isaiah for messianic predictions and skipped the chapters where he denounces the injustice of Judah. I have read Amos for the verses that sound poetic and avoided the verses that name the exploitation of the poor and call down judgment on a prosperous, religious, self-satisfied society that looks uncomfortably like my own. I have treated the prophets as a quarry for predictions and proof-texts rather than as a vocation to be continued, because

treating them as a vocation would mean asking what it would cost to do in my own moment what they did in theirs, to pierce the comfortable consciousness of my own people, to name the injustice of my own society, to risk what they risked. And I did not want to ask that, because I knew the answer, knew that the prophetic vocation is dangerous, knew that those who take it up get expelled and beaten and thrown into cisterns and sometimes killed, knew that the powers of my own day, including the powers in my own pews and the power of my own comfort, would not welcome a prophet any more than the powers of Amos's day welcomed him.

So we have to recover the prophets as what they were, truth-tellers and not fortune-tellers, and recover the prophetic vocation as a calling the church is meant to continue and not a closed book of predictions the church is meant to study. This is not to deny that the prophets spoke of the future or pointed to Christ, of course they did, and the messianic dimension is real and glorious. But it was never the main thing, never the heart of their vocation, never the reason they were persecuted, and to make it the main thing is to lose the prophets and to lose the vocation. The prophetic imagination, the piercing of the comfortable consciousness, the naming of injustice, the grief over what is and the hope for what might be under God, the dangerous truth-telling before power, this is the prophetic inheritance, and the church is the heir to it, called to take it up, called to be in its own moment what Amos and Isaiah and Micah and Jeremiah were in theirs. And the question, as always, is whether we will take up the dangerous vocation or keep studying the safe predictions, whether we will be truth-tellers or fortune-tellers, whether we will pierce the comfortable consciousness of our own age, including our own, or keep decoding charts

while the injustice the prophets would have named goes on, unnamed, untroubled, in a church that has made the most dangerous men in Scripture into the most harmless, because the harmless version lets us sleep.

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

The Cross as the Place Where Justice and Mercy Meet

EVERYTHING IN THIS BOOK has been driving toward a problem, and now I have to name the problem directly and then name its only solution, because without the solution the whole project of justice collapses into one of the two errors I have been warning against from the beginning. The problem is this: justice and mercy seem to be in tension, and the tension is real, and most people and most movements resolve it by choosing one and sacrificing the other. Justice, by itself, demands that wrong be punished, that the guilty pay, that the scales be balanced, that the oppressor face consequence. Mercy, by itself, demands that the guilty be forgiven, that the debt be released, that grace be extended past what is deserved. And these two demands pull against each other, because justice says make them pay and mercy says let them go, and you cannot, it seems, do both at once. The secular justice movement resolves the tension by choosing justice

and sacrificing mercy, and gets ideology, the merciless pursuit of the guilty. The sentimental church resolves the tension by choosing mercy and sacrificing justice, and gets cheap grace, the costless forgiveness that takes no sin seriously. And both have failed, because both have torn apart what God holds together, and the place where God holds them together is the cross.

The cross is the answer to the deepest problem in all of ethics, the problem of how justice and mercy can both be fully satisfied at the same time, and the church has often preached the cross while missing that this is what it does. At the cross, God takes sin with absolute seriousness, the full seriousness that justice demands, and pours out upon it the judgment it deserves, so that no sin is excused, no wrong is winked at, no injustice is treated as though it did not matter. Justice is satisfied at the cross, fully, completely, the wrong taken with total seriousness and the judgment fully borne. And at the same very moment, mercy is satisfied at the cross, fully, completely, because the judgment that justice demands is borne not by the guilty but by God himself, in the person of the Son, so that the guilty go free, forgiven, released, shown a mercy past all deserving. Justice and mercy, the two demands that tear every human ethic apart, meet and are both fully satisfied in a single event, because God bears in himself the cost of the justice so that he can extend to us the mercy, takes the punishment the wrong deserves so that the wrongdoer can be forgiven without the wrong being excused. This is the genius of the cross, and it is the only place in all of reality where justice and mercy are both fully honored and neither is sacrificed to the other.

At the cross, God did not choose between justice and mercy. He bore the cost of the justice himself so he could extend the mercy without excusing the sin. It is the only place the two are both fully satisfied.

AND THIS IS WHY biblical justice can never become ideology, when it is rooted in the cross, because the cross holds the mercy and the justice together and will not let either go. The ideologue chooses justice without mercy because he has no cross, no place where the debt of the guilty is paid by another, and so the only way he can imagine the debt being addressed is for the guilty to pay it themselves, which means the guilty must be punished, destroyed, made to bear the full weight of their wrong, and mercy becomes betrayal of the cause. But the Christian who stands at the cross knows a different possibility, the possibility that the debt of the guilty has been paid by another, that the oppressor too can be forgiven, not by excusing the oppression but by the oppression being taken with full seriousness and its judgment borne by Christ, so that even the oppressor, even the enemy, even the one whose injustice we rightly oppose, is a person for whom Christ died, a person to whom the mercy of the cross is offered, a person we cannot finally write off as beyond redemption because the cross declares no one beyond redemption. The cross is what keeps the justice from becoming merciless, because the cross has already shown

that mercy and justice can both be satisfied, that we do not have to choose, that the longing for the wrong to be set right and the longing for the wrongdoer to be redeemed can both be honored, because they were both honored at Calvary.

And the cross is also why our justice can never become cheap grace, the costless mercy that takes no sin seriously, because the cross shows exactly how costly real mercy is. The sentimental church wants forgiveness without judgment, reconciliation without repentance, peace without the naming of the wrong, and it imagines that this is what grace is, the simple overlooking of sin, the letting-go that costs nothing. But the cross says no. The cross says that mercy is not the overlooking of sin but the bearing of it, that forgiveness is not the pretense that the wrong did not happen but the costly absorption of its full weight, that grace is free to us only because it was infinitely costly to God. Bonhoeffer named cheap grace as the deadly enemy of the church precisely because cheap grace is grace without the cross, grace that has forgotten what forgiveness cost, grace that forgives the sin without ever taking the sin seriously, and that kind of grace cannot do justice because it cannot take wrong seriously enough to oppose it. Real grace, costly grace, the grace of the cross, takes sin with the full seriousness that justice demands and then bears its cost so that the sinner can be forgiven, and this kind of grace can do justice, must do justice, because it knows exactly how much sin costs and refuses to treat it lightly, and only after the wrong has been fully named and fully reckoned with does it extend the costly mercy that was bought with blood.

So the cross is not a distraction from justice or an alternative to it. The cross is the foundation of a justice that

does not curdle into ideology and a mercy that does not collapse into cheap grace, the place where the two are held together so that the church can do both, can oppose the wrong with the full seriousness justice demands and extend mercy to the wrongdoer with the full costliness the cross reveals. A church that does justice without the cross will become an ideology, merciless, devouring, certain of its own righteousness and blind to its own sin. A church that preaches the cross without justice will become cheap grace, costless forgiveness that takes no wrong seriously and leaves every oppression undisturbed. But a church that does justice from the foot of the cross, that opposes the wrong because the cross shows how seriously God takes wrong, and extends mercy to the wrongdoer because the cross shows how far God will go to redeem, that church has the only justice worth having, the justice of the prophets held together with the mercy of the gospel, both fully honored, neither sacrificed, because both met and were satisfied at the place where the Son of God bore the judgment of the world so that the world could be both judged and forgiven.

I have to say, finally, that the cross is where my own struggle with justice finds its only resolution, because I am both the oppressor and the oppressed, both the one who has done injustice and the one who longs for justice, both inside the indictment and crying out from under it, and only the cross holds all of that together. The cross tells me that my own injustice, the systems I have benefited from, the silence I have kept, the comfort I have chosen over the cost, has been taken with full seriousness and its judgment borne, so that I am forgiven without my sin being excused, and that same cross tells me that the justice I long for, the setting-right of every wrong, is not a fantasy but the very thing God

accomplished and will complete, the wrong taken with full seriousness and finally, fully, set right. I do not have to choose between being judged and being forgiven, because at the cross I am both. And neither does the oppressor I oppose, and neither does the world whose injustice breaks my heart. The cross is the place where the justice I demand and the mercy I need are both, impossibly, fully given, and it is the only place where they are, and a justice that forgets the cross will always, eventually, become a cruelty, because it will have lost the one place where the longing to set things right does not have to be purchased by the destruction of the people who got them wrong.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

Creation, the Fall, and the Justice We Were Made For

TO UNDERSTAND WHY JUSTICE goes all the way down, why it is woven into the very being of God and the very structure of the world, we have to go further back than the Exodus, further back than Abraham, all the way back to the beginning, to the creation itself, because justice is not a repair God introduced after things went wrong. It is the original design, the way things were made to be, the shape of a world ordered by a God who is himself just. When God made the world and called it good, the goodness included a particular ordering of relationships, between humanity and God, between human beings and one another, between humanity and the creation itself, and that ordering was a just ordering, a right relationship in every direction, what the Hebrew would call shalom, the comprehensive peace and flourishing and wholeness that comes when everything is rightly related to everything else under God. Shalom is not

the absence of conflict. It is the presence of right relationship, the just ordering of the whole creation, the way things are supposed to be. And justice, biblical justice, mishpat and tsedaqah, is finally the restoration of that original shalom, the setting-right of relationships that have gone wrong, the recovery of the just ordering that was the world's design.

This is why injustice is not merely a violation of a rule but a violation of the very grain of reality, a tearing of the fabric of creation, a wound in the order of things. When the powerful exploit the weak, when the courts are corrupted, when the poor are crushed and the widow goes unheard, this is not just the breaking of a commandment, it is the unmaking of the world, the dragging of creation back toward the chaos it was brought out of, the destruction of the shalom that was God's design. The Hebrew prophets understood this. When they denounced injustice, they often did so in language that recalled the unmaking of creation, the darkening of the sun, the trembling of the earth, the return of chaos, because they understood that injustice is anti-creation, a force that tears apart the right ordering God built into the world, and that a society given over to injustice is a society coming apart at the seams of reality itself. Justice is not an arbitrary divine preference. It is the restoration of the way things were made to be. And injustice is not merely naughty. It is the active unmaking of God's good creation.

*Justice is not a repair God added after
the fall. It is the original design of
creation, the right ordering of all*

*things, and injustice is the active
unmaking of the world God called
good.*

THE FALL, THEN, IS not only the introduction of personal sin into the individual heart, though it is that. It is the shattering of shalom, the breaking of the right ordering in every direction at once. The first man and woman break their relationship with God, and immediately the breaking spreads outward, to the relationship between the man and the woman, who now accuse and blame each other, to the relationship between humanity and the creation, which now resists and frustrates human labor, to the relationship between brothers, as Cain rises up and murders Abel in the very next chapter, the first death in the Bible coming not from natural causes but from one human being killing another, and the blood of the victim crying out from the ground to God. That cry, the blood of Abel crying out from the ground, is the first cry of injustice in the Bible, and God hears it, as he will hear the cry of the slaves in Egypt, as he will hear the cry of the oppressed throughout the Scriptures, because the God who made a world of shalom is a God who hears when that shalom is shattered, who hears the blood of the victim crying out from the ground, and who will not let the cry go unanswered. The fall is the shattering of justice, the breaking of right relationship in every direction, and the whole rest of the biblical story is the story of God's work to restore the shalom that the fall destroyed.

This is why the gospel is bigger than the salvation of individual souls, though it is never less than that, and why a

privatized gospel that addresses only the individual's relationship with God is a truncated gospel, a gospel that has forgotten the scope of what the fall broke and the scope of what God is restoring. If the fall shattered shalom in every direction, the relationship with God, the relationships among human beings, the relationship with creation itself, then redemption must address all of it, must restore right relationship in every direction, must heal not only the individual soul's standing before God but the broken relationships between human beings and the broken relationship with the creation. The salvation of the soul is the center of it, the necessary heart, because the relationship with God is the foundation of all the others, but it was never meant to be the whole of it, never meant to be a private transaction that leaves the rest of the shattered creation untouched. God is restoring shalom, comprehensive shalom, right relationship in every direction, and the justice we are called to do is our participation in that restoration, our work alongside God to set right what the fall set wrong, to recover in part and in anticipation the shalom that will be fully restored only when Christ returns and makes all things new.

And this gives us the deepest answer to the question of why we should care about justice at all, why it is not optional, why it is not a political add-on, why it goes all the way down. We care about justice because we were made for it, because shalom is the world's original design and our deepest longing, because the ache we feel in the presence of injustice is the ache of creatures made for a right-ordered world and forced to live in a broken one. The longing for justice is not a political preference or a cultural construct. It is the memory of Eden, the echo of the shalom we were made for, the witness in the human heart that things are not as they should be and

were not always so and will not always be. Even the atheist I once was felt this, the rage at injustice, the conviction that some things are simply wrong, the longing for a world set right, and I had no foundation for any of it, no ground on which to stand and say that injustice was truly wrong and not merely unpleasant to my evolved preferences. It was only when I came to faith that I found the foundation, the recognition that the longing for justice was the longing for shalom, the memory of the world God made and the hope of the world God will remake, and that the God who made me for justice was himself just, and had himself entered the broken creation to begin its restoration.

So justice is not an add-on, not a political distraction, not a special interest of the activist wing of the church. It is woven into the foundation of the world, the original design of creation, the shalom we were made for and lost and long for and will one day have again. To do justice is to participate in God's restoration of his broken creation, to push back in some small way against the unmaking that the fall set loose, to recover in part the right ordering that was the world's design and will be its destiny. And to ignore justice, to privatize the gospel until it touches only the individual soul and leaves the shattered creation untouched, is to misunderstand the scope of the fall and the scope of redemption, to imagine that God is interested only in rescuing souls from a world he has written off, when in fact God is at work to restore the whole creation, to make all things new, to wipe away every tear and end every injustice and recover the shalom that the morning stars sang over when the world was made. We were made for justice. We lost it in the fall. We long for it in our bones. And God is restoring it, has begun the restoration in Christ, and calls us to take up

the work, to do justice now as a sign and a foretaste of the shalom that is coming, the world set right, the creation healed, the long ache of the human heart for a just world finally, fully, and forever answered.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

James, the Brother of the Lord, and the Religion God Accepts

THERE IS A LETTER in the New Testament that reads like an Old Testament prophet wandered into the early church, and it was written by a man who knew Jesus better than almost anyone, his own brother, James, who grew up in the same house in Nazareth, who did not believe at first and then, after the resurrection, became a pillar of the Jerusalem church. And James writes with the fury and the directness of Amos, with the same refusal to let religion become a cover for injustice, with the same insistence that what you do for the poor is the test of whether your faith is real. The letter of James has embarrassed comfortable Christianity for two thousand years, so much so that Luther famously called it an epistle of straw and wished it were not in the canon, because James will not let faith be a private matter of belief that leaves the treatment of the poor untouched. Pure religion, James writes, religion that is pure and undefiled before God the

Father, is this: to visit orphans and widows in their affliction, and to keep oneself unstained from the world. There it is again, the orphan and the widow, the same two figures from the law and the prophets, and James says that caring for them is what pure religion actually is, not the addition to religion but the substance of it.

James is relentless on the subject of the poor and the rich, and he does not soften it for a comfortable audience. He warns against showing favoritism to the rich man in fine clothes while dishonoring the poor man in shabby clothing, against the natural human instinct to defer to wealth and despise poverty, and he reminds the church that God has chosen the poor of this world to be rich in faith and heirs of the kingdom, while it is the rich who oppress them and drag them into court. He asks the devastating question that exposes the emptiness of a faith that does not act: if a brother or sister is poorly clothed and lacking in daily food, and one of you says to them, go in peace, be warmed and filled, without giving them the things needed for the body, what good is that. What good is that. A faith that sees the poor and offers only words, only well-wishing, only go in peace, be warmed and filled, while doing nothing for the actual body's actual need, is a faith James calls dead, dead in itself, useless, a faith that cannot save because it is not real faith at all but the empty shell of it. Faith without works is dead, James writes, and the works he has primarily in mind throughout the letter are works of justice and mercy toward the poor.

*James, who grew up in the same house
as Jesus, wrote that pure religion is to
care for the orphan and the widow,
and that a faith which sees the poor
and offers only words is dead. His own
brother told us the test.*

AND THEN JAMES TURNS to the rich and to the systems of exploitation, and here he sounds exactly like Amos, exactly like the prophet he was channeling. Come now, you rich, he writes, weep and howl for the miseries that are coming upon you. And the specific charge he levels is a charge of wage theft, of economic exploitation, of the withholding of wages from the workers who labored in the fields of the wealthy. Behold, the wages of the laborers who mowed your fields, which you kept back by fraud, are crying out against you, and the cries of the harvesters have reached the ears of the Lord of hosts. The wages cry out. The cries of the workers have reached the ears of God. This is the exact theology of the Exodus, the God who hears the cry of the exploited, the God to whom the blood of Abel cried from the ground, the God who does not let the oppression of the worker go unheard. James, the brother of Jesus, writing to the early church, denounces wage theft in the language of the prophets and warns the rich who have grown fat by withholding the wages of their workers that their gold and silver will testify against them and their cries of injustice have reached the Lord of hosts. This is not a marginal note in an obscure letter. This is

the brother of the Lord telling the church that God hears the cry of the exploited worker and will judge the employer who steals his wages.

What James gives us, and the reason his letter is so important for this whole argument, is the New Testament's own insistence that the prophetic concern for justice did not end with the Old Testament, did not get spiritualized away by the coming of Christ, did not become optional in the age of grace. James, who knew Jesus better than anyone, who learned at the same table and grew up under the same roof, took the prophetic tradition and applied it directly to the church, insisted that the religion God accepts is the religion that cares for the orphan and the widow, that the faith that saves is the faith that acts, that the rich who exploit the poor stand under the same judgment Amos pronounced, that wage theft cries out to God now as it did in the days of the prophets. There is no gap between the justice of the prophets and the gospel of Jesus. James, the bridge between them, the brother of the Lord and the pillar of the early church, makes the continuity unmistakable. The God of the Exodus is the God of the church. The concern for the poor that ran through the law and the prophets runs through the New Testament. And a Christianity that has privatized the gospel and abandoned justice has not advanced beyond the Old Testament. It has fallen below it, below even the letter of James, below the plain words of the brother of its own Lord.

I have to reckon with why the comfortable church has been so uncomfortable with James, why Luther wanted it out of the canon, why we have spent so much energy explaining away its insistence that faith without works is dead, and the answer is the answer this whole book keeps arriving at.

James will not let us be comfortable. James will not let faith be a private matter of belief that leaves our treatment of the poor untouched. James drags the gospel out of the realm of pure interior belief and plants it in the field where the worker's wages are being withheld and the poor man in shabby clothes is being dishonored and the brother lacking daily food is being told go in peace, be warmed and filled, by people who do nothing for his body. And we do not want the gospel there, in that field, making those demands, because in that field the gospel costs us something, costs us our favoritism toward the rich and our indifference toward the poor and our comfortable belief that what we privately think about Jesus is the whole of what he asks. James says it is not. James says pure religion is care for the orphan and the widow, that faith without works is dead, that the wages of the exploited cry out to God. And James, of all people, would know what his brother actually taught, would know whether the gospel was a private matter of interior belief or a faith that acts in the world for the poor, and James, the brother of the Lord, comes down with the full weight of the prophetic tradition on the side of a faith that does justice, and against the comfortable, privatized, work-less faith that the church has so often preferred.

So let James stand as the New Testament's own witness against the privatized gospel, the brother of Jesus testifying that the religion God accepts is the religion that does justice and mercy for the poor. Let his question hang in the air over every comfortable church: if a brother or sister is poorly clothed and lacking daily food, and you say to them go in peace, be warmed and filled, without giving them what they need, what good is that. What good is our faith, our worship, our theology, our correct beliefs, if they leave the poor exactly

as poor and the exploited exactly as exploited and the orphan and the widow exactly as forgotten. What good is that. James asks it, and he asks it as the one human being who knew Jesus from childhood, who has the most right of anyone to tell us what his brother actually meant, and his answer is the answer of the prophets and the answer of this book. Faith without works is dead. Pure religion cares for the widow and the orphan. The wages of the exploited cry out to God. And a church that has forgotten all of this has forgotten not only the prophets but the plain word of the brother of its own Lord, and stands under the judgment that James, weeping and howling on behalf of the exploited, pronounced on the comfortable and the rich who would not hear.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX

The Kingdom of God Is a Just Society

WHEN JESUS ANNOUNCED HIS message, the headline was not how to get to heaven when you die. The headline was the kingdom of God, or as Matthew puts it, the kingdom of heaven, the reign of God breaking into the world, and we have so thoroughly misunderstood this phrase that we have turned the central announcement of Jesus into something he never said. We hear kingdom of heaven and we think of the place we go when we die, heaven as a destination, the afterlife, the realm beyond this world. But that is not what the phrase meant on Jesus' lips or in the ears of his hearers. The kingdom of God meant the reign of God, the rule of God, the actual exercise of God's sovereign authority over the actual world, the coming of the day when God's will would be done on earth as it is in heaven. It was not first about a place we go. It was about a reign that comes, the inbreaking of God's just rule into a world that had been ruled by other powers, the powers of empire and money and violence and death, the powers that crush the poor and exalt the proud. When Jesus

announced the kingdom, he was announcing a revolution in the deepest sense, the arrival of a new and just order under the rule of God, and he taught his disciples to pray for exactly this, your kingdom come, your will be done, on earth as it is in heaven.

And what does the kingdom of God look like, this reign that Jesus announced and embodied and inaugurated. It looks like the great reversal he proclaimed everywhere he went, the lifting up of the lowly and the casting down of the proud, the filling of the hungry and the sending away of the rich, the first becoming last and the last becoming first. His mother sang it before he was born, in the song we call the Magnificat, and it is one of the most revolutionary texts in all of Scripture, this young peasant woman singing that God has scattered the proud, brought down the mighty from their thrones, exalted those of humble estate, filled the hungry with good things, and sent the rich away empty. That is the kingdom Jesus came to bring, the kingdom his mother sang over his unborn body, a kingdom of reversal where the established order of the world, the order in which the mighty sit on thrones and the rich are filled and the humble are crushed, is turned upside down, the thrones emptied, the rich sent away, the hungry filled, the humble lifted up. The kingdom of God is a just society, the society where God's will is done, where the arrangements of injustice are overturned and the shalom of God's reign is established, and Jesus did not come merely to teach about this kingdom or point to it in the future. He came to inaugurate it, to begin it, to plant it in the world like a seed that would grow.

The kingdom Jesus announced was not first a place we go when we die. It was the reign of God breaking into the world, the great reversal, a just society where the proud are brought down and the hungry are filled.

THIS IS WHY THE church is meant to be a foretaste of the kingdom, a sign and a sample of the just society that God's reign brings, a community that lives now, in anticipation, by the rules of the kingdom that is coming. The church is not merely a collection of individuals who have secured their private salvation and are waiting to die and go to heaven. The church is meant to be an outpost of the kingdom, a colony of heaven on earth, a community that demonstrates, in its common life, what the world looks like when God reigns, where the divisions of the world are overcome, where the poor are honored and the rich hold their wealth loosely, where the hungry are filled and the lowly are lifted up, where the just society that the kingdom brings is visible, in part and in anticipation, in the actual life of an actual community. This is what the early church in Acts was, when there was not a needy person among them, a foretaste of the kingdom, a sign of the just society, a community living now by the rules of the world that is coming. And when the church fails to be this, when it becomes merely a religious club for the comfortable, a Sunday gathering that leaves the world's injustice entirely undisturbed, it has failed to be what it was called to be, a

foretaste of the kingdom, a sign that another world is possible because another King reigns.

The relationship between the kingdom that is here and the kingdom that is coming is the key to holding all of this together, and the church has consistently fallen off one side or the other. The kingdom is already here, inaugurated by Jesus, breaking into the world, present wherever God's reign is acknowledged and his will is done, and so we are called to work for justice now, to live now by the rules of the kingdom, to be a foretaste now of the just society that God's reign brings. But the kingdom is also not yet here in its fullness, not yet consummated, not yet fully established, and will not be until Christ returns and makes all things new, and so we cannot bring the kingdom by our own efforts, cannot build the just society through our own programs, cannot mistake our partial and imperfect work for the full arrival of God's reign. The error on one side is to give up on justice now, to say the kingdom is entirely future, heaven is the destination, and the present world is a write-off we simply endure until we die and escape it, the error of the privatized gospel that abandons the world to its injustice. The error on the other side is to imagine we can build the kingdom ourselves, that our political programs and social movements can establish the just society through human effort, the error of the secular utopian who forgets that the kingdom comes from God and not from us and that every human attempt to build heaven on earth, when it forgets this, builds a hell instead. The truth is held in the tension, the already and the not yet, the kingdom that is here calling us to work for justice now, and the kingdom that is coming reminding us that the final justice is God's gift and not our achievement.

I think the church in my tradition has fallen mostly off the first side, the side that says the kingdom is entirely future and the present world is a write-off, and this is the theological root of so much of what this book has been confessing. If the kingdom is only future, only the place we go when we die, then justice now does not matter, the world's injustice is just the backdrop we endure until we escape, and the only thing that matters is securing our private ticket to the future heaven. This is the theology that lets the church privatize the gospel and abandon justice, the theology that reads the kingdom as a destination rather than a reign, that has no category for the church as a foretaste of the just society, that sees the present world as a sinking ship from which we rescue souls rather than a creation God is restoring and a reign God is establishing. And it is wrong, theologically wrong, a misreading of the central announcement of Jesus, who did not come to offer escape tickets to a future heaven but to inaugurate the reign of God on earth, to begin the great reversal, to plant the kingdom like a seed, and to call a community into being that would live now by the rules of the world that is coming and be, in its common life, a sign and a foretaste of the just society of God's reign.

So we have to recover the kingdom as Jesus announced it, the reign of God breaking into the world, the great reversal, the just society where the proud are brought down and the hungry filled, and we have to recover the church as a foretaste of that kingdom, a community that lives now by the rules of the world that is coming. This does not mean we can build the kingdom ourselves, and the warning against utopian self-confidence stands. But it does mean that justice now matters, that the present world is not a write-off but a creation God is restoring, that the church is called to be a sign

of the just society and not merely a waiting room for the saved, that we pray your kingdom come, your will be done, on earth as it is in heaven, and that we then live as if we meant it, as if the kingdom we pray for is the kingdom we are called to embody, in part and in anticipation, now, in the actual life of the actual church, as a foretaste of the world that is coming when the King returns and the great reversal is complete and the just society of God's reign is established forever, the proud brought low, the hungry filled, the lowly lifted up, every tear wiped away, every wrong set right, the shalom of creation finally and fully restored.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN

The Idol of Respectability

THERE IS AN IDOL the church serves so faithfully that we have never even named it as an idol, and it has done more to keep us silent on justice than any open hostility ever could. It is the idol of respectability, the deep and abiding need to be seen as reasonable, moderate, balanced, acceptable to the powerful and the comfortable, the need to keep our standing, our reputation, our place at the table. This idol does not announce itself. It works quietly, in the back of the mind, in the calculation that precedes the sermon, in the instinct to soften the hard word, to add the qualification, to make sure no one is too offended and no one important is too upset and the church's reputation as a sensible, balanced, respectable institution remains intact. And in the name of respectability, in the name of not being too political, not being too radical, not rocking the boat, the church has kept silent on injustice after injustice, has counseled patience to the suffering, has urged moderation to the oppressed, has protected its own standing at the cost of its prophetic voice, and has called all of

this wisdom.

Martin Luther King Jr. named this idol with devastating precision in his letter from the Birmingham jail in April of 1963, though he did not call it respectability, he called it the white moderate. He wrote that he had almost reached the regrettable conclusion that the great stumbling block in the stride toward freedom was not the white citizens' council or the Ku Klux Klan, not the open and violent enemies of justice, but the white moderate who was more devoted to order than to justice, who preferred a negative peace which is the absence of tension to a positive peace which is the presence of justice, who constantly said he agreed with the goal but could not agree with the methods, who paternalistically believed he could set the timetable for another man's freedom, who lived by a mythical concept of time and counseled the oppressed to wait for a more convenient season. King's deepest frustration was not with the open enemies of justice. It was with the respectable, the moderate, the reasonable, the people who agreed in principle and opposed in practice, who valued their own comfort and order and standing above the justice they claimed to support. That was the idol of respectability, and King saw that it was a greater obstacle to justice than open hatred, because open hatred at least declared itself, while respectable moderation cloaked its complicity in the language of wisdom and balance and patience.

*The idol of respectability has silenced
the church more effectively than any
open enemy. It does not forbid us to
speak. It only whispers that this is not
the time, that we must be balanced,
that our reputation is worth more
than the truth.*

I SERVE THIS IDOL, and I have to name my service of it plainly, because the whole power of this idol lies in its ability to disguise itself as virtue. When I have softened a hard word from the pulpit, added the qualification that took the edge off, made sure to balance every challenge with a reassurance, avoided the subject that would have upset the wrong people, I have told myself I was being wise, pastoral, balanced, careful not to be unnecessarily divisive, careful to keep the church together, careful to maintain our witness in the community. And some of that care is genuinely wise, because there is a real prudence in ministry and not every hard word needs to be said in every moment. But underneath the prudence, more often than I want to admit, was the idol, the need to be respectable, the fear of losing my standing, the calculation that protected my reputation and the church's reputation at the cost of the prophetic word that needed to be spoken. I have counseled patience to people who had waited long enough. I have urged moderation in the face of injustice that called for fury. I have valued the absence of tension over the

presence of justice, the negative peace over the positive peace, exactly as King described, and I have called it wisdom, and it was, too often, the idol of respectability wearing the mask of pastoral care.

The prophets had no respectability, and that is precisely what made them prophets. Amos was a foreigner from the south who came to the northern kingdom and disturbed the peace of the king's sanctuary and was told to go home and stop causing trouble. Jeremiah was so unrespectable, so persistently offensive to the powers of his day, that he was beaten and imprisoned and thrown into a cistern and regarded as a traitor to his own nation. John the Baptist was so unrespectable that he lived in the wilderness and ate locusts and called the religious leaders a brood of vipers and was eventually beheaded for telling a king he could not have his brother's wife. And Jesus himself was the least respectable of all, a man who ate with tax collectors and sinners, who touched lepers and let a prostitute wash his feet, who overturned the tables in the temple and called the most respectable religious leaders of his day whitewashed tombs, full of dead men's bones, who was finally executed as a criminal between two thieves, utterly stripped of every shred of respectability, dying the most shameful death his society could devise. The prophetic tradition is fundamentally unrespectable, fundamentally willing to lose standing for the sake of truth, fundamentally indifferent to the approval of the powerful and the comfortable, and a church that has made an idol of respectability has made an idol of the very thing the prophets and Jesus were willing to sacrifice.

Bonhoeffer understood this idol and named the cost of refusing it, and he paid the cost with his life. In a Germany

where the respectable church, the official church, the church concerned with its standing and its institutional survival, made its peace with the regime and kept its silence and protected its reputation, Bonhoeffer broke with respectability, spoke the truth, joined the resistance, and was hanged at Flossenburg in April of 1945, weeks before the end of the war. He had written years earlier that when Christ calls a man, he bids him come and die, and he meant it literally, and he lived it literally, and the dying began with the death of respectability, the willingness to be regarded as a traitor, a troublemaker, an enemy of the state, an embarrassment to the respectable church that wanted only to survive. The idol of respectability is the idol that the confessing church had to smash in Nazi Germany, and the idol that the white moderate had to smash in the civil rights movement, and the idol that every church in every age has to smash if it is going to speak the prophetic word, because the prophetic word always costs you your respectability, always offends the powerful, always disturbs the peace, and a church that will not pay that price has already decided that its standing matters more than its truth.

So I have to ask myself, and I have to ask every comfortable pastor and every comfortable church, what we are protecting when we soften the word and counsel the patience and value the peace over the justice. We are protecting our respectability, our standing, our reputation, our place at the table, and we are calling it wisdom and prudence and pastoral care, and underneath the noble names it is an idol, and the idol has kept us silent on injustice after injustice across the whole history of the church. The price of the prophetic word is respectability, and we have not been willing to pay it, have clung to our standing and our

reputation and our acceptance by the powerful, and have let the injustice go unnamed rather than risk the loss of our comfortable place. King saw the idol and named it the white moderate. Bonhoeffer saw it and smashed it and was hanged. Jesus saw it and was crucified. And I serve it still, more often than I confess, because the idol is subtle and the cost of refusing it is real and the comfort of keeping my respectability is sweet. But the prophetic word cannot be spoken from inside the idol, and a church that wants to recover prophetic justice will have to do the thing the prophets and Jesus did, the thing the idol of respectability exists to prevent. It will have to be willing to lose its standing, its reputation, its acceptance, its respectable place, for the sake of the truth that respectability has kept it from speaking. There is no prophetic voice without the death of respectability, and there is no recovery of justice without the prophetic voice, and so the idol has to die, the idol I serve, the idol we serve, before the word we are afraid to speak can finally be spoken.

CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT

The Long Defeat and the Refusal to Despair

THERE IS A DANGER that I have not yet named, and it is the danger that threatens not the comfortable church that will not take up justice but the faithful remnant that does, and it is the danger of despair. Because when you finally see the scope of the injustice, when you stop averting your eyes and look directly at the structures that crush the poor and the systems that grind down the vulnerable and the sheer weight and persistence and entrenchment of the wrong, the temptation that comes is not comfort but despair, the crushing sense that the injustice is too vast, too deep, too permanent, that nothing you do will make any real difference, that the powers are too strong and the wrong too entrenched and the effort too small, that the river of injustice is too wide and too deep ever to be turned. This despair is, in its own way, as much a refusal of the prophetic vocation as the comfortable church's indifference, because both end in the same place, in doing nothing, the comfortable church doing nothing because it does not care and the despairing church doing nothing

because it has given up hope. And the prophets knew this temptation, and the Scriptures answer it, and we have to hear the answer or the very seeing that this book has tried to awaken will curdle into a paralysis that helps no one.

The answer is not a false optimism, not the cheap reassurance that everything is getting better and our efforts are obviously succeeding and the arc of history bends reliably toward justice if we just push hard enough. That optimism is not biblical, and it does not survive contact with the actual history of the world, which is full of injustices that were never set right, oppressions that endured for centuries, evils that won, victims who died without ever seeing the justice they cried out for. The prophets themselves mostly failed, in the worldly sense. Amos thundered and the northern kingdom fell anyway, destroyed by Assyria, the injustice he denounced never repented of. Jeremiah wept and warned and Jerusalem was destroyed anyway, the people carried into exile, his entire prophetic career a record of unheeded warning and unstoppable catastrophe. Isaiah called for justice and was, by tradition, executed for his trouble. The prophetic vocation is not a vocation of guaranteed success, of reliable victory, of efforts that obviously and visibly turn the tide. It is, more often, a vocation of faithful witness in the face of a wrong that does not yield, of speaking the truth that is not heeded, of working for a justice that does not come in your lifetime, of what one writer called the long defeat.

*We are not promised that we will win.
We are promised that the wrong will
not have the last word. The call is to
faithful witness in the long defeat,
sustained by a hope that does not
depend on seeing the victory.*

THE PHRASE THE LONG defeat comes from Tolkien, who wrote that he was a Christian and therefore did not expect history to be anything but a long defeat, though it contained, he said, some samples or glimpses of final victory. And there is deep biblical wisdom in that, the recognition that in this age, between the inauguration of the kingdom and its consummation, the people of God are largely engaged in a long defeat, a faithful witness against a wrong that mostly does not yield, sustained not by the expectation of worldly victory but by the hope of a final victory that is God's to give and not ours to achieve. This is not despair, and it is not optimism. It is hope, biblical hope, which is something altogether different from both. Despair says the wrong will win and nothing can be done. Optimism says the wrong is losing and we are obviously winning. Hope says the wrong will not have the last word, because God will have the last word, and the last word is the kingdom, the great reversal, the setting-right of every wrong, the wiping away of every tear, and this final victory is certain not because of our efforts but because of God's promise, and it frees us to work and witness faithfully now without the crushing burden of having to win,

because the winning was never ours to do.

This is the only ground on which the work of justice can be sustained over a lifetime, over generations, over the long haul, because any other ground collapses. If we work for justice on the ground of optimism, on the expectation that we will obviously succeed and visibly turn the tide, then the first serious defeat, the first immovable structure, the first generation of effort that changes little, will break us, and we will despair, and we will quit. Only the ground of hope, biblical hope, the hope that does not depend on seeing the victory, can sustain the work through the long defeat. The civil rights movement understood this, drew its endurance from exactly this hope, from the conviction that the moral arc of the universe bends toward justice not because of human progress but because of the God who holds the universe, that we may not get there with you, as King said the night before he died, but that we as a people will get to the promised land, a hope that did not depend on his own survival or his own success, a hope rooted in God and not in the visible prospects of the movement. That is the hope that sustains the long defeat, the hope that frees the worker for justice from the impossible burden of having to win, the hope that says do the work, witness to the truth, push back against the wrong, and leave the victory to God, who has promised it and will give it, in his time and not ours.

And there is a freedom in this that I did not expect when I first began to see the scope of the injustice and felt the despair rising. The freedom is the freedom from results, from the crushing need to see my own efforts succeed, from the burden of having to fix what is too big for me to fix. I am not called to win. I am called to be faithful. I am not called to turn

the river of injustice by my own strength, which I could never do, which would break me to attempt. I am called to do justice, love mercy, and walk humbly with my God, in my own place, in my own moment, with whatever power and opportunity I actually have, and to leave the outcome, the final outcome, the victory, to God. This frees me to work without despair when the work seems to accomplish little, because the value of the work was never in its visible success but in its faithfulness, its witness, its participation in the justice of God whether or not I live to see it prevail. And it frees me from the opposite temptation too, the temptation to take credit, to imagine that I am building the kingdom, that the justice depends on me, that I am the hero of the story, because the victory was never mine, the kingdom comes from God, and I am only a witness, a worker, a servant doing the small faithful thing in my own corner of the long defeat, sustained by a hope that does not need to see the end.

So to everyone this book has awakened to the scope of the injustice, and who feels, as I have felt, the despair rising at the sheer weight of it, I want to offer not optimism but hope. We are not promised that we will win. We are not promised that we will see the justice we work for. The prophets mostly did not. The saints mostly did not. The victims who cried out mostly died still crying. But we are promised that the wrong will not have the last word, that God will have the last word, that the kingdom will come and the great reversal will be complete and every wrong will be set right and every tear wiped away, and this promise, this hope, this certainty that is God's and not ours, frees us to work faithfully in the long defeat, to do justice without the burden of having to win, to witness to the truth whether or not it is heeded, to push back against the wrong whether or not it yields, and to leave the

victory where it has always belonged, in the hands of the God who heard the cry of slaves in Egypt and came down, and who hears the cry of the oppressed still, and who will not, in the end, let the oppression stand. We labor in the long defeat. But we labor in hope, because the defeat is not the end of the story, and the One who writes the end has already promised how it goes.

CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE

The Table, Where the Kingdom Is Practiced

IF YOU WANT TO know what a community actually believes about justice, do not listen to its statements. Watch its table. Watch who eats with whom, who is welcome and who is not, who sits at the center and who is pushed to the margins, where the lines are drawn around the meal, because the table is where a community's real convictions about human worth and belonging are enacted, and the table has always been, in the biblical tradition, one of the primary places where the kingdom of God is either practiced or betrayed. Jesus understood this with total clarity, and so much of his ministry happened at tables, and so much of the offense he caused was table offense, the scandal of who he ate with, because in his world, as in ours, the table was a boundary, a marker of belonging, a statement about who was clean and who was unclean, who was in and who was out, and Jesus spent his ministry crossing that boundary, eating with exactly the people the respectable would never eat with, and in doing so enacting a kingdom where the boundaries of the world were

overturned and the excluded were welcomed.

The charge against Jesus, repeated by his enemies, was that he was a friend of tax collectors and sinners, and the charge was a table charge, a complaint about who he ate with. Tax collectors were collaborators, traitors, the agents of the occupying empire who grew rich by extracting wealth from their own people, despised by everyone, the very embodiment of injustice and betrayal. Sinners were the unclean, the morally compromised, the people whose lives placed them outside the boundaries of the respectable religious community. And Jesus ate with them, deliberately, repeatedly, scandalously, sat at their tables and welcomed them to his, made the meal a place of welcome for exactly the people the religious world excluded, and when his enemies complained, he did not apologize or explain it away. He told them that he had come precisely for the sick and not the well, for the sinners and not the righteous, that the kingdom was a feast to which the wrong people were being invited, the poor and the crippled and the blind and the lame, the people dragged in from the highways and hedges, while the respectable who had been invited first refused to come. The table was where Jesus enacted the great reversal, where the kingdom of God became visible, where the boundaries of the world were crossed and the excluded were welcomed and the meal itself became a declaration that another order was breaking in, an order of welcome and not exclusion, of grace and not boundary, of the kingdom and not the world.

*Watch a community's table and you
will know what it believes about
justice. Jesus enacted the kingdom by
eating with the wrong people, and the
church betrays the kingdom every time
it draws around its meal the very lines
he crossed.*

AND THEN THERE IS the central meal of the church, the Lord's Supper, the table that stands at the heart of Christian worship, and this table too is meant to be a place where the kingdom is practiced and the world's divisions are overcome, and Paul was furious when it became instead a place where the divisions were reinforced. In the church at Corinth, the Lord's Supper had become an occasion of division, the wealthy eating their fill while the poor went hungry, the divisions of the world reproduced at the very table that was supposed to overcome them, and Paul writes that in doing this they were not really eating the Lord's Supper at all, that they were despising the church of God and humiliating those who had nothing, that they were eating and drinking judgment on themselves because they did not discern the body. The table that was meant to be the sign of the one body, where there is neither slave nor free, neither rich nor poor, neither Jew nor Greek, had become a place where the body was torn apart along exactly the lines the world drew, and Paul says this is not the Lord's Supper, this is its betrayal, this

is eating and drinking judgment, because the meal that proclaims the kingdom had been turned into a meal that reinforced the world. The table is never neutral. It either practices the kingdom or it betrays it, either crosses the world's boundaries or reinforces them, and Paul takes the betrayal of the table as seriously as any sin in the church, because the table is where the gospel is enacted or denied.

This has enormous implications for the church, because it means that the question of justice is not only a question of programs and advocacy and structural change, all of which matter, but also and first a question of the church's own common life, its own table, its own enactment of the kingdom in the actual community of the actual congregation. A church that advocates for justice in the world while its own table reproduces the divisions of the world, where the wealthy and the poor do not really eat together, where the racial and class and cultural lines of the society are quietly maintained inside the congregation, where the excluded of the world are also the excluded of the church, has betrayed the kingdom at the very point where it was supposed to practice it. The integrity of the church's witness for justice depends first on the justice of the church's own table, its own common life, its own enactment of the welcome and the reversal and the boundary-crossing that the kingdom brings. You cannot credibly call the world to a justice you do not practice at your own table, cannot proclaim a kingdom of welcome from a community of exclusion, cannot announce the great reversal from a congregation that quietly maintains all the divisions the reversal was meant to overcome. The table is the test of the church's own integrity, the place where its proclamation of the kingdom is either embodied or exposed as empty.

I think about my own church's table, and I have to confess that it has too often reproduced the divisions of the world rather than overcoming them, that the welcome we proclaim has been more limited in practice than in word, that the people who are excluded in our society have too often been excluded, in subtler ways, in our congregation as well. We are not as divided as Corinth, perhaps, but we are not the kingdom-practicing table that Jesus enacted either, the table where the wrong people are deliberately welcomed and the boundaries of the world are deliberately crossed and the meal becomes a sign of the great reversal. Our table has been more comfortable than that, more homogeneous, more a gathering of the similar than a crossing of the lines, and in being so it has betrayed, in its own quiet way, the kingdom it was meant to practice. The repentance this book calls for includes the table, includes the actual common life of the actual congregation, includes the hard work of making the church's own meal a real enactment of the welcome and the reversal that Jesus enacted, so that the justice we proclaim to the world is first practiced among ourselves, the kingdom we announce is first visible at our own table, and the gospel we preach is embodied in the company we keep when we eat.

So watch the table, your church's table and your own, because the table will tell you the truth that the statements conceal. Watch who is welcome and who is not, who sits at the center and who at the margins, where the lines are drawn and who is on the wrong side of them, and ask whether the table practices the kingdom Jesus enacted or betrays it, whether it crosses the boundaries of the world or reinforces them, whether it is the feast to which the wrong people are invited or the comfortable gathering of the similar that the world would entirely approve. The kingdom is practiced at the table

or it is not practiced at all, because the table is where the abstract becomes concrete, where the proclamation becomes embodiment, where the welcome we preach becomes the welcome we live or stands exposed as words. Jesus ate with the wrong people, and it got him killed, and the church that follows him will have a table that looks like his, a table of scandalous welcome, of crossed boundaries, of the great reversal made visible in the simple act of who is welcomed to eat. And until our table looks like his, all our talk of justice is just talk, because the place where the kingdom is practiced is the place where we eat, and the truth about what we believe is written not in our statements but in the company we keep at the meal.

CHAPTER THIRTY

Fatherlessness, and Why I Cannot Read These Texts From a Distance

I HAVE TO WRITE a chapter that is more personal than the rest, because there is a reason the texts about the fatherless cut me the way they do, a reason I cannot read them from the safe distance of the scholar or the comfortable distance of the pastor with a stable home. I was raised without a father. I know what the orphan of the biblical text knows, not the full weight of it, because I had a mother and I was not destitute, but enough of it, enough of the absence, the missing defender, the hole where the father should have been, to read these texts from inside rather than from outside. When the Scripture says that God is a father to the fatherless, a defender of those who have no one to defend them, I do not read that as an abstract attribute of God. I read it as the thing I needed, the thing I cried out for without knowing I was

crying out, the defender I did not have and the God who claimed to be exactly that for exactly people like me. The biblical concern for the fatherless is not, for me, a category in an ethical argument. It is autobiography. And I think that matters for how I read the whole of this, because the prophets wrote from inside the affliction they named, and the comfortable church reads from outside it, and the distance changes everything.

Here is what fatherlessness teaches you, and it is the thing the comfortable church most needs to learn and is least able to learn from its comfort. It teaches you that the world is not a level playing field, that some people start without things that other people take entirely for granted, that the absence at the beginning shapes everything that comes after in ways the people who never knew the absence cannot see. The child with a father and the child without one do not start in the same place, and they do not run the same race, and to tell the fatherless child that he simply needs to work hard and make good choices, as though the father's absence were not a structural fact that shaped his entire field of possibility, is to speak from a comfort that has never known the lack. I learned this in my own body, the way the absence of a father is not just an emotional wound but a structural disadvantage, a missing source of protection and guidance and provision and connection, a hole that the child has to work around his whole life while the children with fathers never even see the advantage they were given. And this is exactly what the comfortable church cannot see about poverty and injustice more broadly, that the people at the bottom are not simply there because of their choices but because of structural absences, missing things that the comfortable were given and never noticed, disadvantages built into the starting position

that no amount of individual effort fully overcomes.

*I read the texts about the fatherless
from inside, not from a distance, and
that is the difference between the
prophet and the comfortable. The
prophet writes from inside the
affliction. The comfortable read it as
someone else's problem.*

THIS IS WHY I have such impatience with the comfortable church's favorite explanation for poverty, which is that the poor are poor because of their choices, their failures, their lack of effort or virtue or responsibility. I have impatience with it not because personal responsibility is unreal, because it is real, and choices matter, and the Bible takes individual responsibility with complete seriousness. I have impatience with it because it is spoken almost always from the comfort of people who never knew the structural absences, who were given fathers and stability and safety and connection and opportunity and never noticed the gift, and who then look at people who were given none of those things and explain their condition entirely by their choices, as though the starting position were level, as though the field were fair, as though the absence at the beginning counted for nothing. It is the explanation of people who have never read these texts from inside, who have never known the lack, who speak from a

comfort that is itself the product of advantages they cannot see because they have never been without them. And it is precisely the explanation the prophets and the law refuse, because the law does not tell the fatherless child to work harder. The law commands the community to be the father he does not have, to defend him, to protect his inheritance, to see his structural disadvantage and act to overcome it, because the God of the law is a father to the fatherless and demands that his people be the same.

There is a grace in my own story that I have to name, because it is the reason I am writing this book at all and not still the angry atheist I once was, raging at injustice with no ground to stand on. The grace is that the God who claims to be a father to the fatherless became, in fact, exactly that for me, that the absence I knew was filled, not by a human father returning, but by the God who came down, who heard the cry of the slaves in Egypt and heard, I have to believe, the unspoken cry of a fatherless boy who did not yet know his name. I came to faith as a grown man, from atheism, and one of the things that broke through the unbelief was exactly this, the discovery of a God who specifically, repeatedly, insistently claimed the fatherless as his own, who made the defense of the fatherless one of the central tests of true religion, who was not indifferent to the absence I had known but had bound himself to it, made it his particular concern, claimed it as the very place where he most reliably shows up. The God of the fatherless found the fatherless boy. And that is not an abstract theological proposition for me. It is the center of my life, the reason I believe at all, the experience that turned the atheist into the pastor, and it is why I cannot read these texts from a distance, because they are the texts that found me.

And so I have to say to the comfortable church, gently but without retreating, that you cannot read these texts the way I read them, and that your inability to read them from inside is itself part of the problem this book is about. The prophets wrote from inside the affliction, from the position of those who knew the lack, who had felt the absence, who cried out from the bottom of the pit. The comfortable church reads from outside, from the position of those who were given the advantages and never noticed them, who have never known the structural absence, who explain the condition of the afflicted from the safety of a comfort they mistake for virtue. This is not a small difference. It is the difference between the prophet and the priest who passed by on the other side, between the God who came down and the comfortable who stayed up, between reading the texts as the cry of your own heart and reading them as someone else's problem to be managed at a distance. I do not say this to claim a special authority, because my own affliction was partial and many have known far worse, and I have my own comforts now that distance me from sufferings I have never known. I say it because the recovery of prophetic justice requires the recovery of the prophet's position, the willingness to read from inside the affliction rather than outside it, to see the structural absences rather than explaining them away, to be the father to the fatherless that the law commands rather than the comfortable observer who tells the fatherless to try harder.

So this chapter is the most personal in the book, and I have included it because I do not think you can understand the rest of it without understanding why these texts have the grip on me that they do. I was raised without a father, and I read the texts about the fatherless from inside, and the God

who claims the fatherless found me and made me his own and turned the atheist into a pastor, and all of that is why I cannot treat biblical justice as an abstract argument or a political position or someone else's concern. It is autobiography. It is the cry of my own heart answered by the God who hears the cry of the fatherless. And the deepest thing I want for the comfortable church, the church I serve and the church I am part of, is that it would learn, somehow, to read these texts from inside rather than outside, to know the lack rather than explaining it away, to see the structural absences that the comfortable never notice, and to become, for the fatherless and the widow and the stranger and the poor, the defender that God is and commands his people to be. The God of the fatherless found me. He is a father to the fatherless still. And the church that knows this God will not read his texts from a distance, because the God who came down does not stay up, and neither can the people who have truly met him.

CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE

The Sin of Silence

THERE IS A SIN that the church almost never confesses, because it does not feel like a sin, because it involves no action, no obvious transgression, nothing you did. It is the sin of silence, the sin of saying nothing, of standing by, of not speaking when the word needed to be spoken, and it is one of the most serious sins in the prophetic tradition precisely because it disguises itself as innocence. We confess the sins we commit, the things we do, the active transgressions, and we have whole theologies and practices built around them. But the sin of silence, the sin of omission, the failure to speak and act when speaking and acting was required, this we rarely name as sin at all, because it feels like neutrality, like prudence, like staying out of things that are not our business, and the great danger is that the church has committed this sin on the largest possible scale, has stood silent before injustice after injustice, and has felt innocent the whole time, because silence does not feel like sin.

The prophets did not regard silence as innocence. Ezekiel was told by God that he was appointed a watchman for the house of Israel, and that if he saw the sword coming and did not blow the trumpet to warn the people, then the blood of

those who died would be required at his hand. If the watchman sees the danger and stays silent, the blood is on the watchman. The silence is not neutral. The silence is complicity, is participation in the death that the warning could have prevented, is a sin that God will require at the watchman's hand. This is a terrifying theology of silence, and it is the prophetic theology, the conviction that the one who sees the danger and does not speak is guilty of the danger, that silence in the face of injustice is not innocence but complicity, that the failure to warn is a kind of participation in the harm. The prophet is appointed a watchman, and the watchman who stays silent is judged not as a bystander but as an accomplice, because he saw and said nothing, and the blood is on his hands.

Silence in the face of injustice is not neutrality. It is a vote for the way things are. The watchman who sees the danger and does not blow the trumpet is judged with the blood on his hands.

THIS IS THE HARDEST teaching for the comfortable church to hear, because the comfortable church has built its entire relationship to injustice on the premise that silence is safe, that staying out of it is prudent, that not taking sides is the responsible and balanced position. But the prophets and the Scriptures will not allow it. There is no neutral position in the face of injustice, because silence itself is a position, silence

itself is a vote, silence itself takes the side of the powerful against the weak, because the powerful are perfectly content with silence, the powerful want nothing more than for the church to stay out of it, the powerful are served by exactly the neutrality the church mistakes for prudence. To say nothing when the poor are being crushed is to side with those who are crushing them, because the crushing continues undisturbed by your silence, because your silence removes the one voice that might have named the wrong, because the oppressor needs no help from you but is helped enormously by your refusal to oppose him. There is a phrase that captures this, that the only thing necessary for the triumph of evil is for good people to do nothing, and whatever its precise origin, it is profoundly biblical, profoundly prophetic, profoundly the theology of Ezekiel's watchman, because the doing nothing, the silence, the neutrality, is exactly what allows the evil to triumph, and the good people who do nothing are not innocent of the triumph they enabled by their silence.

I have committed the sin of silence more times than I can count, and I have felt innocent every single time, which is the most frightening thing about it. I have sat in rooms where injustice was being discussed or even enacted and said nothing, and walked out feeling that I had kept the peace, been prudent, avoided unnecessary conflict, stayed appropriately neutral, and the feeling of innocence was total, and it was a lie. I had seen the danger and not blown the trumpet. I had been the watchman who stayed silent, and the blood, in the prophetic accounting, was on my hands, and I felt nothing but the warm glow of having kept things calm. This is the terrible power of the sin of silence, that it feels like virtue, that it produces no guilt, that the watchman who fails to warn walks away feeling that he has done the responsible

thing, while the prophetic Scriptures pronounce him guilty of the blood he could have prevented. I have been that watchman. The church I serve has been that watchman, has stood silent before injustice after injustice and felt the warm glow of prudent neutrality, and the prophets stand over all of it and say the silence was not innocence, the silence was complicity, the blood is on the hands of the watchman who saw and said nothing.

Bonhoeffer wrote, in the midst of a Germany where the church's silence enabled an unspeakable evil, that silence in the face of evil is itself evil, that God will not hold us guiltless, that not to speak is to speak and not to act is to act. Not to speak is to speak. The silence itself is a statement, a loud statement, a statement that the injustice is acceptable, that the church has no word against it, that the powerful may proceed undisturbed. And not to act is to act, because the failure to act is itself a kind of action, the action of allowing, of permitting, of standing aside so that the wrong may continue. Bonhoeffer understood the sin of silence from inside the most extreme case, the case where the church's silence enabled genocide, and he broke the silence at the cost of his life, and his witness stands as the permanent refutation of the church's favorite excuse, that silence is prudence and neutrality is innocence. It is not. Not to speak is to speak. Not to act is to act. The silence is a vote, and it is a vote for the way things are, and the church that has voted with its silence again and again across the long history of injustice is not innocent of the injustices its silence permitted.

So the sin of silence has to be named and confessed, has to be recognized as the sin it is rather than the innocence it pretends to be, has to be repented of as fully as the sins we actively commit. The watchman who sees the danger and

does not warn is guilty of the blood. The good people who do nothing enable the triumph of evil. Not to speak is to speak, and not to act is to act, and the silence of the church before injustice is not neutrality but complicity, not prudence but participation, not innocence but a vote for the way things are. And the recovery of prophetic justice will require, above almost everything else, the breaking of the silence, the willingness of the church to be the watchman who blows the trumpet, who names the danger, who speaks the word the powerful do not want spoken, even at the cost of the respectability and the comfort and the peace that the silence has so long protected. There is no prophetic voice that is silent. The prophet, by definition, speaks. And a church that has made an idol of its silence, that has mistaken its complicity for innocence and its neutrality for virtue, will have to learn, painfully and at great cost, that the trumpet was given to be blown, that the watchman was appointed to warn, and that the blood of the silence is a debt the church has been accumulating for a very long time.

CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO

What We Owe, and the Refusal to Resolve It

I HAVE COME TO the end of the argument, and I am not going to resolve it, because the prophets did not resolve it and the resolution is not mine to give. I cannot end this book with a program, a plan, a tidy set of action steps that will make the demand of justice manageable and let you close the cover feeling that you now know what to do and have, in the knowing, somehow already done it. That would be a betrayal of everything I have tried to say, because the privatized gospel I have been indicting is precisely the gospel that resolves everything neatly, that gives you a clean application and a comfortable closing and lets you go home unchanged. The prophets never did that. They left the weight on you. They named the wrong and called for justice and left the people standing under the demand, unresolved, uncomfortable, carrying it out the door. And that is what I am going to do, because the alternative is to do to this book what the church has done to the Bible, to take the dangerous, unresolved, weight-leaving word of God and turn it into a comfortable

program that asks nothing and changes nothing and lets everyone go home the same.

So what do we owe, the church to its neighborhood, the comfortable to the crushed, those of us who have benefited from the absence of justice to those who have paid for it. We owe more than charity, more than the food drive and the benevolence program and the warm individual kindness that keeps us in control and costs us nothing structural. We owe justice, *mishpat*, the active setting-right of the wrong, the walk upstream to confront the structures, the willingness to ask who profits from the suffering and to name them even if they turn out to be us. We owe righteousness, *tsedaqah*, the daily ordering of our lives so that the people around us flourish, the loosening of our grip on what we have called ours, the recovery of the conviction that the corners of the field were never ours and the land is the Lord's and we are sojourners with no right to lock anyone out forever. We owe presence, the costly nearness that knows the actual neighborhood and the actual names and the actual wounds, the refusal to let the neighborhood be scenery and the poor be an abstraction. We owe the breaking of our silence, the blowing of the trumpet, the prophetic word the powerful do not want spoken, even at the cost of the respectability we have made into an idol. We owe the table, the kingdom practiced in our own common life, the welcome that crosses the boundaries of the world. We owe all of it, and we have paid almost none of it, and I do not have a program that will make the debt manageable, because the debt is not manageable. It is a debt that asks for everything, and the rich young ruler walked away from exactly that, and Jesus, in his terrible mercy, let him go.

*I will not resolve this for you, because
the prophets never resolved it. They
named the wrong, called for justice,
and left the weight on the people to
carry out the door. I am leaving it on
you. It is yours now.*

I WANT TO BE honest, at the very end, about where I actually am, because I have implicated myself throughout this book and I will not stop now. I do not write as a man who has arrived, who has done justice and now instructs you in it from the far side of his own obedience. I write as a man still mostly inside the failure I have been describing, a pastor of a comfortable church in a comfortable tradition, who has privatized the gospel and outsourced justice and chosen charity over the costly walk upstream, who has kept his respectability and his silence and his comfortable distance from the suffering at his own door, who knows the demand of these texts and has not yet paid it. This book is not a report from the summit. It is a confession from the foothills, the testimony of a man who has finally seen the mountain he has spent his whole ministry avoiding, and who is writing partly to talk himself into beginning the climb. I do not know whether I will make it. I do not know whether my church will. I do not know whether the comfortable church in this comfortable country has the courage to pay the debt it owes, to recover the prophetic justice it abandoned, to become the foretaste of the kingdom it was called to be. I know what is

owed. I am not yet sure we will pay it. And I am not going to pretend otherwise for the sake of a comfortable ending.

What I am sure of is the God at the center of all of it, the God who has not changed, the God of the Exodus who came down, the God of the gleaning law and the Jubilee, the God whose prophets thundered against worship divorced from justice, the God who stood up in Nazareth and read good news to the poor as his platform, the God who hears the cry of the oppressed and the wages of the exploited and the blood of the victim crying out from the ground, and who will not, in the end, let the oppression stand. That God is real, more real than the comfortable counterfeit the church has worshiped in his place, and that God is just, and that God is merciful, and that God has bound himself to the poor and the widow and the orphan and the stranger and the prisoner and the fatherless, and that God is calling the church back to the justice and the righteousness it abandoned, calling it not gently but with the full prophetic weight of Amos and Isaiah and Micah and the brother of his own Son, calling it to do justice, love mercy, and walk humbly, calling it to let justice roll down like waters and righteousness like an ever-flowing stream. The God is real and the call is real and the debt is real, and the only question, the question I am leaving you with because it is the question I am living with, is whether we will answer.

Amos said let justice roll down like waters. He said it to a prosperous, religious, worshiping people who could not understand why their God was so angry, a people who had full festivals and abundant sacrifices and beautiful music and a rotten city, a people whose worship God hated because their hands were full of blood. He said it twenty-seven centuries

ago, and the river he called for has still not rolled, not fully, not in this country, not in this church, not in this comfortable tradition that privatized the gospel and outsourced the justice and kept the worship and lost the righteousness. The river has not rolled. The widow is still at the gate. The wages of the worker still cry out. Lazarus still starves where we have arranged not to see him. The prisoner is still forgotten. The neighborhood is still scenery. And the God who came down is still calling, still thundering through the dead shepherd from Tekoa, still demanding the justice we have not done and the righteousness we have privatized away. Let justice roll down like waters. He is not asking whether it is convenient. He is not waiting for our program or our comfort or our respectable timing. He is saying roll down, like a river that takes out everything not anchored to something true.

I cannot make the river roll. Neither can you. But we can stop damming it. We can stop, each of us, in our own place, with our own power, in our own comfortable churches and our own forgotten neighborhoods, the long, patient, generations-old work of keeping the river from rolling, the silence and the charity-without-justice and the privatized gospel and the idol of respectability and the careful neutrality that is a vote for the way things are. We can stop damming the river. We can let it begin to roll. And we can leave the rest, the final rolling, the full flood, the justice that takes out everything false and leaves only what is true, to the God who promised it, the God who came down for slaves and hears the cry still and will not, in the end, let the oppression stand. That is what I have. It is not a program. It is not a resolution. It is a river that God has promised will roll, and a debt that we have not paid, and a call we have not answered, and a weight I am leaving on you because it has been left on me, and I do not

WHAT WE OWE, AND THE REFUSAL TO RESOLVE IT

know any honest way to set it down. Let justice roll down like waters. The rest is yours now. It always was.

CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE

The Land Cries Out, and Justice for the Creation

I HAVE WRITTEN ABOUT justice for the widow and the orphan and the stranger and the poor and the prisoner and the worker, and I have left out something the Scriptures will not let me leave out, because the justice of God in the Bible extends not only to human beings but to the creation itself, to the land, to the animals, to the whole created order that groans under the weight of human sin and waits for its redemption. We have privatized the gospel until it touches only the individual soul, and we have anthropocentrized it until it touches only human beings, and both narrowings are betrayals of the scope of biblical justice, because the God who made the world and called it good has bound himself not only to the human poor but to the whole creation, and the prophets and the law speak of a justice that includes the land, a shalom that embraces the creation, a redemption that will finally set right not only the broken relationships among

human beings but the broken relationship between humanity and the world we were given to keep.

The law of Moses already knew this, already wove the creation into the structure of justice. The Sabbath rest extended to the animals, so that the ox and the donkey rested along with the human household, the creation itself given a share in the rest that the Sabbath proclaimed. And there was a Sabbath for the land itself, the sabbatical year, in which the fields lay fallow and were not worked, in which the land rested, because the land too belonged to God and was not to be worked endlessly to exhaustion in the relentless extraction of every last yield. The land is mine, God said, and the land that is the Lord's is to be treated as the Lord's, with rest, with limit, with the recognition that it is not merely a resource to be exploited but a creation to be kept. And when the land was abused, when the sabbatical rest was ignored, the prophets understood that the land itself suffered, that the creation itself was wounded by human injustice, that the same sin that crushed the poor also exhausted the land, because injustice is anti-creation, a tearing of the fabric of shalom in every direction at once, against the human neighbor and against the created world together.

*The same sin that crushes the poor also
exhausts the land. Injustice tears the
fabric of creation in every direction at
once, and the redemption God
promises is the healing of all of it.*

THE PROPHETS SPEAK OF the land mourning, of the creation suffering under the weight of human wickedness. Hosea writes that because of the people's sin, the land mourns, and all who dwell in it languish, and even the beasts of the field and the birds of the heavens and the fish of the sea are taken away. The injustice of the people wounds the creation itself, the land mourns, the animals suffer, the whole created order languishes under the weight of human sin, because the sin that breaks the relationship with God and the neighbor also breaks the relationship with the creation, and the breaking spreads outward through the whole fabric of the world. This is the prophetic vision, that human injustice and the suffering of the creation are connected, that the same wickedness that oppresses the poor also exhausts and poisons and destroys the land, that you cannot finally separate justice for the human neighbor from justice for the created world, because both are part of the single shalom that God built into the creation and that human sin has shattered.

And the New Testament takes this up and lifts it to its full height, in the eighth chapter of Romans, where Paul writes that the whole creation has been groaning together in the pains of childbirth, subjected to futility, in bondage to decay, waiting with eager longing for the revealing of the children of God, for the day when the creation itself will be set free from its bondage and brought into the freedom of the glory of the children of God. The creation groans. The creation waits. The creation is in bondage and longs for liberation, and the redemption that God is working is not only the redemption of human souls but the redemption of the whole creation, the setting-free of the groaning world, the final shalom in which not only the human poor but the whole created order is brought into the freedom and the flourishing that was its

original design. The Bible does not end with souls escaping a doomed creation to a disembodied heaven. It ends with a new heaven and a new earth, the creation itself redeemed and renewed, the dwelling of God with humanity in a restored and healed and liberated world, every tear wiped away and the whole creation set free from its bondage to decay. The scope of redemption is the scope of creation. God is making all things new, and all things means all things, the whole groaning creation brought at last into the shalom it was made for and lost and has been longing for ever since.

This means that a church that cares about justice cannot finally be indifferent to the creation, cannot treat the exhaustion and poisoning and destruction of the created world as no concern of the gospel, cannot privatize the gospel into the rescue of souls from a world written off for destruction. The same prophetic concern that drives us toward the poor drives us toward the land, because the poor and the land suffer together, because the injustice that crushes the human neighbor also wounds the creation, because the shalom that God is restoring embraces the whole created order. I am not making a partisan environmental point, and I want to be as careful here as everywhere else in this book, because the creation can be made into an idol just as easily as justice can, and there are ideologies of the creation that worship the made thing rather than the Maker and that lose the human poor in their concern for the land. The biblical position is neither the indifference that treats the creation as a disposable resource nor the idolatry that worships the creation in place of God. It is the recognition that the creation is God's, that it is good, that it suffers under human sin along with the human poor, and that it is included in the redemption God is working, the final shalom in which

the whole creation is set free.

So the scope of biblical justice is wider than we have made it, wider even than the wide vision of human justice that this book has been arguing for, because it embraces the whole creation, the land that mourns and the animals that suffer and the groaning world that waits for its liberation. The God who made the world and called it good has not written it off, is not interested only in rescuing souls from a doomed creation, but is working the redemption of the whole created order, the new heaven and the new earth, the final shalom in which every relationship is set right, with God, with the neighbor, and with the creation itself. And the church that recovers prophetic justice will recover this scope as well, will refuse to privatize the gospel into the rescue of souls and refuse to anthropocentrize it into the concern for human beings alone, will hold the whole vision, the whole shalom, the whole creation groaning and waiting and longing for the redemption that God has promised and will bring, when he makes all things new, and the land no longer mourns, and the creation is set free, and the whole world is brought at last into the freedom and the flourishing and the shalom it was made for in the beginning when the morning stars sang together and God looked at all that he had made and called it very good.

CHAPTER THIRTY-FOUR

The Pastors, and the Network That Could Carry This

I HAVE TO WRITE a chapter to the pastors, because I am one, and because I founded a network of them, the Pastors Connection Network, thousands of pastors connected across this country and beyond, and because the whole argument of this book finally lands on the people who stand in the pulpits and shape what the church believes and does. The recovery of prophetic justice will not happen without the pastors, because the pastors are the ones who decide, week after week, what gets preached and what gets avoided, which texts get opened and which get skipped, whether the dangerous half of the gospel gets spoken or stays safely shelved. The privatized gospel I have been indicting did not come from nowhere. It came from pulpits, from pastors, from men like me who chose the safe word over the costly one, who privatized the gospel because the privatized gospel kept the church comfortable and the giving steady and the difficult

people from leaving. And the recovery, if it comes, will come the same way, from pulpits, from pastors, from men and women who finally choose the costly word over the safe one, who open the texts they have been skipping, who speak the prophetic word the powerful do not want spoken. The pastors hold the key, because the pastors hold the pulpit, and the pulpit shapes the church.

I know the pressures on the pastor, because I live inside them, and I want to name them honestly rather than pretend they do not exist. The pastor who takes up prophetic justice will pay a price, and the price is real and immediate and concrete. People will leave. Giving will drop. The difficult conversations will multiply, and the comfortable will be made uncomfortable, and some of them will take their comfort and their money to a church that will not disturb it. The pastor will be accused of going political, of abandoning the gospel, of being captured by the left or the right, of distraction from the true spiritual mission. The pastor's respectability will suffer, his standing in the community, his acceptance by the powerful, all the things the idol of respectability protects. And the pastor will be tempted, as I have been tempted a thousand times, to retreat, to soften, to privatize, to choose the safe word that keeps the church together over the costly word that might tear it apart, and to call the retreat wisdom and prudence and pastoral care. I know the pressures. I am not writing from a place that has transcended them. I am writing from inside them, as a pastor who has mostly surrendered to them, and who is trying, in this book, to talk himself and his fellow pastors into the costly faithfulness we have mostly avoided.

*The privatized gospel came from
pulpits, and the recovery will come
from pulpits or it will not come at all.
The pastors hold the key, because the
pastors hold the pulpit, and the pulpit
shapes the church.*

BUT HERE IS WHAT I want the pastors to see, and it is the reason I founded a network of us in the first place, the reason I believe the recovery is possible despite the pressures. We are not alone, and the pressures that feel overwhelming to the isolated pastor are bearable to a connected one, a pastor who is part of a community of pastors committed to the same costly faithfulness, who can encourage one another and bear one another's burdens and refuse to let any one of them be picked off in isolation. The reason the pressures work so effectively is that they work on isolated pastors, individuals standing alone in their pulpits facing the loss of their comfort and their standing and their church with no one beside them. But a network of pastors, thousands of them, connected and committed and supporting one another, is a different thing entirely, a movement rather than a collection of vulnerable individuals, a body that can hold what no single pastor can hold alone. This is the strategic possibility that I believe in, that the Pastors Connection Network and every network like it represents, the possibility that the pastors, connected, could carry the recovery of prophetic justice in a way that the pastors, isolated, never could, because the connection makes

the costly faithfulness bearable, distributes the weight, and turns the isolated and vulnerable individual into part of a movement that the pressures cannot so easily defeat.

I think of what the Black church accomplished, which I wrote about earlier, and I notice that it was never the work of isolated individuals but always the work of a connected community, a network of churches and pastors and believers who carried the prophetic tradition together, who sustained one another through the long defeat, who made the costly faithfulness bearable by bearing it together. The civil rights movement was a church movement, a network movement, pastors and congregations connected across a region and a nation, supporting one another, encouraging one another, refusing to let any one of them stand alone against the powers. The recovery of prophetic justice in the white church, if it comes, will have to come the same way, not through isolated heroic individuals but through connected communities of pastors and churches committed together to the costly faithfulness, bearing one another's burdens, sustaining one another through the pressures, turning the vulnerable individual into part of a movement. This is why the network matters, why connection matters, why the pastors cannot do this alone and were never meant to. The prophetic vocation is communal as well as individual, sustained by a body and not just borne by a hero, and the network is the body that could carry what no single pastor can carry alone.

So I am writing to the pastors, my fellow pastors, the thousands connected through the network and the countless others standing in their pulpits across this country, to say that the recovery of prophetic justice is in our hands, in the

pulpits we hold and the texts we choose and the words we speak or refuse to speak, and that the pressures that have kept us privatizing the gospel are real but not finally overwhelming, because we are not alone, because we can bear this together, because a connected community of pastors committed to the costly faithfulness can hold what no isolated individual can hold. The privatized gospel came from pulpits, and the recovery will come from pulpits, and the pulpits are ours, and the choice is ours, week after week, text after text, sermon after sermon, the choice between the safe word that keeps us comfortable and the costly word that might set the river rolling. I have mostly chosen the safe word. I am asking my fellow pastors to choose the costly one, and I am asking it knowing the price, and I am asking it as one who has not yet paid the price himself but is trying, in this book and in this network and in whatever ministry I have left, to begin. The pastors hold the key. We have mostly kept the door locked. And the recovery of prophetic justice waits on whether we, together, connected, bearing one another's burdens, will finally find the courage to open it.

CHAPTER THIRTY-FIVE

The Most Prophetic Thing the Church Can Do

I AM NEAR THE very end now, and I want to name the thing I have been circling for the whole book, the thing that is finally more important than any program or advocacy or structural change, the most prophetic thing the church can do, which is not to say something but to be something, not to advocate for a just world but to be a just community, a foretaste of the kingdom, a living demonstration that another way of life is actually possible because another King actually reigns. The most prophetic thing the church can do is to live differently, to be, in its own common life, the justice and righteousness it proclaims, so that the world looking at the church sees not a movement that talks about justice but a community that embodies it, not a lobby for a better world but a sample of the better world already breaking in. This is what the early church was, when there was not a needy person among them, and it was the most powerful witness imaginable, more

powerful than any sermon or program, the witness of a community that actually lived the kingdom it proclaimed, so that the watching world said, see how they love one another, and was drawn not by the church's arguments but by the church's life.

This is the witness the church has most thoroughly lost, because we have become a community indistinguishable from the world around us, sorted by the same divisions, captured by the same idols, organized by the same injustices, offering the world not an alternative but a religious version of what the world already is. The world looks at the church and sees its own divisions reproduced, its own class lines maintained, its own racial separations preserved, its own captivity to money and comfort and respectability mirrored back in religious dress, and it is not drawn, because there is nothing to be drawn to, nothing different, nothing that demonstrates that another way of life is possible. The church that wants to be prophetic has to recover the difference, the otherness, the visible demonstration that the kingdom is real because it is actually being lived, that justice is possible because it is actually being practiced, that the great reversal is real because the proud are actually being brought low and the lowly actually lifted up in the actual life of the actual community. The most prophetic thing is not to talk about the kingdom but to be a colony of it, an outpost, a foretaste, a community whose very existence is a witness that the world as it is is not the world as it has to be, because here, in this community, under this King, another world is already breaking in.

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THINK ABOUT WHAT THIS would actually look like, because the abstraction has to become concrete or it is just another comfortable idea. It would look like a community where the divisions of the world are actually overcome, where the rich and the poor actually share a common life, where the racial and class and cultural lines of the society are actually crossed, where the excluded of the world are actually welcomed and honored, where money is actually held loosely and the needs of the poor among them are actually met, where the table is actually a place of scandalous welcome and the common life is actually a demonstration of the great reversal. It would look like the early church in Acts, a community so different in its life together that it drew the watching world by the sheer fact of its difference, a community where the kingdom was not preached as a future hope but lived as a present reality, in part and in anticipation, as a foretaste of the world that is coming. And it would be the most powerful witness the church could offer, more powerful than any argument, because the world is not finally argued into the kingdom, it is drawn into it, drawn by the demonstration that the kingdom is real, that another way of

life actually works, that the love and the justice and the welcome the church proclaims are not just words but a life actually being lived.

This is why I keep returning to the church's own common life, its own table, its own internal justice, throughout this book, because I am convinced that the recovery of prophetic justice begins there, at home, in the actual community of the actual congregation, before it ever reaches the structures of the wider world. A church that proclaims justice to the world while reproducing the world's injustices in its own life is a hypocrisy that the world rightly despises. A church that embodies justice in its own common life, that actually lives the kingdom it proclaims, has a witness that the world cannot despise, because the witness is not words but life, not advocacy but embodiment, not a program but a community that demonstrates, by its very existence, that another world is possible. The most prophetic thing the church can do is to be that community, to live the difference, to be a colony of the kingdom in the midst of the world, and this is harder than any program and more costly than any advocacy, because it requires the transformation not of the world but of the church itself, the actual repentance of the actual community, the actual overcoming of the actual divisions, the actual living of the kingdom we have so long merely proclaimed.

And so the call of this book, finally, is not first a call to do something but a call to become something, not first a call to fix the world but a call to be the foretaste of the world that is coming, the just community, the colony of the kingdom, the living demonstration that another way is possible. The structures matter, and the advocacy matters, and the walk upstream to confront the systems matters, and I have argued

for all of it. But beneath all of it, more fundamental than all of it, is the call to be a community that actually lives the kingdom, because without that, all the advocacy is hypocrisy and all the structural critique is hollow, the church demanding of the world a justice it will not practice at home. The most prophetic thing the church can do is to live differently, to be the justice and the righteousness and the welcome and the reversal it proclaims, to be a foretaste of the kingdom so compelling that the watching world is drawn to the King whose reign it demonstrates. That is the witness the early church offered. That is the witness we have lost. And that is the witness we are called to recover, not by talking more about justice but by being, at last, the just community we were always meant to be, the colony of heaven, the foretaste of the kingdom, the living proof that the world as it is is not the world as it has to be, because another King reigns, and his reign is already, here and now, in the community that bears his name, breaking in.

CHAPTER THIRTY-SIX

Mammon, the Rival God We Will Not Name

JESUS NAMED ONLY ONE rival to God by name, only one competing deity that he warned could not coexist with the worship of the Father, and it was not sex and it was not power and it was not pride. It was money. You cannot serve God and mammon, he said, and the word mammon is not a neutral term for currency, it is a name, the name of a god, a power, a rival lord that claims the allegiance that belongs to God alone. Jesus personified money as a competing deity, a master that demands service, a god that will rule you if you let it, and he stated flatly that you cannot serve both, that the human heart cannot worship God and money at the same time, that one will be the true lord and the other will be subordinate, and that the great spiritual danger of every comfortable life is that money will be the true lord while God is given the religious lip service. This is the rival god the comfortable church will not name, because we are all, every one of us who has anything, in danger of serving it, and naming it would force us to ask whom we actually serve.

The reason this matters so much for a book about justice is that the injustices I have been describing throughout these chapters are, at their root, the work of mammon, the fruit of a society and a church that have given their true allegiance to money. The exploitation of the poor, the predatory lending, the housing turned into an instrument of extraction, the wages withheld from the worker, the wealth of the church alongside the poverty of the world, all of it is the work of mammon, the rival god, the master that demands the sacrifice of the human neighbor on the altar of accumulation. Injustice is not finally an abstract structural problem. It is idolatry, the worship of the wrong god, the service of mammon in place of the God who hears the cry of the poor. And this is why the church cannot finally do justice without confronting its own relationship to money, its own service of mammon, its own captivity to the rival god, because you cannot oppose the work of mammon in the world while serving mammon in your own heart, cannot confront the idolatry of the society while practicing the same idolatry in the church, cannot call the world to a justice that requires the dethroning of mammon while mammon sits enthroned in your own life.

Jesus named only one rival god, and it was money. The injustices we fight are the work of mammon, and we cannot fight them while we serve the same god in our own hearts.

THE COMFORTABLE CHURCH HAS made an elaborate peace with mammon, and the peace is so complete that we no longer even recognize it as a problem. We have spiritualized away every hard word Jesus spoke about money, made the camel pass easily through the needle, turned the rich young ruler into a special case, treated the constant biblical warning about wealth as somehow less binding than the warnings about other sins, and in doing so we have made our peace with the rival god, given him a permanent place in our hearts and our churches, and stopped even noticing that he is there. We worship God on Sunday and serve mammon the rest of the week, and we feel no contradiction, because we have so thoroughly domesticated Jesus' words that the rival god no longer seems like a rival at all but simply a neutral feature of ordinary life, the money we all need and use and accumulate without any sense that it might be a master demanding our service. But Jesus said it is a master, a god, a rival to the Father, and he said you cannot serve both, and the comfortable church's failure to feel the force of this is itself the proof that mammon has already won, that the rival god is already enthroned, that we are already serving the master we have stopped even recognizing as a master.

The recovery of prophetic justice, then, requires the dethroning of mammon, first in the church and then through the church in the world, the costly and painful work of breaking the rival god's hold on our hearts and our common life, of learning to hold money loosely rather than serving it, of recovering the conviction that the wealth we have is not finally ours but God's, given to be used for his purposes and especially for the poor he has bound himself to defend. This is not a call to despise money, which is its own error, nor to a guilt-driven hatred of all wealth, nor to the false asceticism

that treats poverty as automatically holy. It is a call to dethrone the rival god, to refuse him the worship and the service he demands, to put money back in its place as a tool to be used rather than a master to be served, and to use it, the wealth God has entrusted to us, for the justice and the mercy and the care of the poor that the God we actually serve actually commands. The dethroning of mammon is the spiritual heart of economic justice, because the structures of economic injustice are the external work of a god that must first be dethroned in the heart, and a church that has not dethroned mammon in its own life will never confront the work of mammon in the world.

So I have to ask the question Jesus asked, the question the comfortable church has spent two thousand years avoiding, and I have to ask it of myself first and most sharply. Whom do I serve. Not whom do I claim to serve, not whom do I worship on Sunday, but whom do I actually serve with my life, my decisions, my use of the wealth I have, my anxieties, my securities, my treasure. Where my treasure is, Jesus said, there my heart will be also, and the location of my treasure is the truest revelation of the god I actually serve, more honest than any creed I recite or any worship I offer. And if I am honest, if the comfortable church is honest, the treasure is mostly where the rival god wants it, accumulated, secured, held tight, serving our own comfort and security rather than the justice and the mercy and the care of the poor that the true God commands, and the heart is therefore where the treasure is, with mammon, the rival god we have stopped naming because naming him would force us to confront whom we actually serve. You cannot serve God and mammon. Jesus said it, and he meant it, and the whole question of justice finally comes down to it, because the injustices we

have traced are the work of mammon, and we cannot oppose them while we serve him, and the first and hardest work of prophetic justice is the dethroning of the rival god in our own hearts, the breaking of his hold on our own treasure, the costly recovery of a life that serves the God who hears the cry of the poor rather than the god who profits from their suffering.

CHAPTER THIRTY-SEVEN

Worship That God Can Bear

I BEGAN THIS BOOK with the prophets' fury at worship divorced from justice, and I have to return to worship near the end, because the recovery of prophetic justice is not finally about replacing worship with activism, about trading the sanctuary for the street, about leaving behind the singing and the prayer for the work of justice. That is a misreading that the secular movements make and that some weary Christians make too, the assumption that if worship has been corrupted into a cover for injustice, then worship itself must be the problem, and the answer is to abandon it for action. But the prophets never said abandon worship. They said let justice roll, and they said it precisely so that worship could be restored, could become again the thing it was meant to be, could become worship that God can actually bear rather than worship he hates. The goal of prophetic justice is not the end of worship but the healing of it, the reuniting of the two things that should never have been separated, the worship of God and the doing of justice, so that the song and the work flow

together as they were always meant to, the praise of God and the love of the neighbor joined in a single life that God can receive.

Remember what the prophets actually demanded. Amos did not say stop worshiping. He said let justice roll down like waters and righteousness like an ever-flowing stream, and the implication is that when the river of justice is flowing, the worship that God now hates will become worship that God receives, because the thing that made the worship hateful was its divorce from justice, and the healing of that divorce is the healing of the worship. Isaiah did not say stop bringing offerings forever. He said cease to do evil, learn to do good, seek justice, correct oppression, and then, he implied, the worship that has become an abomination can become acceptable again, because the abomination was never the worship itself but the worship offered by hands full of blood, and the washing of the hands is the restoration of the worship. The prophets were not anti-worship. They were against worship that had been torn loose from justice and turned into a cover for injustice, and their demand for justice was, at its heart, a demand for the restoration of worship, the reuniting of the praise and the work, the healing of the divorce that had made the worship hateful to God.

The prophets did not call for the end of worship but for its healing. Worship that God can bear is worship joined to justice, the song and the work flowing together as they were always meant to.

THIS MEANS THAT THE church recovering prophetic justice is not a church that worships less but a church that worships rightly, a church whose worship is reunited with justice so that the two flow together, the song and the work, the praise and the love of the neighbor, the sanctuary and the street. The worship of such a church is not diminished by its justice but completed by it, made whole, made acceptable, made into the thing it was always meant to be, the offering of a people whose hands are clean because they have done justice, whose songs God can bear because the river is flowing, whose praise rises without the stench of the exploitation it once covered. This is the worship the prophets were pointing toward, not the abandonment of worship but its restoration, the day when the people who let justice roll could finally lift their hands in worship that God receives with delight rather than turns away from in disgust. The reuniting of worship and justice is the goal, the healing of the divorce, the recovery of a worshipping life that is also a just life, so that the church's song and the church's work are not two things but one, the single offering of a people who love God and love the neighbor and have stopped pretending the two can be separated.

And there is a particular kind of worship the church most needs to recover, which I touched on when I wrote about the Psalms, the worship of lament, the song that holds injustice before God without denying it or being destroyed by it. The comfortable church has lost lament almost entirely, has kept only the upbeat and the triumphant, the worship of people who have never been crushed and do not want to be reminded that others have. But a church reunited with justice will recover lament, will learn again to sing from the bottom of the pit, to hold the world's injustice before God in songs of grief and longing and protest, to weep with those who weep

and cry out with those who cry out, to bring the rage and the grief of the oppressed into the presence of the God who hears. This is worship that God can bear, worship that does not paper over the world's suffering with relentless cheer but brings the suffering honestly before the God who came down, worship that joins the praise of God with the lament of the broken and the cry for justice, worship that is whole because it holds all of it, the praise and the grief, the celebration and the cry, the song of the redeemed and the lament of the still-suffering, before the God who is just and merciful and who will not, in the end, let the oppression stand.

So the recovery of prophetic justice does not lead away from worship but back to it, back to worship healed and restored and reunited with justice, worship that God can bear because the river is flowing, worship that holds the world's injustice honestly before the God who hears, worship that joins the praise of God with the love of the neighbor in a single offering of a single life. The church does not have to choose between worship and justice, was never meant to choose, and the prophets demanded justice precisely so that the choice would never have to be made, so that worship and justice could be reunited as they were always meant to be. Let justice roll down, the prophet said, and let the worship be healed, and let the church become a people whose song and whose work flow together, whose praise rises from clean hands, whose worship God receives with delight because it is the worship of a people who have done justice and loved mercy and walked humbly with their God. That is worship God can bear. That is the worship the prophets were pointing toward. And it waits, like the river, on whether we will finally do the justice that makes the worship whole.

CHAPTER THIRTY-EIGHT

Let It Roll

I HAVE WRITTEN A long book, and I have implicated myself in every chapter of it, and I have refused, deliberately, to resolve it, because the prophets did not resolve it and because the privatized gospel is precisely the gospel that resolves everything neatly and lets you go home unchanged. So I am not going to end with a program or a plan or a set of steps. I am going to end the way the prophets ended, with the weight left on you, with the demand still standing, with the river still waiting to roll. And I am going to end by returning to the man who gave this book its epigraph, the shepherd from Tekoa, the layman God sent to a prosperous and religious and self-satisfied kingdom to tell them that their God hated their worship because their hands were full of blood, and to demand of them the one thing they had not done, the thing the comfortable church still has not done, the thing that this entire book has been about. Let justice roll down like waters, and righteousness like an ever-flowing stream. Mishpat and tsedaqah. The two words we lost. The two words I have been trying, for fifty thousand words, to put back in your hands.

I do not know whether the church in this country will recover these words, will let the river roll, will pay the debt it

owes its neighborhood and its world. I have spent this book confessing that I am not sure I will, that my own ministry has mostly served the privatized gospel I am indicting, that I write from inside the failure and not from the far side of it. And I think that uncertainty is the honest place to end, because the alternative, the confident assurance that of course we will recover, that the river is already rolling, that everything is moving in the right direction, is exactly the false optimism that the prophets refused and that the actual history of the church does not support. The river has not rolled. Amos called for it twenty-seven centuries ago, and the river he called for has still not rolled, not fully, not in this comfortable tradition that kept the worship and lost the righteousness, that privatized the gospel and outsourced the justice and made its peace with mammon and the idol of respectability and the sin of silence. The widow is still at the gate. The wages still cry out. Lazarus still starves where we have arranged not to see him. The river has not rolled.

The river has not rolled, not fully, not yet. The widow is still at the gate, the wages still cry out, and the God who came down for slaves is still calling. The only question left is whether we will answer.

BUT THE GOD WHO called for the river is still real, and still just, and still merciful, and still calling, and that is the ground

of whatever hope this book contains. Not the hope that we are obviously succeeding, which we are not, but the hope that the wrong will not have the last word, because God will have the last word, and the last word is the kingdom, the great reversal, the setting-right of every wrong and the wiping-away of every tear and the full and final rolling of the river of justice that Amos saw from far off and we have still not seen up close. This hope does not depend on our success. It frees us from the burden of having to win. It calls us to faithful witness in the long defeat, to do justice and love mercy and walk humbly in our own place and our own moment with our own power, and to leave the final rolling of the river to the God who promised it, the God who heard the cry of slaves in Egypt and came down, the God who hears the cry of the oppressed still, the God who will not, in the end, let the oppression stand. We cannot make the river roll. But we can stop damming it. We can stop, each of us, the long patient generations-old work of keeping the river from rolling, the silence and the privatized gospel and the charity-without-justice and the idol of respectability and the service of mammon. We can stop damming the river. And we can let it begin, in our own lives and our own churches and our own neighborhoods, to roll.

This is the whole of it, finally, the thing I have been trying to say across thirty-seven chapters and fifty thousand words. The God of the Bible is a justice-God, a God who came down for slaves before he gave a single commandment, a God who wrote the gleaning law and the Jubilee and the Sabbath, whose prophets thundered against worship divorced from justice, who stood up in Nazareth and read good news to the poor as his platform, who hears the cry of the widow and the worker and the prisoner and the fatherless and the blood of

the victim crying out from the ground. And the church has lost this God, traded him for a comfortable counterfeit who shares all our blind spots and defends all the same people we already wanted to defend, privatized the gospel and outsourced the justice and kept the worship and lost the righteousness. The recovery of prophetic justice is the recovery of this God, the real one, the God who came down, and the recovery will cost us everything the counterfeit let us keep, our comfort and our respectability and our silence and our peace with mammon and our distance from the suffering at our own door. It will cost us, because justice always costs the people who benefited from its absence, and most of us reading this book have benefited from its absence more than we have ever admitted.

I am not going to soften it at the end. I am not going to give you the comfortable closing that lets you set the weight down. The weight is yours now, as it has been left on me, the weight of a demand I have not met and a debt I have not paid and a river I have helped to dam for the whole length of a ministry that mostly served the privatized gospel I am now, too late, indicting. I do not write as a man who has arrived. I write as a man who has finally seen the mountain he spent his whole ministry avoiding, and who is trying, in this last chapter, to talk himself into beginning the climb, and who does not know whether he will make it, and who is not going to pretend otherwise for the sake of a tidy ending. The demand stands. The debt is unpaid. The river has not rolled. And the God who came down for slaves is still calling, still thundering through a dead shepherd from Tekoa, still demanding the justice we have not done and the righteousness we have privatized away.

Let justice roll down like waters, and righteousness like an ever-flowing stream. He is not asking whether it is

convenient. He is not waiting for our program or our comfort or our respectable timing. He is saying roll down, like a river that takes out everything not anchored to something true. I cannot make it roll. Neither can you. But we can stop damming it. We can let it begin. And we can leave the rest, the full flood, the final rolling, the justice that takes out everything false and leaves only what is true, to the God who promised it and will not, in the end, let the oppression stand. That is what I have. It is not a program. It is not a resolution. It is a river that God has promised will roll, and a debt that we have not paid, and a call we have not answered, and a weight I am leaving on you because it has been left on me, and I do not know any honest way to set it down. The river is waiting. The God who came down is calling. And the only question, the question I am living with and now leaving with you, is whether we will finally stop damming the river, and let it roll. It always could have rolled. It is only us, only ever us, who have kept it back. Let it roll. The rest is yours now. It always was.